

NOT A POTATO

MADE OR NOT

ANDRIES J. GREYLING

Chapter 1 — Arrival at the Edge

The ferry from Ishigaki put us down at Kubura harbour with the wind coming off the East China Sea sideways, the way it does at the western edge of Japan, where the next thing out there is Taiwan and a great deal of water nobody owns. Mei felt the place before she saw it. That was always the order of things with her. The salt first, fine as a powder, settling on the lips. Then the diesel and the gull-stink and the dry rasp of the dock rope she put her hand to without meaning to — sisal, sun-cured, the fibres standing up under her palm like the nap on a cat's tongue.

She read the rope the way other people read a face. Coiled by the same person every morning, she'd have bet on it, same over-under, the wear all on one side.

"You're touching the harbour again," Tomas said behind her, hauling the pelican cases off the gangway one-handed. The fish-voice of the group, dry as a cracker. "We've been here ninety seconds. At least buy it dinner."

"It's load-bearing," Mei said. "The rope."

"So am I, and you don't pet me."

The LENS — we'd stopped using his name years ago, even he had — stood apart at the end of the concrete with the camera already up, already working, the long grey lens panning slow across the moored boats. He shot the fishermen mending net before he shot the sea. He always went for the people who didn't want to be shot. Old habit, bad places. Nobody told him to lower it. You learned not to.

And Jakobus was just — there. He had a way of being already arrived, the weathered fixer leaning on a bollard like he'd grown out of it, talking low to a man in a sun-bleached cap who turned out to own three of the boats. By the time the rest of us had our bags Jakobus had a truck coming and a name. He handed both to us and stepped back, the way he did. The road, never the lead.

The name was a dive shop two streets up from the water, a tin-roofed shed with air tanks racked outside like a church organ and a hand-painted board over the door. Sou Wes Diving. Inside it smelled of neoprene and old coffee and the particular mildew of wetsuits that never fully dry on an island where nothing ever fully dries.

Dr. Saki Tanaka did not get up when we came in.

She was at a steel table with a tide chart and a laptop and a mug that said something rude in Okinawan dialect, and she let us stand there in the doorway dripping the day's first rain off our jackets while she finished a sentence on the screen. Late forties, maybe. Diver's hands, scarred across the knuckles where coral and basalt had had their say over thirty years. She had the build of someone who'd spent more of her life horizontal in green water than vertical on land.

"You're the documentary people," she said, in English, not looking up. "From the boat. Aratake-san told me." A beat. "He thinks you're harmless."

"We're aiming higher than harmless," Tomas said.

"Don't." She did look up then, and the look went around all four of us in about a second and a half, and Mei felt herself get measured and shelved and was, despite everything, impressed. Saki's eyes stopped on the LENS's camera, on the way he held it angled down now, defensive, and softened by exactly nothing. "No filming in the shop. You can put that away or wait outside in the rain. I don't care which."

He put it away. That alone told me something.

She made us coffee anyway, which I learned later was not a thaw so much as a basic decency she'd have shown a stray dog, and over it she gave us the official story.

She gave it straight. That was the thing I didn't expect — that the

local who guarded the monument's dignity most fiercely would lay out the skeptics' case first, cleanly, without a thumb on the scale.

"The rock is sandstone," she said. "Yaeyama Group, Lower Miocene. Twenty million years old, the stone itself. Fine-grained, mudstone in bands." She tapped the table edge. "Sandstone like this fractures. It has bedding planes — flat, like a stack of paper — and it has vertical joints where the stress released. Earthquakes here, all the time. We sit on the edge of everything. You crack a layered rock along two sets of planes at right angles and you get—" she made a step with her two flat hands, one rising off the other —steps. Terraces. Corners. The sea takes the loose pieces. What's left looks built."

"And Schoch's right about all that," Mei said carefully. Robert Schoch. Boston University geologist, the most credentialed voice on the natural side, the one who'd dived it and come up shrugging — natural fracturing, bedding planes, marine erosion, and similar shapes on the islands above water where no one had ever been underwater to carve them.

"Schoch is not wrong about any of that," Saki said. "Every piece of it is true. There are formations on Yonaguni you can walk to, dry, on the cliffs, that look just as cut. I'll take you. You'll feel stupid for asking."

"And Kimura?" Tomas asked.

A flicker. Masaaki Kimura, University of the Ryukyus, the marine geologist who'd spent decades down there and come up the other way — a man-made structure, a platform, terraces and stairs and what he read as carvings, even inscriptions. Site maps. Photographs. A whole submerged ceremonial world. Not accepted by most of his field. Not retracted by him.

"Kimura is not a crank," Saki said, and there was a warning under it. "Whatever the internet does with him. He has dived that site more than any living person except me. He measured the right angles. He's not wrong that they're strange." She turned the mug a quarter-turn on the steel. "He's just — sure. Both of them are sure. That's the only thing they have in common and it's the only thing I don't trust about either of them."

Outside, the rain picked up and drummed the tin.

"So which is it," Tomas said. The fish, going for the soft spot. "Made,

or not?”

Saki Tanaka looked at him with something close to pity.

“You think I’ve spent thirty years not answering that because I’m being mysterious for tourists,” she said. “I’m not. I don’t know. That’s the answer. I don’t know, and I’m the one who’d know.”

The first descent wasn’t for two days — slack tide, weather, the queue of permissions — but she let us walk the harbour, and that evening Mei stood at the seawall and looked at the water that had the monument under it, somewhere off the southern point, five to twenty-five metres down, and tried to feel it the way she felt everything else. The rope. The tin roof. The grain of a thing that told you how it was made.

She couldn’t, of course. It was a kilometre out and under. But she’d been doing this long enough to know the trap she was already in, and she named it to herself the way you name a riptide before it takes you.

The eye wants the building. That was the whole problem with Yonaguni, in one sentence. The eye is a pattern engine that evolved to find the lion in the grass and the face in the rock, and it would rather see a staircase than a stack of fractured sandstone every single time, because a staircase means somebody, and somebody is the most interesting thing in the universe. You had to fight your own equipment.

She’d tried the potato test in her head a hundred times before they’d left. Go to a beach, any beach with sandstone, and try to make a right angle with a chisel and a mallet. Try to make a flat terrace forty metres long and clean. Try it underwater, holding your breath, fighting a current, with stone-age tools — because if it’s man-made it was made when this rock was last dry, two thousand years ago at the soonest, ten thousand at the most, depending whose sea-level number you trusted. You’d come up with a mess. You’d come up with a gouged, crumbling, lopsided thing. A potato. The sea, it turned out, was a far better mason than any man with a rock — it had ten million years and no hands to slip.

So the skeptics were right. That should have been the end of it.

“You’re doing the thing again,” Tomas said, appearing at her elbow with two cans of something cold and unidentifiable from a vending

machine that glowed alone on the dark street like a small shrine. "Standing very still and arguing with yourself."

"There's a hole," Mei said.

"There's always a hole. It's the show."

"No, listen." She took the can. "Schoch's right. Sandstone fractures into steps. Fine. But nobody — and I mean nobody, in forty years — has put another formation next to it. Not on the cliffs here, not anywhere underwater on Earth. Something this big, a hundred and fifty metres of terrace, this many clean angles, this regular, made by nothing but jointing and the sea." She drank. It was sweet corn flavour. She decided not to think about it. "And on the other side — Kimura's been down there longer than her, with cameras, for decades, and he can't put one tool mark on the table that survives peer review. Not one. Not a chisel scar anybody else will sign off on. No cultural layer. No pots, no bones, no hearth."

"So both sides came up empty."

"Both sides came up with the strongest case and the missing piece. Same gap." She tipped her head at the black water. "It's sitting right in the middle of two things that can't be true at once, and neither of them can close it."

Tomas was quiet for a second, which was rare enough to note.

"Don't say that on camera the way you just said it to me," he said. "You'll make people happy and we'll never sell the sequel."

We saw the survey team for the first time the next morning, and we heard them before that.

There's a sound a well-funded operation makes. Generators. New aluminium clinking on new aluminium. The chirp of survey gear being calibrated by people who've never had to fix it with a zip tie. They'd taken the long quay on the far side of the harbour, the deep-water side, and they had a vessel that made the local boats look like bath toys — multibeam sonar pod, a moonpool, a crane. The National Maritime Survey Unit, in tidy blue jackets with a tidy logo, and a logistics tent going up with the snap and pop of a circus that wasn't going to be any fun.

The recorder — call her Bea, our methodical one, sample bags and a waterproof notebook and a temper she kept in a Pelican case — clocked their permit board pinned to the tent. She read it twice and came back to us with her jaw set.

“They’ve got the site,” she said.

“We’ve got the site,” Tomas said. “We have the permission. Saki signed off on—”

“They’ve got the site,” Bea said again. “Read it. Document and archive. Six-week window. And there’s a line at the bottom, in Japanese and English both, very polite.” She breathed out through her nose. “Access to the monument to be coordinated through the survey to ensure safety of operations. They’re the gate now. Not Saki. Them.”

Across the harbour, a man in a blue jacket lowered a clipboard and looked over at us — at the LENS, really, at the camera up on his shoulder again, working, panning slow across the new vessel and the crane and the tidy logo. The man smiled. He had a good smile, a clean-handed smile, the smile of someone who has never once had to be the villain and isn’t going to start today. He raised a hand. A wave. Friendly.

Then he said something to the woman beside him, and she made a note, and the LENS’s lens caught the note being made, the small bureaucratic act of someone deciding a thing about you while smiling at you, and held on it half a second too long.

Behind us, in the doorway of Sou Wes Diving, Saki Tanaka came out with the rude mug still in her hand and looked across the water at the blue jackets and the crane and the moonpool. Her face didn’t move. That was the tell. With Saki the stillness was the weather report.

“They moved their start up,” she said, to no one, to the harbour. “It was eight weeks. Now it’s six.” She drank. “Somebody’s in a hurry to be finished knowing.”

She looked at us then — at Mei, last, longest, the way she did.

“You’ve got one slack tide before they close the water to read it,” she said. “Maybe two. After that the monument belongs to the people who already decided what it is.” A gull came down hard on the seawall

and she didn't flinch. "So. You still want to feel the stone?"

Out past the point, under a kilometre of moving green, the edge of the last step held its angle in the dark, and went on holding it, the way it had for somebody's two thousand years, or for nobody's ten million, and waited to be touched by the only one of us who might be able to tell the difference, and probably wouldn't.

Mei put her hand back on the harbour rope, over-under, the wear all on one side, and said yes.

Chapter 2 — The Official Story

The research tent smelled of brine and instant coffee, and Mara had her hand flat on the printout before she meant to.

It was a habit nobody had ever managed to train out of her — touching paper as if it could tell her something the ink wouldn't. The printout was a photograph of the Main Terrace, blown up to grain, and under her palm she felt only the cheap satin of the page. But her eye was doing the other thing, the thing it always did: running the edge in the picture, the long top of the terrace where stone met green water, looking for the place where the line broke.

It didn't break. That was the trouble. It just kept going.

"Kimura first," said Theo, who managed the samples and the spreadsheets and, when he could get away with it, the order in which everyone looked at things. He had laid the folders out in two stacks on the folding table, and he tapped the left one. "Because he's the reason any of us are here, and because it's polite to start with the man who's spent his life on it."

Masaaki Kimura. University of the Ryukyus. Forty years, give or take, of descending onto this thing and surfacing with the same conviction: that the sea was hiding architecture. The folder held his maps — careful, hand-corrected, the kind a man draws when he has been somewhere so many times he no longer needs the lines to be told to him. He had labelled features the way you'd label rooms in a house you grew up in. The stage. The steps. The road. The loop road. The face.

“He sees a city,” said Aoki, the dry one, from the cot where she’d folded herself with a can of something cold against her neck. “Or a temple. Or a quarry that became a temple. It depends which interview.”

“It depends which decade,” Theo said, not unkindly. “He’s revised. That’s what people are supposed to do.”

Mara turned the photograph so the light from the tent flap raked across it. Here was the thing about Kimura’s case, and she made herself say it to the room the way you’d say a thing you respected even if you weren’t sure of it: it was not stupid. People liked to act as if believing the monument was made required you to be the kind of person who buys crystals. It didn’t. Kimura was a marine geologist. He knew his sandstone. And he stood at the foot of those steps — broad, flat treads, one above another, the risers near enough vertical — and he said, *show me the natural process that stacks risers like that, here, at this scale, and nowhere does it leave the rubble it should.*

“That’s his strongest one,” she said. “The debris. If you fracture sandstone and the blocks fall, they fall *somewhere*. They pile at the base. He says the base is too clean.”

“He says,” Aoki agreed. “Currents.”

“Currents,” Mara said. “But you still have to show the currents carried it off and left the steps.”

The right-hand stack was thinner, because Robert Schoch wrote like a man who didn’t think the question was hard, and men who don’t think the question is hard write less. Boston University. Geologist. He had dived it too — that mattered, Theo kept insisting, he had actually been down there, this wasn’t an armchair takedown — and he had surfaced with the opposite certainty, delivered with the patience of someone explaining the obvious to a child who’d been allowed to stay up too late.

It’s bedding planes, Schoch said. The Yaeyama sandstone lies in flat sheets, parallel, laid down twenty-odd million years ago in the Lower Miocene, layer on layer like a stack of paper. And it’s cut by joints — vertical fractures, sets of them, running in directions that follow the rock’s own grain. Flat layers parted along the bedding. Vertical

breaks dropped along the joints. Where a flat plane meets a vertical break you get —

“A right angle,” Mara said, to the photograph. “You get a step.”

“You get a step for free,” Theo said. “That’s the whole sermon. Nature does the ninety degrees on its own, every day, for nothing, in any quarry on any island, and Schoch says go look — there are formations *above* the water on the islands right here that do the same trick and nobody calls them temples because you can walk up and see them being boring.”

So the sea built it, the rock came pre-scored, and the divers walked into a cathedral that’s actually just a very tidy collapse. Cool. Cool cool cool. Anybody want to ask the cathedral?

The fish — that was what they called the voice, Aoki’s voice mostly, the one that lived at the back of every conversation and refused to be solemn — had said it before Mara could stop the picture in her head: the two of them, Kimura and Schoch, standing on the same step in the same green light, looking at the same stone, and one seeing the hand of a people and the other seeing the patience of a fault. Both credentialed. Both wet. Neither lying.

That was the part the documentaries always smoothed over. They wanted a winner. There wasn’t one. The literature — the actual peer-reviewed, footnoted, careful literature — did not contain a sentence that closed the case. It contained a split. Two geologists, both real, both having done the work, and the field had not chosen between them, because the field could not.

“What do *you* feel,” Theo asked her, the way he asked when he wanted the texture and not the argument.

Mara looked at the photograph a while longer. “I feel like the page doesn’t know either.”

Saki Tanaka came in out of the heat with salt drying white on her forearms and looked at the two stacks of paper as if they were both slightly embarrassing.

She was Okinawan, a marine geologist herself, and she had been

diving this water since before Mara could swim, and she had the particular flatness of someone who has watched a great many people fly a great distance to be wrong about her sea. She picked up Kimura's map, glanced at it, set it down on the man-made side. She picked up Schoch's printout, glanced at it, set it down on the natural side. Then she moved them both two inches apart so they weren't touching, which Mara found she liked more than she could say.

"You've read the legends," Saki said. It wasn't a question. "Atlantis of Japan. The Pacific Mu. Sunken pyramid. Lost civilisation." She said the words the way you'd recite a tide table. "And you've read the men who exist only to say it's just rocks, who never get in the water, who put up a slide of a joint set and go home." She looked at them. "Both groups are selling something. Both think this is about them."

"And you," said Mara. "What are you selling."

"Nothing. That's why I'm poor." Saki almost smiled. "I'll tell you what I tell the boats. Kimura is a serious man who loves a place and has looked at it longer than anyone alive. That love is a tool and it is also a thumb on the scale, and he knows it, and he leans anyway. Schoch is right that this rock breaks square. He is also a tourist who came twice and is very sure." She tapped the table once. "The sandstone is real. The bedding is real. The joints are real. That much you can't argue with. The Lower Miocene doesn't care what you want."

"But," Aoki said from the cot.

Saki was quiet a moment. Outside, a generator coughed and steadied.

"But I have put my hand on the corner of the upper terrace at slack water," she said, "with no surge to lie to me, and I have run my glove along the riser, and it goes —" she drew her finger straight across the air, slow, level — "and it keeps going. Longer than a joint set has any right to. And I have looked for the rubble Kimura wants gone, and it is gone, and the currents *could* have taken it, currents take everything here. Could." She let the word sit. "I don't say more than the rock lets me. That's the whole job. People hate it."

Mara felt the texture of it then — not the stone, the *not-knowing*, the way it had weight. She had spent a life reading rooms because no one had ever let her stop, reading the difference between a smile

that meant it and a smile that was waiting for something, reading the worked edge from the broken edge with her fingers in the dark. The gift had never refused to answer before. It was refusing now, politely, the way Saki refused, and she understood she was going to have to put her hand on the actual stone to find out whether the gift would speak underwater at all.

“The potato,” Theo said suddenly, to himself.

“The what,” said Saki.

“Nothing. A thing we do.” He had the grace to look sheepish. “We try to make the thing. By hand. To see how hard the easy story is. If it’s man-made we should be able to get a chisel and cut a clean step. If it’s natural we should be able to find a stone above water doing the same trick.” He gestured weakly at the printouts. “Usually whatever we make comes out a mess. A potato. The world’s better at this than we are.”

Saki considered him for a long moment, and something in her face moved — not warmth exactly, but the first crack of it.

“You’re going to try to carve sandstone underwater,” she said.

“In a controlled spot, yes. Away from the monument.”

“With a chisel.”

“With whatever you’ll let us bring.”

She laughed — short, surprised, real. “You’ll make a potato,” she said. “I’ll bring the camera.”

The Lens hadn’t said anything in twenty minutes, which was how you knew he was working.

He was over by the tent wall with the back screen of his camera lit, going through the morning’s surface shots — the harbour, the boats, a fisherman’s hands coiling line — and his thumb was very still on the wheel, which meant he’d found one he couldn’t decide about. Mara drifted over without meaning to and looked.

It was a frame of the water above the monument. Nothing in it but green and the faintest suggestion of structure far down, more idea

than object, terraces ghosting up through twenty meters of light. You couldn't tell anything from it. You couldn't tell *made or not*. It was the most honest photograph she'd seen all day because it admitted it didn't know.

"It's beautiful," she said.

"That's the problem," said the Lens, and lowered the camera, and then a moment later raised it again, because lowering it was the thing he could not do, and they both pretended not to notice. He'd spent years pointing a lens at things that wanted to hurt him and learning to see the composition before the danger, and the habit didn't switch off because the danger here was only the sea. "When a thing's that beautiful you stop checking whether it's true. I don't trust how much I want it to be a city."

"That's the most useful thing anyone's said today," Mara told him, and meant it.

The turn came in through the tent flap wearing a clean polo shirt.

He was young, and pleasant, and his lanyard said NATIONAL MARITIME SURVEY UNIT in letters that had cost someone money, and he held a clipboard the way some people hold a faith. He introduced himself, apologised for interrupting, admired the printouts with the easy admiration of a man who has already decided they belong to him.

"We're so glad you made it out," he said. "Genuinely. The site deserves the attention. We're just — well, we're documenting and archiving, you know how it is, and I wanted to make sure your team had the schedule, so there are no surprises."

He set a single laminated page on the table, between Kimura and Schoch, on the two empty inches Saki had cleared.

It was a calendar. Most of it was crosshatched grey. *Survey operations — closed to third-party access*. The grey began in nine days and did not appear to end.

Mara found the white squares. There were three of them.

"You've got the next three slack-tide windows," the young man said

warmly. “After that we’ll need the water to ourselves while we do the photogrammetry. It’s nothing personal — it’s just hard to archive a site properly with other divers in the frame.” He smiled. “We’re trying to *preserve* it. Settle it, really. People have argued about this place for decades. Be nice to give them an answer, wouldn’t it?”

Nobody said anything for a second.

Then Saki picked up the laminated page, glanced at it, and set it down on neither stack — off the table, on the floor, by her boot, where she could see it.

“Three dives,” she said. To the crew, not to him. “And the sea decides which of those three it’ll actually give you.”

The young man was still smiling as he ducked back out into the heat, and the generator coughed, and Mara put her hand flat on the photograph of the long, straight, impossible top of the Main Terrace, and felt the cheap satin of the page, and nothing else, and wanted very badly to get wet.

Three windows to settle what nobody’s settled in forty years. And a man with a laminated calendar who thinks the ocean takes appointments. Bless him. Bless his little lanyard.

Outside, the tide was already turning.

Chapter 3 — First Descent

The water at slack tide goes still the way a held breath goes still — not calm, just paused, the whole muscular machine of the current waiting for permission to start again. Mara checked her gauge, checked the line, checked the gauge again. Forty bar more than she needed. She always carried more than she needed. You watch a room long enough, you learn to bring the exits with you.

Tanaka rolled off the gunwale without a splash. That was the first thing — the no-splash. The woman entered the sea the way the rest of them entered a sentence they'd rehearsed.

"She's already down," said Owen over the comms, flat as a ledger. Owen was the recorder. He noted Tanaka's depth, the time, the visibility — eight meters, generous for here — and the fact that the National Maritime Survey Unit's second boat was idling four hundred meters off, white hull, two outboards, a man on the bow doing nothing very visibly.

"Watching us watch them," said Pinch, which was the dry one's only contribution and exactly enough.

Mara went over backward and the green-blue closed over her mask.

Here is the official story, and it is worth telling straight, because the people who tell it are not fools and they are not liars and most of them have spent more of their lives wet than Mara had spent awake.

In 1986 a dive guide named Kihachiro Aratake was scouting hammerhead grounds off the south coast of Yonaguni, the last scrap of Japan before Taiwan, and he came up over a wall of rock that did not

behave like rock. Steps. Terraces. A face of stone dropping in clean stages toward twenty-five meters. He told people. People came. Among them came Masaaki Kimura of the University of the Ryukyus, a marine geologist of real standing, who dove it and mapped it and came up convinced he was looking at architecture — a platform, a road, the drowned bones of something built. And among them came Robert Schoch of Boston University, a geologist of equal standing, who dove the same stone and came up convinced he was looking at sandstone doing what sandstone does: splitting along its bedding planes, cracking along its joints, the Lower Miocene Yaeyama Group obeying twenty million years of physics and the patient editing of the sea.

Two credentialed men. Two readings. No referee.

That is not a gap the believers invented to crawl through. That is the literature.

Mara descended into it.

The terraces resolved out of the haze the way a word resolves out of a mouth full of mumble — too late to brace for. First just shapes, sediment-soft, then edges. Then *the* edge.

The Main Terrace ran off into the green on her left, a hundred and fifty meters of it, forty wide, and the top of it was *flat*. Not flat-ish. Not flat-for-the-ocean-floor. Flat the way a table is flat, the way her whole body wanted to call deliberate before her brain could file an objection.

She put her glove on it.

This was the thing she did. This was the thing she was *for*. Mara could not always tell you why a face had gone wrong across a dinner table, could not always parse the joke before everyone else had laughed, but she could lay a hand on stone and feel the difference between a surface that had been *worked* and a surface that had merely *broken* — worked stone carries the rhythm of intention, the small repeating violence of a tool; broken stone carries the long single shrug of pressure and time. Worked stone has a beat. Broken stone has a sigh.

She laid her hand on the Main Terrace, and the terrace did both.

The flat under her palm was bedding-plane flat — she could feel the grain of the sandstone running away from her in the direction it had been laid down, sediment on sediment, twenty million years of patient compaction, and a plane like that splits clean because it *is* a clean thing, a layer-cake parting at the layer. Schoch. Schoch was in her glove. This was natural. This was the sea reading the rock's own instructions back to it.

Then she moved her hand to the riser — the step's vertical face, the drop to the next terrace down — and the rock turned a corner.

Ninety degrees. Or near enough that her hand, sliding the join, reported *corner* before it reported *angle*. The horizontal plane met the vertical plane and there was a *line* there, a meeting that her palm wanted to call a seam, a fit.

"It's—" she started, and stopped, because she didn't have the second word.

THE FISH — and there is always a fish, the heckler in the cheap seats of every certainty — would like to point out that nature loves a right angle. Sandstone joints often run vertical because the rock relaxes upward when the weight above it goes; bedding planes run horizontal because that is how the mud settled. Cross the two and you get a step. Cross a lot of them and you get a staircase. The fish has seen basalt columns make hexagons it never sat an exam for. The fish is not impressed by a corner.

The fish, treading water somewhere behind Mara's sternum, also could not get the second word out.

Tanaka appeared beside her without seeming to have crossed the water between. She didn't gesture grandly. She didn't sweep a hand to present the wonder. She tapped two fingers on the riser face — *here* — and then drew them down it, slow, and Mara understood she was being shown how to read, not what to conclude.

Tanaka's finger stopped at a notch. A small interruption in the vertical, the size of a fist, where the clean drop hiccuped inward and

out again. Then she moved Mara's own glove to a notch nine meters along the same riser. Then a third. Three notches, roughly even, roughly aligned, marching the length of the terrace at the same height.

Mara's whole skin went cold in a way the water hadn't managed.

Even spacing was the beat. Even spacing was the tool-rhythm, the thing worked stone carried and broken stone could not. Three of them in a line at the same elevation — that was either someone counting, or—

Tanaka shook her head. Slow. Deliberate. *No*. And she took Mara's glove off the third notch and laid it flat against the stone *between* two of them, and held it there, and waited, until Mara felt it: the same grain. The same bedding plane, the same fine sandstone running the same direction through notch and gap alike, undifferentiated, continuous, a single sheet of rock that happened to have failed at intervals because rock that is layered and stressed and undermined by the sea *fails at intervals*. Joints propagate. The sea hollows under the weak spots. The weak spots in a bedded sandstone tend to come — Tanaka spread her hand, measuring nothing, measuring everything — *evenly*.

The beat was real. The beat was not a tool. The beat was the rock's own metronome.

Mara had read the stone correctly. The stone had lied. Or the stone had told the truth and she had heard a tool in it, which is the same failure wearing better clothes.

This is the potato, and you should feel it the way Mara felt it, in the hands, because the believers feel it too and they are not stupid: it is genuinely hard to make this stone by accident, and it is genuinely hard to make it on purpose, and nobody has cleanly done either.

Picture the on-purpose. You are a Ryukyuan, some span of years ago — the rock above you, last dry, somewhere between two and ten thousand years back, depending on which sea-level curve you trust. You have brought, what, stone tools, since metal is a stretch and a half here. You want a terrace a hundred and fifty meters long, dead flat, in a sandstone that — and ask anyone who has tried to carve sandstone

— does not take a clean line. It crumbles. It spalls. It comes off in grit and disappointment. You would leave marks. You would leave thousands of marks, the rhythmic bite of the tool, the *beat* — and across nearly forty years of diving and mapping and photographing and Kimura's own published surveys, no one has produced a single tool mark that the wider geological and archaeological community has accepted. Not one, peer-reviewed and stood up. The believer's best receipts are *possible* marks, *interpreted* inscriptions, things that might be the beat and might be the sea.

Now picture the by-accident. The sea did all of it. Fine — the sea does flat planes, the sea does joints, the sea does steps. But show the fish another one. Another underwater sandstone of this scale, this stacked, this *geometric*, made purely by jointing and tide, somewhere else on this planet, so we can all nod and say *ah, of course, it's just one of those*. Nobody has produced that either. There are similar fractured formations above water on the nearby islands — Schoch's people point to them, rightly, and they are real and they matter. But the full package, at this size, at this regularity, underwater: Yonaguni stands in a category it is the only member of.

So you have a thing too clean for the skeptic's comfort and too unmarked for the believer's proof, and two geologists with the same letters after their names reading it opposite ways, and a hole in the middle of the literature you could drop a temple into.

Mara was kneeling on the lip of that hole with her hand on the stone, and the stone would not tell her which way to fall.

Behind her, the LENS was not falling either. The LENS was working.

He'd come down last, the way he always did, hanging above the rest of them at first like a man unsure the floor would hold his weight, and then the camera had come up and the camera had taken over, the way it did, the way the rest of them had stopped pretending it wouldn't. Through the housing his face went smooth. The terrace through his lens was not a question. It was a composition — the riser cutting the frame, Tanaka's silhouette against the brighter water above, a sea fan trembling on the corner where geometry met the encrusting life that had spent centuries softening every honest edge on this whole formation into something you had to *imagine* clean.

He shot the corner forty ways. He did not shoot it as evidence. Mara could tell. He shot it as a thing that was beautiful and would not say what it was, and the not-saying was the beauty, and she watched him fall toward it the way she was falling toward the stone, and somewhere up the line Owen logged the time and Pinch said nothing and the white hull idled four hundred meters off, waiting to box all of this up and write *natural formation, archived* on the lid and close the file.

“Survey boat’s moving,” Owen said. “Slow. Toward the channel.”

Nobody answered. The sea ate the words.

Tanaka took Mara to the Trench.

The Road, some called it — a long straight channel running parallel to the monument’s flank, walls rising sheer on both sides, the floor of it flat, the whole thing aimed like a corridor at nothing Mara could see. They swam its length and the walls held the same impossible double truth: bedding-plane flat, joint-straight, the grain running on through and the corners turning clean, and Mara stopped trusting her glove entirely and just *swam*, just let the corridor carry her, and for one stretch — twenty meters, thirty — it was unmistakably a built place, a thing meant to be moved through, a road *to* somewhere, and the certainty was total and physical and rose in her chest like warm water.

Then the corridor ended in a heap of fallen blocks, jumbled, random, sandstone that had simply come apart and lain down where it fell, no rhythm, no beat, no intention, pure shrug — and the certainty drained out of her so fast she felt her ears pop with it.

The road went somewhere. The somewhere was rubble.

She hung there in the green, in the silt the fanning had lifted, and the question pressed on her from every side the way the water pressed, even, total, indifferent — *made or not, made or not* — and her gift, the thing she was for, the hand that knew worked from broken, lay open at her side and reported, with perfect honesty, *both*.

Tanaka touched her shoulder. Pointed up. Time.

They rose along the great flat face of the Main Terrace, slow, the safety stop strung out at five meters, and from up there the whole thing laid itself out below her in the clearing light — the terraces, the steps, the long straight Trench, the stacked deliberate-looking shape of it dropping away into blue — and from up here it looked *made*. From here, where you couldn't touch it, where the hand couldn't argue, it looked like a city had drowned and was waiting to be remembered.

That was the trouble. That was the whole trouble in one ascent. Close enough to touch, it was stone arguing with itself. Far enough to see whole, it was architecture. The sea kept the answer at exactly the distance where you could not hold it.

Tanaka hung beside her, watching Mara watch it. The local's eyes through the mask were not triumphant and not amused. They were patient, the patience of someone who has lived next to a question her whole life and has made her peace with its weight and is wondering, mildly, whether these outsiders will try to pick it up and carry it off like the white boat means to, or whether they will set it back down where it belongs.

Mara looked at the terrace. She looked at her own hand. She did not have the second word, and for the first time in her life that felt less like a failure than like the only honest thing in the water.

Below them the survey boat's shadow slid across the Main Terrace, and was gone.

They broke the surface into wind and noise and the bright flat ordinary world, and nobody said anything, and Tanaka pulled her mask down around her neck and looked back at the place she came from, and that — the looking back, the not yet saying — was the door.

Chapter 4 — The Potato Test

The block came up on a sling from the harbour quarry, a slab of the same Yaeyama sandstone that built the island and, twenty meters down, maybe built something else. It sat on the dive platform dripping seawater, the colour of weak tea where the sun had it, darker in the grain. Vinh had begged it off a stonemason in the village who cut foundation blocks for typhoon walls, and who had charged a fair price and thrown in the warning that came free: *that stone don't do what you want. It does what it does.*

I put my hand flat on the top of it before anyone said anything.

This is the part I can't make sound like science, so I won't try. The block was cool the way wet stone is cool, and under that there was the texture, and the texture talked. Fine grain, even, packed close — Lower Miocene, twenty million years of being pressed into a shape that was no shape, just sediment with patience. I ran my thumb along a fresh face where the mason's saw had been and felt the rasp of it, the millions of identical small drags. A made edge. Then I went to the side the saw hadn't touched, where the slab had split along its own grain, and felt the difference: not smooth, not rough, *clean* in a way that has no fingerprint at all. Stone deciding for itself where it wanted to come apart.

Worked stone remembers the worker. Fractured stone remembers nothing. My whole job, if I have one, is that the two feel different under the hand, and I have never once been wrong about it on dry land.

That was the whole problem with Yonaguni. I was about to be wrong

a lot.

“So.” Marlow set down a canvas roll and unbuckled it, and there they were: chisels, a mallet, a flat bolster, a tape measure, a carpenter’s square in oxidised brass. “The proposition is simple. Kimura looks at the Main Terrace and reads a man at work. Schoch looks at the same terrace and reads bedding planes and joints and the sea. Both of them have letters after their names. Both of them have been down there with their own eyes.” He picked up the square and laid it against the slab, and the long arm of it sat true along the top edge — the mason’s edge — and gapped a hair along the split face. “We are not going to settle that. God forbid. We’re going to do the one thing neither of them spends much ink on.”

“Which is,” said the fish — Dela, our dry one, perched on the gunwale with her feet not touching anything, the way she sat when she’d already decided how this ended. “Find out if a man with a chisel can make the thing at all. Because everyone’s arguing about *who* and *when* and nobody’s checked whether *can*.”

“Replication,” Marlow said. “Cut me a right angle. A real one. Two faces meeting at ninety, both flat, the corner crisp. Like the ones at fifteen meters that keep people up at night.”

Saki Tanaka was sitting on an overturned crate in the shade of the wheelhouse with a thermos of something and the patience of a person who has watched a great many mainlanders do a great many things to her rocks. She was in a half-dry wetsuit, hood pushed back, and she had not said a word since the slab came up except to ask, mildly, whether we’d be putting it back in the sea after or whether she should expect it to live on the boat forever. She had an interest in the answer, you understood, that was older and harder than ours.

She lifted her chin at the tools. “Go ahead.” Two syllables that meant *I have seen this film*.

—

Here is the official story, and I want to give it the respect it has earned, because the believers earned theirs and so did the skeptics and they are both standing in the same cold water.

Masaaki Kimura is a marine geologist at the University of the Ryukyus. He did not wander onto a beach with a metal detector and a pod-

cast. He dove Yonaguni for decades. He produced site maps, measured the terraces, photographed what he reads as steps and a road and walls meeting at corners that the sea, in his judgment, does not make. He sees a ceremonial platform, maybe a temple, maybe more, drowned when the land that held it last stood in air — somewhere, the estimates say, between two thousand and ten thousand years ago. That is a man looking at a thing and saying: *a hand was here*. A whole life of looking. You don't wave that off.

Robert Schoch is a geologist at Boston University, and he went down too, with the same eyes and a different verdict. Sandstone fractures along bedding planes — flat sheets, near-horizontal, stacked like the slab on our platform. It joints vertically, and where horizontal sheets meet vertical joints you get — say it slowly — right angles. Steps. Terraces. Schoch points up at Yonaguni's own coastline, above water, dry, walkable, where the same stone has made the same shapes with no help from anyone. He points out, fairly, that decades of diving have produced not one tool mark anybody could publish and defend. Nature, he says, is the mason. The sea is the chisel.

Neither of them can shut the other up. That's not a scandal. That's the honest state of the file.

So we tried to be the mason.

—

Marlow went first because Marlow is steady and has done dry-stone walling and didn't think it would be hard, exactly, but thought it would be *doable*. He scribed a line with the square, set the bolster, and struck.

The stone took the blow and gave back a chip the size of a thumbnail, and a second strike took a chunk three times bigger than he'd aimed for, following a grain we couldn't see until it was already gone. He worked at it for forty minutes. He had calluses and patience and a good eye and the result, when he stepped back, was a face that was *flattish*, sloping where it didn't want to slope, a corner that crumbled to a soft edge instead of a crisp one because sandstone at a fine angle doesn't hold a line — it sugars away under its own weight.

"Potato," said Dela, not unkindly.

It was. It looked like a potato. It looked like something a glacier had

been bored by.

I took the chisel next, which was vanity, because the thing I'm good at is reading edges, not making them, and the two are not the same skill no matter how badly you want them to be when the LENS is filming. Soren had the camera up — of course he did — finding the way the light came off the wet new chip and the way Saki sat in the dark of the wheelhouse not watching the stone at all but watching *us*, which I think was the actual photograph and which I think he knew.

The chisel jumped in my hands. I felt the strike travel into the grain and split somewhere I hadn't authored, and the corner I wanted came away as a curve. I tried again, lighter, reading the face between blows — *here, the grain runs this way, so come in across it* — and for one stroke it obeyed me and I had a flat the length of my palm, dead flat, and my whole chest went up like a kid's. Then the next stroke found a bedding plane I hadn't read and lifted a sheet clean off, flat as a table, perfect, *better* than anything I'd made on purpose, and ruined the corner entirely.

That was the moment it got into me, the real cold of this place, colder than the water.

The sheet the stone gave me by accident was *flatter than the flat I'd fought for*. My deliberate work was a potato. The stone's careless work was a terrace.

Saki saw my face. She gets up off her crate when something's worth getting up for, and she came over and picked up the sheet I'd accidentally produced, turned it in the light, and set it down on the slab where it had come from, fitting it back like a tile.

"This," she said, tapping the flat of it. "You think you did this." Not a question. "You hit it. The stone already knew where it would go. You just told it when."

—

The thing about Saki out-reading you is she doesn't perform it. She doesn't make a speech. She crouched at the slab with her thermos cup steaming in one hand and put two fingers on a bedding plane I'd exposed and said, "Down at the Terrace, where the steps are — people stand at the top and say, *look how level, a man made it level*." She drank. "The level was already in the rock when the rock was mud.

Twenty million years ago. Flat water, flat mud, flat stone. The sea didn't carve the flat. It *uncovered* it." She looked up at me, and there was no contempt in it, which somehow made it land harder. "Same with the corners. The mud lies flat. Then the ground shakes — we get earthquakes here, big ones, all the time — and it cracks straight down. Flat meets straight. Ninety degrees. You don't need a temple. You need patience and a fault line and a few thousand years of bad weather."

"That's Schoch's case," Marlow said, careful, respectful, the way you'd lay a card down face up.

"That's what's *under my hands every day I go down*," Saki said, and there was the edge of the protectiveness in it, the thing the whole island had — *this is not your puzzle, it is our home, and we have been swimming in it since before you knew the word for it*. She softened it with the next breath. "I'm a geologist. I want the boring answer. The boring answer is usually true."

Then she did the thing I keep thinking about.

She put my failed potato-corner next to a photograph from Vinh's folder — one of Kimura's, the famous one, the corner at the Main Terrace meeting clean at fifteen meters with a diver hanging beside it for scale. She set them side by side on the wet wood. My corner: soft, crumbled, a thing chewed. Kimura's corner: sharp enough to set a square against.

"You see?" she said. "You can't do it." A beat. "I can't do it either."

"And the sea can," said Dela.

Saki looked at the photograph a long time. The current was changing out past the breakwater; you could hear it, the harbour starting to breathe. When she spoke she wasn't agreeing with herself anymore, which is the only kind of expert worth your trust.

"The sea can make flat," she said slowly. "The sea can make straight. I have seen it make both, above water, on this island, you can walk up and touch it." She set her cup down. "I have never, anywhere, above water or below, seen the sea make *that many of them in a row*."

That's the hole, and I want to be exact about it, because being inexact about it is how you end up on the wrong kind of television.

Nobody — not Kimura, not anybody — has put a confirmed, peer-reviewed human tool mark on Yonaguni. Decades. Cameras, divers, the man's whole career. Not one mark the field will sign off on. That is real, and it is the skeptics' best and truest card, and it makes a man with a chisel look very small.

And: nobody has shown another formation, anywhere, underwater, of that *scale*, with that many right angles and terraces and steps marching along in series, made flat-out provably by nothing but bedding planes and joints and the sea. The above-water look-alikes Schoch points to are real and they are convincing and they are also, every one of them, *smaller, or fewer, or messier*. A potato or two among them. Not a hundred-and-fifty-meter run of them lined up like a thought.

So you've got two things that are both, infuriatingly, true. No tool marks. No twin. The case is a coin standing on its edge, and two serious people are each absolutely certain it's about to fall their way, and it has not fallen in thirty-odd years, and our slab on the dive platform had just demonstrated, with a fresh wet potato, exactly why neither of them can knock it over.

I picked up the accidental sheet again. The one flatter than my best work. I turned it so the light raked across it the way Soren likes, and I felt the surface — fine, even, no fingerprint, no rasp, no million small drags of a tool. The signature of a thing that decided for itself.

It felt exactly like the worked edges down at fifteen meters had felt under my glove, three days ago, in the green dark.

That was the part I hadn't told anyone yet.

—

Saki saw me holding it and stopped putting her tools away.

"What," she said.

"Down there," I said. "On the Terrace. Some of it feels like this. Like the rock chose." I turned the sheet. "And some of it feels —" I didn't have the word, so I used my hands, ran the slab's sawn mason-edge under her eyes, the rasp of it, the *somebody-was-here*. "Like that. And they're an arm's length apart. The same wall."

She didn't tell me I was wrong. That's the thing. She, who knew every current and every joint, who wanted the boring answer, who could have ended my whole crisis with one professional sentence — she just looked at the slab, and the sheet, and the photograph, and then out at the water where the tide had turned and was running hard now toward the monument she'd dive again at slack and could read better than any of us would ever read anything.

"Hm," she said.

Out past the breakwater a radio crackled. Vinh checked his phone and his face did a thing. The Survey boat had moved its mooring closer to the monument overnight, and they'd filed a new dive plan with the harbourmaster, and the window we thought we had at slack tomorrow was now their window, stamped and official, *documentation and archiving*, and the polite letter would arrive within the hour.

Saki read all of it off Vinh's face before he said a word. She picked up the accidental sheet of flat stone, the one neither I nor she could make on purpose, and she held it out to me — not giving it, exactly, just letting me take its weight.

"Tomorrow," she said, "before they lock the gate, I'll show you the one I can't explain." She looked at me, level as the bedding plane. "Then you tell me which it feels like."

The fish, for once, didn't heckle. The tide ran out toward the dark stairs and didn't tell anyone where it was going.

Chapter 5 — Currents and Edges

Slack tide gives you maybe forty minutes. Tanaka said it the way you'd say the bus comes at nine — not a warning, a fact you arrange your life around. We dropped off the *Yaeyama-maru* in a line, four of us and her, into water the colour of bottle glass held to a window, and the first thing I felt through five millimetres of neoprene was the cold of the place arriving early, before the eyes caught up.

The Trench runs along the monument's southern flank like a corridor somebody forgot to roof. That's the believer's word for it, *corridor*. The skeptic's word is *channel*, and the geologist's word — Tanaka's word — is a Japanese term she gave us topside and then didn't translate, because, she said, the translation would do half my arguing for me and she wanted us to do our own arguing.

So we descended into the un-translated thing.

Here is the official story, and I want to give it to you straight, because it deserves better than the breathless version it usually gets. The Yonaguni Monument is sandstone and mudstone of the Yaeyama Group, laid down in the Lower Miocene — call it twenty million years ago, mud and sand pressed into rock long before there was anybody to wonder about it. Sandstone like this fractures along bedding planes, the flat seams where one season's deposit met the next, and along vertical joints where the stone cracked under stress and let go clean. Push those two habits together — horizontal seams, vertical breaks — and you get steps. You get terraces. You get right angles, because the joints often meet the bedding at ninety degrees, the way a brick wall does, for the same boring reason a brick wall does. Add

earthquakes, which the Ryukyus have in abundance, add ten thousand years of marine erosion working the loosened blocks free, and you can build a staircase out of pure geology with nobody holding the chisel.

Robert Schoch dived here and came up with roughly that. Natural fracturing, jointing, the sea doing what the sea does. He pointed at formations on the islands *above* water — same stone, same right angles, same terraced look, dry and undisputed and made by nobody. If it's natural up there in the sun, why not down here in the dark.

That's the case. It's a good case. It is, by the count of credentialed geologists, the majority case, and I'd ask you to hold it in your hands like the heavy thing it is before anyone whispers the other word.

Tanaka took us along the Trench wall to show us the case in the rock itself.

She moved the way you move in a room you grew up in. No fin-wash, no clawing — she let a current we hadn't registered yet carry her elbow-first along the wall and put her bare fingertip — bare, she'd cut the tip off her glove years ago, she told us later, because the rock won't talk to you through rubber — on a horizontal seam at eye level.

I watched her trace it. The seam ran arrow-straight for the length of three of her hand-spans, then stepped down a hand's height to another seam, just as straight, and the corner where they met was a corner. Sharp. The kind of edge that makes the back of your neck go cold and your mouth want to say a word the rock hasn't earned.

She tapped it twice. Then she rolled her wrist and laid the same fingertip on the *underside* of the step, the bit you don't photograph, and held there, and looked at me through the mask until I came and put my own bare fingertip beside hers.

The fish, our recorder's voice in my ear over the comms, dry as a dock at low water: "She's making you do your homework in front of her."

I shut him out and felt.

This is the thing my wiring does, the thing that got me put in a quiet room a lot as a kid and gets me hired as an adult: I can feel where a surface was worked and where it broke. A worked surface has a

grammar — the pecks march, the grind goes one direction, the chisel bites and skips with the hand that drove it. A fractured surface has weather instead of grammar; it conchoids, it steps along the grain, it follows the rock's own opinion about where to come apart. Most days that distinction sings to me clean as a struck glass.

Under the top edge of that step, the stone was rough in exactly the way fresh-broken sandstone is rough — granular, irregular, no march to it, the grain visible and going where the grain wanted. The top face above it, the part that read as a tread, that part was *flatter* than the underside had any right to predict, but it was flat the way a bedding plane is flat: it was flat because it was a seam, a buried sheet of denser sediment exposed when the looser sand above it sheared off.

I came up off the wall and gave Tanaka the flat-hand wobble. *Both. I'm getting both.*

She nodded once, like I'd passed something, and that's when the cold got worse, because the thing she was teaching me wasn't *it's natural*. The thing she was teaching me was *you cannot tell by touch*, and she was teaching it to the person whose entire value to this expedition was telling by touch.

She drew a line in the water with her finger — *follow* — and led us deeper along the Trench toward the place the locals call, when they call it anything, the corner of the steps.

Now the potato. You can't replicate a thing you don't understand, but you can try, and the trying tells you how hard the easy story is. The day before, in the shallow scatter off the harbour mouth, Tanaka had let us bring a chisel and a rock hammer down and have a go at a loose block of the same Yaeyama sandstone — her condition was that we work a block already broken free, nothing in situ, and she watched the whole time with her arms folded in the water like a teacher who has seen this lesson taught to fools before.

I'm decent with stone. Our recorder is patient and methodical and has dressed building blocks on land. Between us, with an hour and good tools and air on our backs and *intent* — that's the thing the sea doesn't have, intent — we tried to cut one clean ninety-degree corner into that block, the way the Trench wall does it for free.

We made a potato. The chisel bit and the sandstone didn't shear, it

crumbled, the grain plucking out in little granular avalanches so that every edge came out furred and approximate, a child's idea of a corner. Underwater you can't swing for power, the water eats the blow; the stone fights you soft and wins. Forty minutes of two competent people with steel and lungs and a plan, and our corner was rounder and messier and more obviously *handled* than anything in the monument. The sea's corner was sharper than ours. The sea's corner was sharper than ours by a country mile, and the sea had used no hands at all.

Schoch, I thought, swimming after Tanaka's fins, would have enjoyed watching us fail. He'd have been right to.

The corner of the steps, when we reached it, was the cleanest thing I have ever put my eyes on underwater.

Two faces of rock met in a vertical line that fell from a tread above us down past two more treads to the silt floor, and the line was *plumb*. Not nearly plumb. Plumb. The light came down green-gold through twelve metres of water and lay along that edge and the edge held it like the spine of a book. To the left and right, the rock did rock things — encrusted, lumped, alive with coralline crust and the small commuting fish and a dark fan of soft coral working in the surge. But the corner itself stayed bare, swept, as though the current that ran the Trench kept it polished, and it ran true top to bottom with the sea filing it forever and nobody, nobody, ever once raising a tool to it.

I put my fingertip on it. I had to.

And here is where my gift ran out, and I want to be honest about the running-out because it's the truest thing I felt down there. The edge was sharp. The grammar I look for — the march of the worked tool — was not there; I felt no grind, no peck, no bite-and-skip. Just the grain, and the seam, and the joint, doing their twenty-million-year-old work. Everything my fingers said agreed with Schoch.

And everything my eyes said wanted to disagree. Because nature, the books all grant, fractures sandstone into steps and right angles *at small scale, here and there, often*. What my eyes were arguing with was the *and-then-it-kept-going*. The corner held plumb for two metres. The tread above ran flat and level for the length of a hallway. The repetition is the thing. One clean right angle is a Tuesday in sandstone. A staircase of them, stacked, at this scale, underwater —

that's the part nobody, on either side of the credentialled split, can point to a second example of and say see, *nature does this too, all the time, here's another*. Above water, Schoch's similar formations are real and they are similar. They are also, the honest among the skeptics will tell you, *smaller*, and *fewer*, and not quite this.

That's the hole. It's not a tool mark — there's no confirmed tool mark, the believers haven't produced one in nearly forty years and they're owed the respect of saying so plainly. And it's not, on the other side, a matching natural twin of this size and this geometry that anyone can sail you out to. The hole is the shape of an absence on both shores. The case is split between two people with the same letters after their names, and the rock won't break the tie.

"You feeling it?" the fish murmured. "That's the sound of a draw. Both heavyweights still standing. Crowd wants a knockout. Rock's not in the mood."

Tanaka had been watching me feel the corner. She reached past me — that bare fingertip again — and laid it not on the sharp plumb line but two hand-spans to the right of it, on a face that looked, to my eyes, identical. Same crust, same green light. She pressed, and beckoned, and I came and felt where she'd felt.

This face stepped *wrong*. Where the corner ran plumb, this one had a hairline veer in it, a drift of maybe a finger's width over its run, the seam wandering off true the way a seam will when the bedding plane it follows has its own gentle dip. And once she'd put it under my hand I could feel that the surge worked this face differently — it caught here, eddied, where at the corner it had run clean. She held up two fingers. Pointed at the plumb corner. Pointed at the veering face. Turned her hand over, palm up, empty. *Same stone. Same sea. One ran true. One didn't. Why this one and not that one — that's the question, and I am not going to pretend I have closed it for you.*

She knew this Trench the way I know my own hands, and what her knowing produced was not an answer. It was a sharper question, handed over without being solved, which is a harder and more generous thing to give than a verdict, and I think I understood for the first time why she'd kept that one word in her own language.

Our LENS had been below us the whole time, hanging in the blue with the housing up, and I'd half-clocked the strobe not firing. When

I looked he had the camera lowered, just holding it against his chest, watching the plumb corner with his actual eyes the way you'd watch a fire. He'd come here to make an image and the image was refusing to behave — was both threat and beauty, both made and broken, in the same frame, and you cannot caption that, and he knew it, and for once he wasn't trying.

Tanaka tapped her wrist. Slack was ending. We'd feel it in a minute or two, the Trench waking up, and when it woke it would not care that we had questions.

I went back to the corner one last time and put my hand flat against the cold of it. Worked or broken. Made or grown. My fingers, the best instrument I own, the thing that is how I see, said *I cannot tell you*, and for once that wasn't a failure of the instrument. It was the instrument reading the world exactly right.

The current came up the Trench then, soft and then less soft, a hand on the small of the back. Tanaka was already finning into it, easy, reading water none of us could see. Above her the survey unit's mooring buoy hung at the surface like a clean white verdict waiting to be issued.

She'd shown us the sea's case in full, edge by honest edge, and the sea's case was strong, and the sea's case had a corner two metres of true plumb wide that it couldn't quite account for.

We followed her up.

Chapter 6 — The Survey Team Closes In

The boxes came ashore before the divers did.

The LENS stood at the harbour wall with the camera not yet raised, watching them stack: pale crates the colour of bone, ribbed with aluminium edges, each one wearing a barcode and a humidity strip and a stencilled crest he had to squint to read. NATIONAL MARITIME SURVEY UNIT. Beneath it, in smaller characters, a registration string, the kind you found on shipping manifests and morgue drawers. He had seen crates like these in three countries he no longer said out loud. They were always the same. Whatever went in them came out catalogued and gone.

The boats were better than the local boats. That was the first thing. White hulls, twin outboards, a survey vessel anchored beyond the reef with a dive platform that folded out hydraulically, slow and certain, like something exhaling. The Survey Unit moved the way well-funded things move — without hurry, because hurry implies the possibility of losing.

A young officer in a navy windbreaker came along the wall with a clipboard and a smile so even it had clearly been issued with the windbreaker. He bowed. He spoke careful English for the LENS's benefit, careful Japanese for Saki's, and managed both without seeming to switch, which was its own kind of skill.

"You are with the documentary group," he said. Not a question.

"We're with the documentary group." The LENS let the camera hang.

"We appreciate your patience." The officer turned the clipboard so

it faced no one in particular. “The site requires careful management. There are conservation concerns. Diver traffic disturbs the sediment. We are establishing a baseline survey, and a clean baseline cannot be —” he searched, found it — “contaminated. You understand.”

The LENS understood. The word *contaminated* was doing a great deal of work, and most of it had nothing to do with sediment.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and you should let it stand up straight before you start looking for where it leans.

The Yonaguni Monument is a national curiosity inside Japanese waters, and Japan takes its waters seriously, and a formation this size — a hundred and fifty metres of terraced sandstone with a fanbase that spans from credentialed geologists to people who own crystals — is exactly the kind of thing a responsible government documents properly before someone with a GoPro and a theory loves it to death. The Survey Unit was not cartoon villainy. It was a baseline study. Photogrammetry. Sediment cores. A current model. The marine encrustation alone — and the monument is *encrusted*, furred over in coral and algae and the patient architecture of small living things — makes any honest survey a slow, expensive, repeatable affair you do not want forty tourists fanning silt into.

They had permits. They had a mandate. They had, the officer mentioned pleasantly, a deadline, because the funding cycle that paid for the boats and the crates and the windbreakers did not extend itself for sentiment.

And — this is the part you must hold without flinching — they were *right* about the silt. Saki had said it first, on the first day, before any of this. Every fin-kick lifts a season of patience off the stone. The crew were a disturbance. Everyone diving that water was a disturbance. The Survey Unit had simply decided they were the only disturbance the site could afford, and had the letterhead to make the decision stick.

Sure, said the dry one, the fish-voice, somewhere in the back of the dinghy, examining a crate label through the binoculars. *Baseline survey. Forty crates for a rock that's twenty million years old. You'd think one crate. You'd think a photo.*

Nobody answered him. The crates went up the wall, one by one, into a refrigerated container truck that had no business on an island this small and had clearly come over on a ferry that cost more than the island's annual squid haul.

Saki took it standing very still, which the LENS had learned to read as the opposite of calm.

She was on the slipway in her wetsuit, hood down, hair flattened in a salt halo, and she watched the dive schedule get amended on a whiteboard the Survey Unit had bolted to the harbour office wall like they owned it, which by Friday they functionally would. Slack tide was the only window that mattered. At slack, the current relented and you could hang over the Main Terrace without being peeled off it, and the visibility — green-blue, cathedral light, the chill coming up off the edges before you touched them — opened up enough to see. There were maybe two usable slacks a day. The Unit had taken both. Their boats would be on the platform for the morning slack and the afternoon slack, baseline, baseline, and the crew's window had narrowed to a smear of churned water at the change of tide when nobody could see their own hands.

"They've timed it," the recorder said, copying the whiteboard into her notebook the way she copied everything, dates and depths and the registration string off the crates, because someday a thing you wrote down would be the only proof a thing had happened. "Both slacks. Every day this week."

"They've timed it," Saki agreed. Her voice was even. The LENS noticed her hands. They were doing nothing at all, which is what hands do when they very much want to do something.

The young officer drifted back, all apology. He was sorry. The schedule was tight. Conservation. He hoped the crew had gotten what they needed — and there it was, the assumption inside the courtesy, the gentle nudging of *had gotten*, past tense, finished, a thing concluded so smoothly you might forget you hadn't agreed to it.

"We've gotten one dive," the LENS said.

"Ah." The officer looked genuinely pained, which was worse than if he hadn't. "I will see what can be arranged."

The ND lead was not at the wall. They were on the dive platform of the small boat, out of the sun, hands flat on the gunwale, because the harbour was a riot of inputs and the gunwale was one true thing — warm fibreglass, a known texture, a place to put the hands while the rest of the world arrived all at once.

They were thinking about the stone. They could not stop thinking about the stone.

On the one dive they'd been allowed, they had touched the third step of the eastern stack — the famous one, the one in Kimura's photographs, the one that makes believers of careful people. Under the glove, even through neoprene, the edge had read *clean*. Not smooth. Sandstone is never smooth; it has tooth, it has grain, it sheds against your palm like wet sugar. But the edge had been a *corner*, a right angle held over a run of stone, and the ND lead's whole nervous system had lit up the way it does when worked and broken disagree.

Because that was the thing. Broken stone, fractured stone, jointed stone — and the Yaeyama sandstone is *built* to fracture, bedded in flat sheets and split through by vertical joints, it wants to come apart in rectangles the way slate wants to come apart in plates — broken stone has a *language*. The conchoidal swell where a flake popped. The step-fracture where a joint met a bedding plane and the rock simply obeyed two laws at once. The ND lead could read it. It was the only thing they had ever been able to read more easily than faces.

And the third step had spoken both languages at once and the ND lead could not make it choose.

That was the potato. Not a failed model in a tank — that came later, the chisel and the slab and the result you could only call a potato with a straight face — but this, right here, the body's own instrument running off the scale. The gift that had never failed them, hitting a stone that would not resolve. *Worked*, said the corner. *Fractured*, said the grain inside the corner. *Both*, said the sea, which had had ten thousand years to work whatever a vanished hand might have started, or to do the whole thing alone with current and earthquake and the slow surgery of salt, and which kept no notes.

Schoch would stand at that corner and see bedding planes doing

what bedding planes do, at a scale that surprises the eye but breaks no law of geology. Kimura would stand at the same corner and see a stair, deliberate, a riser cut to a tread, and would not be a fool for it. The corner did not care which of them was right. The corner was just *there*, holding its angle in the green light, indifferent and beautiful, and decades of credentialed argument had not made it confess.

The ND lead pressed their palms to the gunwale and breathed.

The LENS found them there and sat, not too close, and did the thing he did instead of talking, which was to lift the camera and not press the shutter.

Through the viewfinder the boxes on the wall composed themselves into a frame he didn't want: the refrigerated truck, the crates, the white hull beyond the reef, the whiteboard with the slacks all claimed. It was a clean image. It told a clean story. A government documents a site; a documentary crew runs out of time; the legend gets archived. He had spent twenty years making clean images of unclean things, and the cleanness was the lie, every time. He let the shutter rest.

"They're not stealing it," he said finally. "I want to be clear with myself about that. They've got every right. The silt thing is real."

"The silt thing is real," the ND lead agreed.

"It just —" He lowered the camera. "When something gets boxed, it stops being a question. It becomes an *answer*, even if the answer is 'no comment.' Especially then." He watched a crate go up the wall. "I've seen places get answered. You can't un-answer them."

Down the slipway, Saki and Jakobus had drifted into the slack patch of shade by the office wall, and the LENS, who read frames the way the ND lead read stone, watched them without needing to hear.

Jakobus was doing what Jakobus did, which was almost nothing. He stood the way he always stood off his own ground — a little provisional, a guest, hands loose, the weight of his whole career as the man who reads made things held politely in abeyance because this was not his water and not his read to make. He said something short. Saki shook her head, not in disagreement, more in the manner of someone setting down a heavy thing to look at it.

The LENS couldn't hear the words. He could see the shape. Jakobus had asked something — and you could tell from the angle of Saki's chin that it was *the* question, the one Jakobus carried into every site like a tuning fork, *what is it for* — and Saki had not answered, and Jakobus had not pressed, had instead turned his face out to the white survey hull and let the question sit between them like a third diver waiting on the slack.

Whatever it was for, the Survey Unit did not have the read. They had the crates. Those are different things, and only one of them ships.

The amended schedule was final by Thursday. The officer delivered it himself, holding the clipboard at the precise apologetic angle, and he had, he said, managed to arrange one more window. The crew should be grateful, and the LENS, to his own irritation, was.

One dive. The morning slack on Saturday, before the Unit closed the site to all non-survey traffic for the duration of the baseline study — a duration the permit listed and the funding cycle would extend approximately never. After that, the water belonged to the white hulls and the crates and the clean image. The legend would not be debunked or confirmed. It would simply be *archived*, which in the long run is the same as a stone falling in deep water: it makes no sound anyone above is permitted to hear.

"One dive," the recorder repeated, and wrote it down, with the date, and the slack time, and the depth they'd be cleared to, and — because she copied everything — the officer's name, which she would later find did not appear on any public document, not because of a conspiracy, but because junior staff rotate and paperwork is mortal and the world simply does not keep everyone.

Saki took the news without moving. Then she pulled her hood up, which on her was a decision, and looked at the crew — the LENS with his lowered camera, the ND lead with their hands still flat on the warm fibreglass, the recorder with her honest notebook, the dry one already half a heckle into the silence.

"One dive," she said. "Then I'll show you the thing I've been not showing you."

She did not explain. She was Okinawan and a geologist and she had

spent her professional life standing between the people who wanted Yonaguni to be a temple and the people who wanted it to be a rock, refusing both the satisfaction of her certainty, because she had it and it was not theirs to take. She owned the currents. She owned the stone. She owned, most of all, the right to decide what the place was *for*, and whether these strangers with their cameras and their tender, overloaded, unhealable way of seeing had earned the giving of it.

Out beyond the reef, the survey hull rode at anchor in the last of the afternoon light, and on the harbour wall the crates climbed one by one into the cold, and the tide turned, and the green water over the Main Terrace went, for a few unwatched minutes, perfectly clear, and held its angle, and told no one anything at all.

One dive, said the fish, very quietly for once. *No pressure*.

The slack would come at 6:14 on Saturday morning. The door was that wide.

Chapter 7 — Stone Memory

The face was waiting where the chart said it would be, eight meters down, on the seaward edge where the terrace dropped into blue.

Mara found it the way you find anything underwater — sideways, by accident, when the silt clears for the length of a held breath. There were two hollows in the rock, set above a longer horizontal groove, and the brain did what the brain always does. It assembled a face out of three accidents the way it builds a man in the moon. Eyes. Mouth. A brow ridge that ran clean across, level, like a shelf someone had set there.

She knew the trick of it. She knew that pareidolia was the oldest debunk in the box, that you could find faces in toast and on Mars and in the grain of a kitchen cupboard, and that the honest thing was to say so out loud and move past. The face is not a face. It is a coincidence of weathering on Lower Miocene sandstone laid down twenty million years before anything had a face to lose.

She said it to herself, dead straight, and then she put her glove out and touched it anyway.

Here we go, said the fish in her ear — not really the fish, just Tomas on the comm, dry as ever, watching her bubbles climb on his monitor up in the boat. *Mara's about to have a conversation with a rock.*

"I'm reading it," she said.

That's what I said.

She wasn't going to argue with him underwater. She let the glove rest on the brow ridge and went still, the way she went still in a crowded room when the noise got to be too much and the only way through

was to slow everything down and take the textures one at a time. That was the whole of her, really. People had spent her childhood trying to teach her to stop doing this — to stop reading the seam of a shirt collar, the grain of a desk, the way a chair leg had been turned by a machine and not by a hand. She had not stopped. She had just gotten good enough at it that grown men paid her to do it on camera.

The brow ridge was wrong for natural.

That was the first thing the glove said, and she trusted the glove. Sandstone fractures along bedding planes, flat sheets stacked like a deck of wet cards, and it splits along vertical joints where the stress finds the weakness, and when you put those two together you get steps. Right angles, even. Nature does corners. Anyone who tells you nature doesn't do corners has never looked at the Giant's Causeway or a basalt sill or a quarry face nobody ever quarried. The skeptics were right about that and Mara loved them for it, the way she loved anyone who refused to be impressed.

But the brow ridge ran *across* the bedding.

She felt for it again, mapping the planes with her fingertips, building the rock's history out of the way it had given way. The layers ran one direction — she could feel the soft hand-width courses of mudstone between the harder sandstone, the thing that made the whole monument want to break into shelves. And the groove of the brow cut a clean line at an angle to all of it. Not along the grain. *Across* it.

That was the kind of thing that, in any other stone, in any other place, she'd have called worked without a second's hesitation. Cut. Made. A person with a tool and a reason.

"Saki," she said. "Come look at this."

Dr. Tanaka had been below her the whole time, working the trench, and she came up the wall in that economical Okinawan-diver way that made Mara feel like she was thrashing. No wasted kick. She arrived at the face and hung there, neutral, one hand loose at her side, and looked at it for a long moment without touching anything at all.

That was the difference between them, and Mara had clocked it on the first dive. Mara read with her hands. Saki read with her whole

life. She had been diving this water since she was nine. She knew which way the current came at slack and which way it came at the turn, knew where the surge built and where it died, knew the monument the way you know a face you've watched age — not by its features but by everything the features had survived.

Saki tapped the brow ridge. Then she tapped a spot two meters to the left, where there was nothing, just plain rock, and held up a finger. *Wait.*

She did something with her free hand near the groove — fanned the water, gently, the way you wave silt off a thing you don't want to scratch. A small cloud lifted and drifted seaward in a thin ribbon, and Mara watched it go, and Saki watched her watch it.

The current at the brow ran across the bedding.

The water did exactly what the groove did. It came in off the open sea at this depth and at this angle, deflected by the terrace lip above, and it scoured along the line of least resistance, which was not the bedding plane here — here, the joint and the soft mudstone parting and the angle of the wall conspired to send the water *across*. For twenty million years of standing here, or for two thousand of standing here as a drowned thing, depending on whose stopwatch you believed.

Mara felt her certainty come apart in her hand.

She put her glove back on the brow ridge and felt it again, and now she couldn't unfeel the other thing. The "cut across the grain" — it could be the water's cut. Erosion doesn't only follow the layers. Erosion follows the *flow*, and the flow had been carving this exact line, day in and day out, longer than there had been a sea here to do it.

She had built a face out of three accidents, and she had built *worked stone* out of the wrong assumption that nature only ever breaks along the grain.

Saki was watching her, and behind the mask her eyes were not unkind. She made a small gesture — flat hand, tilted side to side. *Maybe. Maybe not.*

On the surface, between dives, they sat on the deck with their suits peeled to the waist and the island a low green smear to the north, and Saki drank her tea and let Mara talk herself out.

"It felt cut," Mara said. "It felt cut to me and I trust my hands more than I trust my eyes and my hands have never lied to me before."

"Your hands didn't lie." Saki turned the cup. "Your hands told you it goes across the bedding. That's true. It does. They told you that's strange." She shrugged. "It is strange. That's not a lie either."

"But."

"But your hands can't feel time." She said it without any drama. "You touch the line and you feel a decision. A person, a tool, a moment — *I will cut here*. That's what worked stone feels like to you, yes? A decision."

Mara nodded. That was exactly it. That was the whole gift, if it was a gift. A worked edge held a choice. A fractured one held only physics.

"The sea makes decisions too," Saki said. "Slower ones. It picks the soft layer over the hard one. It picks the joint over the solid. It picks this line over that line, every tide, the same choice, ten thousand years of the same choice." She set the cup down. "By the end it looks like someone meant it. Because someone did. The water meant it. The water just isn't a someone."

Behind them, Lukas had the camera up. He'd had it up for an hour. He had it pointed not at the monument and not at the survey boat sitting smug and white across the channel, but at Mara's hands, which she'd been holding in front of her without noticing, fingers moving, reading the brow ridge of a rock that was eight meters underwater and not there at all.

"You're filming my hands," Mara said, not looking.

"They're doing something," Lukas said. He didn't lower it. He never lowered it. The war had taught him that the moment you put the camera down was the moment the thing you needed happened, and he had not yet unlearned the lesson, and maybe he never would. "Keep going. Don't watch me."

Tomas, logging samples, didn't look up. *He's not wrong*, the dry voice said. *You look like you're conducting an orchestra of dead crabs.*

Jakobus was at the rail, where he always was, where the camera could find him only in profile and only when it wanted him. He'd asked one question all day, which was a lot of questions for him. He'd asked Saki what the local fishermen called the face, and Saki had told him a word in the island language, and Jakobus had repeated it once, carefully, getting his mouth around it, and then he hadn't asked what it meant. Mara had noticed that. He hadn't asked what it meant. He'd just kept it, the way you keep a key before you know the door.

Here is the potato of it, and it is worth eating cold.

The skeptics' case is gorgeous and it is mostly right. Sandstone bedded in flat courses, riven by vertical joints, in an earthquake country, under a sea that grinds at it from a consistent angle — that makes terraces. It makes steps. It makes corners that are very nearly right angles, because joints in this kind of rock do tend toward the perpendicular, and there are formations *above water* on the islands nearby that nobody is calling temples, because you can stand on them and see the seams and the silly truth of them in the sunlight. Robert Schoch dove this and came up calling it natural, and he is a credentialed geologist who has spent his life being right about hard things, and he brought the receipts.

And then there is the other man.

Masaaki Kimura dove this for decades. University of the Ryukyus. He mapped it — actually mapped it, the steps and the terrace and the trench, more thoroughly than anyone — and he came up calling it made. A platform. A monument. Possibly carvings, possibly something like writing. He is also a credentialed geologist who has spent his life being right about hard things, and he brought *his* receipts.

They looked at the same stone. They touched the same brow ridge. One of them felt a decision in it and one of them felt the sea. And there is no peer-reviewed paper, no published tool mark accepted by anyone who isn't already convinced, no cultural layer, no shard, no bone, nothing — and there is also no other formation anywhere of this size, this geometric, this insistent, that everyone agrees the sea made all by itself.

The case is split right down the middle by two men who are not cranks.

That is the whole of it. That is the honest country, and the survey boat across the channel was there to pour concrete over it and call it managed.

Mara's gift had run straight into the seam between those two men and stuck there, the way her finger had stuck on the brow ridge, reading a decision that might have been a man's or might have been the patient, mindless, ten-thousand-year decision of water.

She went down once more before the light went, alone except for Saki, who would not let her go alone.

She went back to the face. She didn't touch it this time. She did what Saki did — hung in front of it and tried to read with more than her hands, tried to feel the current that had carved the line she'd been so sure about, tried to put twenty million years and two thousand years both into her chest at once and hold them there.

She couldn't.

That was the turn, and it came not as a defeat but as a kind of cold clean air. Her hands could feel the difference between worked and fractured stone in a hundred quarries and on a thousand walls and they would never lie to her there. But here — here the sea had spent so long making decisions that its work and a person's work had stopped being two different textures. Here the gift didn't fail. The gift just arrived at the actual edge of itself and found a real thing standing there: an ambiguity that wasn't a gap in her knowledge but a fact about the stone.

The face looked back at her with its two hollow eyes that weren't eyes, level under its brow that crossed the grain because the water willed it, and gave her nothing.

Saki tapped her shoulder. Pointed up. The light was going green-gray, the silt rising, slack tide ending. Time, in this place, was always running out — the survey's clock, the sea's clock, the tide that gave you forty minutes of stillness and then took it back.

As they rose, Mara looked once more at the face and let herself not know it. Let the not-knowing be the true thing she was bringing up, instead of an answer she'd manufactured out of three accidents and

a glove.

Well? said the dry voice on the comm as her head broke the surface.
Made or not?

She spat the regulator and floated there a second, the island green at the edge of everything, the survey boat white and waiting, the water carrying the question the way it had carried everything for ten thousand years or twenty million, the way it would carry it after all of them were gone.

"Yes," she said.

That's not an answer.

"I know," she said, and reached for the ladder.

Chapter 8 — Above Water, Below Surface

The recorder — call him Pieter, because that is what the others called him when they wanted something logged, and there was always something to be logged — went up the cliff path at Sannin-dai with a clipboard he didn't need and a tape measure he did. He had stopped trusting his memory at nineteen, when a professor had laughed at a number he'd misremembered by a single decimal, and the laugh had cost him a grade and a small private dignity he had never quite got back. So now he wrote everything. He wrote the time. He wrote that the wind off the East China Sea came up the rock face in gusts that smelled of salt and diesel and, faintly, of someone's lunch from the harbour below. He wrote that the path was dry sandstone and that it rang slightly under the heel.

He wrote: *Above-water analog. Per Schoch. Compare.*

That was the assignment, more or less. If the monument under the water was just stone behaving like stone, then stone up here, in air and daylight, ought to be doing the same thing where nobody could call it a temple. Robert Schoch had said as much — the man had dived the site himself in 1997, surfaced, and pointed at the cliffs of Yonaguni and the neighbouring islands and said, in effect, *look, the rock does this on its own, you just can't usually walk on the version that's drowned*. It was a serious argument made by a serious geologist, and Pieter intended to give it the full courtesy of the tape measure.

"This way." Dr. Tanaka was already ahead of him, not waiting, the way locals never wait. She wore a faded rashguard under a fisherman's

vest and moved on the rock like the rock owed her money. “The good outcrop is where the path turns. Mind the loose face. People fall here for cameras.”

The LENS was behind them both, of course, with the camera, finding the place where the light fell off the cliff edge and made the wind visible in the spray. He had not lowered it once since the harbour. Pieter had stopped expecting him to.

Here is the official story, told straight, because it deserves to be.

Sandstone fractures. It is one of the most reliable things sandstone does. The Yaeyama Group that makes up these islands — laid down in the Lower Miocene, something on the order of twenty million years ago, when this was riverbed and shallow sea and not yet anything you could stand on — is bedded. It came down in layers, and layers part along their seams. That gives you the flat. Then the whole region got squeezed and shoved by the same tectonic temper that makes Japan Japan, and stone under that kind of stress cracks along planes, often at angles startlingly close to ninety degrees, because that is the geometry that relieves the stress most efficiently. Bedding plane horizontal. Joint set vertical. Where the two meet, you get a step. Where many meet, you get a staircase that nobody built.

You don’t have to take it on faith. You can climb up to Sannin-dai with a tape measure and find it.

Which is what Pieter did.

He found a block the size of a small car that had parted clean off the cliff along a bedding plane and left behind a face flat enough to read a book on. He laid his hand on it the way the ND lead had taught him to, even though he didn’t have the gift — flat, patient, listening with the skin. It was cool from the sea wind and very slightly gritty, like fine sugar pressed into mortar. He measured the parting plane. He measured the vertical break where the block had let go. He wrote down the angle the two made: $\sim 88^\circ$. Close enough to a right angle that, underwater, blurred by silt and a meter of marine growth and the human appetite for meaning, you would swear a mason had snapped a chalk line.

“You see it,” Tanaka said. She wasn’t asking.

"I see a step," Pieter said. "Made by nobody."

"Good. Now count them."

He looked up. The cliff above the flat block went up in three more like it, then four, then the count got away from him where the face leaned back into shadow. A flight of stairs for a giant who had never existed, going nowhere, holding nothing up, asking for nothing. He wrote: *Stacked terracing, natural, ≥7 risers visible, no tooling*. He ran his thumb along a riser edge. It was rounded, sea-rounded, weathered soft — the edge of something old that the weather had been at for a long time without any opinion about it.

"This is the case," he said, half to himself. "This is Schoch's case, just standing up in the air."

The fish-voice — the dry one, the recorder's opposite number, who had stayed at the foot of the cliff because climbing was for people with something to prove — drifted up on the wind from below.

"So we drove to an island, hired a boat, and learned that rocks have *stairs*. Riveting. Wake me when the rocks file a building permit."

Pieter wrote that down too. He logged everything.

Tanaka took them along the headland to where the path gave out and the rock ran straight down into the surf. She sat on a flat shelf as easily as another person sits in a chair and looked at the water for a while before she spoke, and Pieter had the sense, which he often had around people who actually belonged somewhere, that she was deciding how much to give.

"When I was a girl," she said, "the old men would not say the monument was anything. You understand? They would not say *made*. They would not say *natural*. If you asked, they got a face." She made the face — flat, polite, shut like a door. "Yonaguni is the end of Japan. You can see Taiwan from the lighthouse on a clear day; the children are taught that the island is the last step before the world stops being ours. There is pride in being last. There is also —" she searched for it — caution. A small place learns that when outsiders come asking what something *is*, they have usually already decided what they want it to be, and they want the island to agree."

The LENS shifted, framing her against the drop-off, and then — Pieter watched it happen, the small private event he would not log — lowered the camera a hand's width, so that he was looking at her with his own eyes for a moment instead of through the glass.

"Aratake found it for the tourists," Tanaka went on. "1986. A diver looking for hammerheads, and he comes up over the terrace, and —" she opened her hand, let the wind take it. "After that, everyone wanted it to be something. The believers wanted Atlantis. The scientists wanted a clean answer. The town wanted the boats. My teacher, who taught me the stone, wanted it left *uncertain*, because uncertain is what it honestly is, and he thought certainty was the dishonest thing people did to a place to take it from it."

"And you?" Pieter asked. He kept his voice level, the way he kept his hand level on the stone.

"I want," Tanaka said, "for you to do your test first. Then I will tell you what I want." She almost smiled. "I have read about your crew. You break things to find out how they were made. So break something."

The breaking — the potato — they did the next morning, in shallow water off the harbour, on a slab of the same Yaeyama sandstone that Tanaka pointed them to with the resignation of a teacher handing out a problem she already knew the answer to.

The ND lead did it. This was their hour, and the rest of the crew got out of the light. They had a flat chisel and a wooden mallet and a slate to score along, and the simple, dead-straight goal of cutting one clean right-angled step into the stone — one riser, one tread, the corner sharp — to match the corners the believers swore were carved.

It is harder than it has any business being. Pieter logged it minute by minute. Sandstone is not granite; it doesn't fight you. It *crumbles*, which is worse. The chisel bit and the rock didn't part along a line, it parted along its own lines — the bedding it remembered from twenty million years ago, the grain it had been waiting to follow. The ND lead chased a straight edge and the stone gave them a curve. They scored deeper and the corner sheared off in a chunk that took a hand's-width of the tread with it. Underwater the work was slower, the mallet drag-heavy, the silt blooming up to hide the very cut they

were trying to read.

When they finished — when the air ran low and the light went sideways — they had a thing. It was a step, technically. It was rough as a healed scar, the corner blunt and ragged, the tread dished where the rock had popped out wrong, the whole of it announcing in every grain that a clumsy primate with a stick had been here and tried.

The ND lead surfaced and pulled the regulator and floated on their back a moment, looking at the sky, breathing.

“It feels wrong,” they said. “It feels — *worked*. You can feel my hand all over it. Every centimeter is a decision I made or a decision I lost. The terrace down there —” they tipped their head toward the deep water, toward the monument “— doesn’t feel like decisions. It feels like *agreement*. Like the stone and the sea agreed on something and that was that.”

Pieter logged it as: *Manual replication = rough; corner shear, tread dish; subject reports tactile signature of human work absent from monument*. Then, because he was honest, in the margin: *Subject is the best reader I have. This is not nothing*.

The fish-voice, from the boat: “So the lesson is the sea is a better stonemason than us. Comforting. I, too, would lose a chisel fight to the Pacific Ocean.”

Nobody argued.

But here is the hole, and Pieter wrote it last, and slowest, because it was the thing he could not make sit down.

He had his above-water analog. He had Sannin-dai in his book, seven risers and an eighty-eight-degree corner and not a tool mark in sight — Schoch’s argument standing up in the air for anyone to measure. The rock makes stairs. The rock makes flats. The rock makes right angles. All true. All logged. All real.

So that evening he sat on the harbour wall with his clipboard and the photographs the LENS had handed him, the dry prints still smelling of fixer, and he laid the above-water beside the below-water and did the one thing a recorder is for, which is to put the like things next to the like things and read the difference.

The above-water terraces were terraces. They were also small, and broken-edged, and rounded by weather, and they petered out — three risers, five, seven, then chaos, then a tumble of fallen block, the way natural fracturing does when you give it room and time. A staircase that started and lost its nerve.

The thing under the water did not lose its nerve.

The Main Terrace runs roughly a hundred and fifty meters long and forty wide. That is not a number you measure with a tape over lunch; that is a number you measure with a survey, and the surveys agree on the order of it. A hundred and fifty meters of flat, with steps that hold their line, with corners that keep being corners step after step after step — at a scale, and with a consistency, that the cliffs above the tide line simply do not produce. Pieter had walked the cliffs all day looking for the above-water match, the natural formation that would let him close the book and say *see, it's just bigger underwater, that's all*. He had found stone doing every individual thing the monument did. He had not found stone doing all of them at once, that clean, that vast, in one place.

That was the gap. Not a tool mark — there are no confirmed tool marks, and he was not about to invent one. Not an inscription — Kimura saw inscriptions; the peer-reviewed literature did not. The gap was *negative*, which is the hardest kind to hold: nobody, in decades, had produced the above-water natural formation that matched Yonaguni for geometry *and* scale at once. The believers couldn't show you the chisel. The skeptics couldn't show you the twin.

He wrote it down exactly, because it was real and because it was checkable and because it was not his to resolve: *Above-water analogs reproduce every feature individually. None reproduces all features at this scale in one formation. The match is absent. Cited: no equivalent published.*

Then he sat there with the photographs in the dark and did not write anything for a while, which for Pieter was a kind of vertigo.

Tanaka came and sat beside him on the wall. She had a flask of something hot and she poured him a cup of it without asking, which

is how you know someone has decided you are all right.

"You found the cliffs," she said.

"I found everything," Pieter said. "Every piece. Separately."

"Yes."

"And not the one place where it all happens together. Above water."

Tanaka looked out at the dark sea where the monument was, twenty-five meters down, holding its line.

"My teacher used to say," she said, "that the island is honest. It does not lie to you. It only refuses to tell you the part you most want to know." She capped the flask. "You did your test. Tomorrow I will show you the currents, how the stone and the water work — and you will see things that could go either way, and I will not tell you which way. Not yet."

"Why not yet?"

"Because the survey people," Tanaka said, and now there was iron in it, the protective iron Pieter had heard under everything she'd said all day, "want to come and measure it once, fast, and write *natural* or write *artifact* on a form and lock the boats and call it documented. And then it is finished. Then it is a fact and not a place." She stood. "I will tell you what it is for when I am sure you can hold the not-knowing without dropping it. Most people can't. They reach for the answer and squeeze the wonder right out of it."

She went up the harbour toward the lights of the town.

Pieter looked at his clipboard. Under the last line he had written — *the match is absent* — he added the time, because he always added the time. Then he sat a while longer in the dark, holding the not-knowing, testing whether he could.

It was heavier than the tape measure. It did not ring under the heel. But he found, to his own surprise, that he had not dropped it yet.

Chapter 9 — The Official Arguments

The rain came in off the East China Sea the way it always did on Yonaguni, sideways and warm, and it drummed the corrugated roof of the dive shed until the whole building hummed like the inside of a kettle. Somebody had pulled the long folding table into the middle of the concrete floor and somebody else had taped a tarp over the worst of the leaks, and now there were photographs everywhere — fanned across the table, clipped to a wire run between two posts, stacked in damp piles that curled at the corners. The smell was rubber and salt and instant coffee.

Maren sat at the head of the table with her hands flat on the wood, reading the grain of it through her fingertips because the photographs were too loud to look at all at once. That was the thing nobody warned you about pictures of Yonaguni. They came in two flavors. Half of them looked like a quarry. The other half looked like a cliff. And the maddening part was that they were photographs of the same stone.

“Right,” said Toby from behind the camera tripod, which he had set up to film the table even though nobody had asked him to and nobody, anymore, told him to stop. “Whose case do we want to wreck first.”

“Nobody’s,” Jakobus said.

He was standing a little apart, near the open shed door where the gray light came in, one shoulder against the post and his arms folded, watching the table the way he watched everything — like it might be a made thing and he was waiting to be introduced. He had a coffee he wasn’t drinking. He never drank the coffee. Maren had decided,

weeks ago, that the coffee was a prop, a thing for his hands, the way other people had cigarettes.

“We do them both,” he said. “Straight. Full marks. You want to find the hole in a thing, you build the thing right first. A man who only knows half the argument doesn’t get to be skeptical. He just gets to be loud.”

Saki Tanaka was at the far end of the table, and she had not sat down. She had her wetsuit peeled to the waist and a towel over her shoulders and she was looking at the photographs upside-down from where she stood, which Maren had noticed she did on purpose, because she said you saw the lines and not the story when the picture was the wrong way up. She didn’t say anything. She rarely said anything when the crew started talking. She just watched, the way you watch a guest pick up something fragile in your house.

“Kimura first,” Maren said. “He’s the believer. Give him the floor.”

Toby reached across and pulled a particular photograph to the center. The Main Terrace. Even Maren, who distrusted her own eyes here, felt the small lurch she felt every time. The thing was *flat*. Not flat the way a hillside is roughly flat — flat the way a table is flat, a great broad shelf of sandstone running off into the green dark, and at its far edge a riser, and below that another shelf, and below that another. Steps. The eye could not be talked out of the word. Steps.

“Masaaki Kimura,” Toby said, in the radio-announcer voice he used when he was being careful. “Marine geologist, University of the Ryukyus. Dives the site since the late eighties. He has mapped it more thoroughly than anyone alive. And he reads it as built.” He tapped the riser. “His case isn’t *vibes*. He’s got specifics. Right-angled corners that meet clean. Terraces at consistent levels, like courses. A feature he calls a road, running parallel to the structure. Pairs of features that mirror each other across an axis — which nature doesn’t usually bother to do. And he points at the holes.”

“Post holes,” said Priya, the recorder, who had her notebook out and her sample logs squared against the table edge, because chaos made her hands itch. “Round depressions he reads as cut, for posts. And what he describes as carvings. Faces. Animals. Inscriptions.”

“The reads aren’t confirmed,” Maren said. “Say that part.”

"The reads aren't confirmed," Priya repeated, without looking up. "Nobody's verified the inscriptions in peer review. Nobody's verified a tool mark. That's the whole — that's where we live. But he's not a crank. He's a credentialed geologist who has spent more hours on that stone than anyone in this room, and his read is *built*. You have to sit with that before you knock it down."

Or you could just knock it down, said the fish — which was the voice Toby used when he wasn't being careful, the dry one, the one that lived in the room like a heckler in a cheap seat. "Round holes, eh? You know what makes a round hole in sandstone, free of charge, no ancient labor involved—"

"We'll get to the natural case," Jakobus said mildly.

"I'm just saying. The sea's got a chisel and it never stops for lunch."

"We'll get to it."

Maren slid the terrace photograph toward herself and put two fingers on the cold flat of the printed step, which was absurd, you couldn't read a photograph, but her hands wanted to anyway. She'd had her actual hands on that actual riser four days ago. She closed her eyes and made herself remember it honestly, which was a discipline, because memory wanted to tidy.

The edge had been sharp. Sharper than stone underwater had any right to be, where everything gets fuzzed with growth and silt. She'd run a gloved thumb along it and felt the corner bite back, a long true line, and her whole body had wanted to shout *worked, worked, somebody worked this*. And then she had moved her hand half a meter to the left and the same edge had crumbled under her thumb into the unmistakable layered cleave of bedding plane, sheet lifting off sheet like the pages of a wet book, and her whole body had said, just as loud, *natural, natural, nobody touched this*. Same edge. Half a meter.

That was the thing. That was the thing she didn't have words for that wasn't either-or, and her wiring, which read worked-from-broken in the dark by touch alone and had never once led her wrong on a quarry floor or a temple wall, had come back from that dive without a verdict for the first time in her life. It hadn't felt like failure. It had felt like standing at a door that didn't open.

“Maren.” Saki, finally, from the far end. “Don’t trust your thumb here.”

Maren opened her eyes. “I know.”

“I mean it as a kindness.” The towel shifted. “Everyone who dives that stone brings a thumb that’s been right a thousand times. The stone doesn’t care about your thousand.”

“Schoch,” Toby said, into the small silence, and pulled the second pile to the center.

These were the cliff photographs. The above-water formations on the nearby islands, on Yonaguni itself — the same Yaeyama sandstone, the same Lower Miocene beds laid down twenty million years ago, broken in air where everyone could stand on it in the sun and watch how it broke. And it broke in steps. It broke in right angles. It broke into broad flat shelves with clean risers, all on its own, no diver, no chisel, because that was simply what this stone did when it fractured along its bedding planes and its vertical joints. Sandstone in parallel sheets, cracked by two sets of stresses at ninety degrees to each other, made *steps*. It made them in the air. It made them where you could prove it.

“Robert Schoch,” Toby said. “Geologist, Boston University. Dived the site himself. His read is natural, full stop. Bedding planes and vertical joints, two joint sets close to perpendicular, plus a few million years of earthquakes and tide doing the demolition. He points at the rock above water doing exactly the same trick. He points out there’s no unequivocal tool mark on the whole formation. And he points out the boring part that nobody wants to hear—”

“No culture,” Priya said. “Mainstream archaeology doesn’t know a Ryukyuan culture with the engineering to cut a hundred-and-fifty-meter terrace and the motive to put it underwater. Or to have it above water and then watch the sea take it, somewhere between two and ten thousand years ago, depending whose sea-level curve you trust. No tool kit found. No spoil. No quarry. No bodies, no pots, no fire pit. A city with nobody’s fingerprints on it.”

“That’s the killer,” Jakobus said quietly. He’d come a little off the post now, into the light. “Not the geometry. The *absence*. You build a thing this size, you leave a mess. Where a man works, a man drops things. Yonaguni’s got no broken chisels, no waste flakes, no off-

cuts, no half-finished corner he gave up on. The skeptic isn't saying *it looks natural*. He's saying *it looks unattended*. And built things are never unattended."

He let that hang. He was good at letting things hang. Saki was watching him now with something that wasn't quite agreement and wasn't quite argument, the look of someone watching a man do a thing well that she still wasn't going to be moved by.

"So that's Schoch," said Toby. "And it's a *good* case. It's not the lazy case. He's the one with the rock above water on his side. Nature's the simpler answer and she's got an alibi."

"Then why isn't it closed," Maren said.

The rain had eased. The drumming on the roof dropped to a patter and then to single fat drops, and in the new quiet the question sat on the table next to all the photographs and refused to pick a side.

"Because the believer's got the same alibi," Jakobus said. "Turn it around. Nature makes steps in this sandstone — granted, proven, above water, in the sun. But show me where she made *this*. This scale. This persistence of right angle over a hundred and fifty meters. This —" he touched the photograph of two paired features, the ones Kimura read as mirrored — "this *symmetry*. The skeptic says nature does steps. True. The believer says: show me nature doing *this much* of it, *this clean*, underwater, anywhere else on Earth. And the skeptic —" he spread one weathered hand, palm up, the coffee in the other still untouched — "can't. There's no second Yonaguni to point at. One of a kind cuts both ways. It's either the only natural formation like it, or it's the only structure like it. Either way it's the only one."

And either way somebody's wrong, said the fish, but it came out softer than usual. Even Toby's heckle had run into the wall.

"So there it is," Toby said, after a moment. "Two credentialed geologists. Both have dived it. Both have the receipts. One reads built, one reads broken, and there is no third paper, no clinching photograph, no smoking tool mark that walks into the room and ends the fight. The literature is split right down the middle and it has stayed split for going on forty years."

He turned the camera, slowly, to take in the whole table — the quarry pictures and the cliff pictures, side by side, irreconcilable.

“Dr. Tanaka.” He didn’t turn the lens on her; he’d learned that much. He left her out of frame, where she preferred to be. “You’ve dived it more than either of them, probably. You know that stone in the dark. Which is it?”

The drops had stopped. Out past the shed door the cloud was tearing open over the water and the light coming in went from gray to a thin moving gold, and it caught the wet edge of the table, and for a second every photograph had a line of brightness along its top like the rim of a step.

Saki picked up the Main Terrace photograph. She turned it the right way up, looked at it the way the believers wanted you to look at it, the steps marching down into green. Then she turned it over again, upside-down, and looked at it the way she always did, the lines and not the story. She put it down flat.

“You want me to choose,” she said.

“I want your read,” said Toby.

“My read is that you both want a small woman to settle a thing two famous men couldn’t, so you can write it down and go home.” She said it without heat, which was worse than heat. “Kimura is not a fool. I have stood on his maps underwater and they are honest maps. Schoch is not a fool. I have watched the stone above the water break in steps with my own eyes, in the rain, like today. They are both careful men and they are both telling the truth about what they saw. That is the part outsiders cannot hold. You want one of them lying. Neither of them is lying.”

“Then which—”

“I don’t choose.” She pulled the towel tighter. “I’ve dived that terrace four hundred times. Some days my hand says made. Some days the same hand, the same corner, says broken. You felt it, Maren. Half a meter and it flips. You think that’s your thumb failing. It isn’t. It’s the *stone*. The stone is telling the truth in both directions at once and it is not my job, and it was not Aratake’s job, and it is not yours, to make it shut up and pick.”

She looked at each of them in turn, and last of all at Jakobus, who had not asked the question and would not, and who inclined his head a centimeter, conceding the floor he had never tried to take.

“The split is real,” Saki said. “It is not a problem waiting for your clever to fix. It is the most honest thing on this island. You have come a very long way to be told there is no answer. So.” She put both hands flat on the photographs, made-and-broken under her palms together. “Welcome to Yonaguni.”

Outside, the rain came back — one slow line of it, walking in off the sea — and somewhere down by the harbor a boat engine turned over, and turned over, and turned over, and would not catch.

It was, Maren thought, a survey boat. They were taking advantage of the break in the weather. They were going out to read the stone too. And they had a deadline, and orders, and a verdict already filed somewhere in a building in Tokyo with a date on it, and they were not the kind of people who could stand at a door that didn't open and simply *stand* there, with the wonder of it, the way the woman at the head of the table did.

The engine caught. Maren listened to it pull away across the water, toward the steps that would not say whether they were steps, and she put her own hand back down on the cold printed line, and let it not know.

Chapter 10 — A Question of Function

The harbor at Yonaguni smells of diesel and bait and the particular iodine sweetness of the sea when it has been working at stone for a long time. By midmorning the survey team's tender was already out past the breakwater, a white hull pinned to the water like a thumb on a map, and the rest of us were ashore with nothing to do but watch the watchers.

I had been told to watch Jakobus, which is its own kind of assignment. He doesn't perform. He puts his hands in his pockets and lets a place talk to him, and if you crowd him he goes quiet in a way that makes you feel you've spoken too loud in a library.

He and Dr. Tanaka had fallen into step along the quay without anyone arranging it. She walked the way she dove — economical, no wasted motion, her weight always slightly forward as though the next step were downhill. She had a coil of frayed line over one shoulder she'd picked up off a bollard without seeming to decide to, and she worried at the frayed end with her thumbnail as she walked.

The fish — our dry one, the recorder's shadow, the voice that lives in the back of every boat — leaned on the gunwale of a dinghy and said, to no one, "Two grown adults are about to solve archaeology by walking slowly. I've seen this episode."

Nobody answered him. That's the trick with him. You don't.

Here is the official story, walked dead straight, because it deserves to be.

For nearly forty years the Yonaguni Monument has sat in the warm green-blue off the island's south coast and refused to settle the only argument anyone wants to have about it: did hands make it, or did the sea? You have two credentialed geologists with two whole careers and two whole reputations standing on opposite banks of the same fact. Masaaki Kimura of the University of the Ryukyus has spent decades down there with measuring tapes and a diver's patience, and he reads stairs. He reads terraces. He reads a worked thing — a platform, maybe a temple, maybe a town's worth of intention drowned by rising water some thousands of years ago when this corner of the world was last dry enough to walk on. He has published his maps. He has photographed what he calls steps and what he calls, more daringly, marks.

And across from him Robert Schoch of Boston University — no slouch, no debunker-for-hire, a man who has staked plenty of his own credibility on old stones being older than people like — dove the same site and came up reading sandstone. Lower Miocene sandstone, twenty million years laid down in beds, the kind of rock that cracks along its own grain in long flat sheets and clean vertical joints, that an earthquake will step for you and the tide will sweep clean. He points to the islands above water where the same beds make the same staircases in the daylight, no carvers required. He points to the thing nobody has ever managed to put on a peer-reviewed page: a tool mark that holds up.

That's the case. Both sides bring the receipts. Neither side can close the door. You can stand in that gap your whole life and the gap will outlast you.

I tell you all this so you understand what Tanaka did next, which was to ignore every word of it.

"You want to know who made it," she said to Jakobus. Not a question. She'd clearly had the conversation before, with better-funded men, and lost patience with it sometime in the previous century.

"No," Jakobus said.

She glanced sideways at him. The line stopped fraying under her thumb.

"Everyone wants to know who made it," she said.

"That's a museum question." He said it without heat. "Who, when, with what. You answer it and you put a card next to the glass and people walk past." He stopped at the edge of the quay where a flight of concrete steps went down into the water, slick with weed, the bottom three rungs lost in green. "I'd rather know what it's *for*."

"Same thing."

"Not at all the same thing." He nudged the top step with his boot, testing the weed. "A man can carve a step. The sea can crack a step. But a step is only a step because somebody, sometime, *went down it*. Or up it. The function is the part that doesn't care who you ask."

The fish, from the dinghy: "He's going to get a TED talk out of this and I'm going to row to Taiwan."

Tanaka almost smiled. She didn't give it to him fully. She turned the not-quite-smile out at the water instead, where the survey tender sat over the site like a held breath.

This is the potato of the chapter, and it's a quiet one. We'd already had the loud kind — the day before, three of us in the shallows with hammers and a slab of the local sandstone the harbor master let us scavenge, trying to chip ourselves a right angle. The ND lead had run their bare palm over our best effort afterward, eyes half-shut, reading it the way they read everything, by texture before judgment. Worked stone has a signature, they'd told us once — a bias, a directionality, the ghost of a tool's intention dragged across grain. Fractured stone has a different one — it goes where the rock wants, not where you want.

Our slab had gone where neither of us wanted. The angle came out ninety degrees the way a child draws a square: close enough to wound you, never clean. A potato. The sea, down at the monument, makes better corners than three adults with hammers and an afternoon.

But that's the shallow potato, the replication one. Here on the quay was the deep one, and Tanaka was the only person on the island who could serve it.

"You think function is easier," she said. "It's not. With *who made it* you at least know what you're failing to prove." She crouched at the top of the wet steps and laid her hand flat on the second one down, fingers in the green, and the gesture was so exactly the ND lead's gesture that I felt the back of my neck go cold. "Function you can't even fail honestly. Down there—" she tipped her chin at the water "—every feature is two things. The Trench is a quarry cut, or it's a joint the current widened. The terrace is a floor, or it's a bedding plane that calved. You read it as a *use* and you've already decided who used it."

"So don't decide," Jakobus said.

"Then you have nothing."

"Then you have the water." He crouched too, knees cracking, an older man's caution near a wet edge. "Tell me what the water does there. Not what it means. What it does."

She told him. And this is the part the survey team, with their grant and their archive boxes and their tidy mandate to *document*, will never put on a card, because it isn't a measurement.

She told him the current at the monument runs hard and it runs *cornered*. That the terraces don't just sit there being flat — they shed flow, they channel it, the long straight edge of the Main Terrace throws a sheet of water off its lip at slack tide like a weir does, and a diver who knows it can ride that shed instead of fighting it. That the right-angled rooms aren't still; they hold and turn the water so that even with the current screaming across the open faces you can hang in the lee of a corner and not move at all, and breathe, and look.

"You learn the monument as a *map of where the water lets you live*," she said. "Forty meters of it. Every diver here who's any good has it in their hands before they have it in their head. We don't dive a temple. We dive a set of places the sea agreed to leave a person."

Jakobus was very still.

"Now," she said, and the not-smile came back and this time it had teeth in it, "is that function? Did somebody build a thing whose corners hold a diver against a four-knot current? Or did the sea build the

corners and we just *use* them that way, the way you'd use a boulder for a bench?"

"Yes," Jakobus said.

"Yes which."

"Yes."

The fish, very quietly now, no longer heckling, just present: "...okay, that one landed."

The LENS had drifted up behind us at some point. They'd had the camera at their chest, not their eye, which for the LENS is a kind of weather report — the war-trained reflex to frame the danger and the beauty in the same rectangle, held in check, the lens pointed at the deck. They were listening. They lifted the body once toward Tanaka's hand on the green step and then, deliberately, let it down again. Some images you don't get to take. Some you understand you'd be stealing.

Tanaka noticed. She notices everything; she'd out-read the lot of us underwater and she out-read us here, on the dry stone, in the sun.

"You don't shoot it," she said to the LENS. Not accusing. Cataloguing.

"Not this," the LENS said.

She nodded, once, like a thing had been settled.

I want to be honest about the hole, because we are nothing if not honest about the hole.

Here it is, cold-eyed, no reaching: after almost four decades of diving, photographing, mapping, arguing, no one has produced a tool mark that survives independent peer review. Not Kimura, for all his hours. Nobody. And on the other shore — this is the part the debunk leaves open and walks away from — nobody has put another underwater sandstone formation of *this* size next to it, this geometric, this stepped, and said *there, see, the sea does this on its own, here's the twin*. The above-water lookalikes are smaller. The argument from analogy gets you partway across the gap and then the analogy runs

out of size and you're standing on the same edge as everyone else, with the same green water below you, and the case is exactly as open as it was in 1986 when a local diver named Kihachiro Aratake first swam over it looking for hammerhead sharks and found a staircase that may not be a staircase.

That's the whole hole. It is not a doorway to anything. It is a fact-shaped absence, citable, dated, real, and it does not close.

What Tanaka had done — and I didn't see it until later, walking it back — was decline to step into either side of the hole, and offer something else instead. Not *who made it*. Not even *is it made*. A use. A way the thing is held by the people who hold it, regardless of how it came to be holdable.

That's the function. And the function, as it turns out, does not answer the question. It opens a worse one.

"There's more," Tanaka said. She'd stood up. She was looking out at the survey tender again, at the white hull and the lock it represented, the polite well-funded outfit that wanted this whole live ambiguous thing pinned and labelled and *managed*, the legend filed under closed.

"More function," Jakobus said.

"Maybe." She rolled the frayed line off her shoulder and looked at it as if surprised to find it in her hand, then began, slowly, to splice it — fingers working without her eyes, the way you do a thing your hands learned before you were old. "When the fishermen go out past the point in bad light, what do you think they line up on?"

"The island," Jakobus said. "A peak. A notch."

"And in fog. And at night, before there were lights." Splice, tuck, pull. "Old knowledge says a place. A bearing. You sit your boat where two marks come together and you know where you are without seeing the shore." She looked up. "I'm not telling you the monument is that. I'm telling you it could *do* that. A long straight edge under shallow water, where the sea breaks different over it, where the color of the water changes — a fisherman five hundred years ago doesn't need to know who made it to read it. He needs it to be *there*, and *straight*, and *the*

same every time. Function doesn't care about origin. You said that. I'm agreeing with you. I'm just agreeing harder than you wanted."

"A sea-mark." Jakobus's voice had gone careful.

"A sea-mark. A meeting place — you say *come together where the water turns over the long stone* and everyone knows the spot, generation to generation, no card in a museum, no name carved, just *the place that stays put*. A memory you can stand on." She finished the splice and tested it, two hands pulling, the line holding. "Navigation. Meeting. Memory. Pick one. Pick all three. None of them tell you whether a hand made the edge or the sea did, and that—" she dropped the coil back on its bollard "—is exactly why I'll tell *you* and not them."

She tipped her head at the tender.

"They want the answer that closes it. *Made. Not made.* Either one lets them put the lid on. But a thing you *use* — you can't archive a use. It only exists while someone's doing it." She started walking again, down the quay, and we trailed after her like the line behind a boat. "Ask me what it's for and I'll tell you what we *do* with it. I won't tell you what it *is*. I can't. Nobody can. And the day somebody can—" she didn't slow down "—it stops being ours."

The fish said nothing at all.

Out past the breakwater the survey tender shifted on its mooring, swung its bow to the turning tide, and over the place where the long straight edge lies in the green the water did the thing it does at the turn — broke different, paled, drew a line on the surface you could steer by, the same line it has drawn every slack tide for longer than anyone has been alive to read it, for a use no one on this quay would name.

Tanaka watched it the way you watch a thing you've decided to keep.

"What's it for," Jakobus said, very low, not really asking now.

She didn't answer. She just kept walking toward the boats, into the work, and left the question standing where the water had drawn it.

Chapter 11 — Pressure Drop

The barometer in the harbor office had a crack across its glass, an old one, the kind that gets pointed at and laughed about and never replaced. The needle sat just left of CHANGE. Mara photographed it anyway — close, the crack catching the morning, the dust on the brass case, the little chalk marks where somebody had tracked the pressure by hand for years before the digital one arrived and made the practice sentimental rather than useful. She did this. Lowered the lens to the dead instruments, the things nobody else thought to look at, because they were quieter than people and held still and didn't ask her what she'd seen.

Through the window the survey team's boat was loading. Two cases an hour, by her count. She'd been counting since six.

The National Maritime Survey Unit had three vessels now where last week there'd been one. Their crates were the modular kind, foam-cut interiors, stenciled with a serial logic she'd read off enough crime scenes and aid convoys to recognize as a system built by people who never expected to be questioned. Polite people. The unit's lead, a young man named Endo with a clipboard he didn't need and used anyway, had waved at her across the dock that morning. A real wave. There was nothing to hate in him, which was the part Mara found hardest to photograph.

"They moved the closure up," Saki said.

She'd come in without the door announcing her, the way she did everything — currents and conversations both, arriving where she already was. She had a wetsuit pushed down to her waist, the arms knotted at the front, and her hair was wet at the ends from a dawn dive nobody had cleared with anyone.

“How far up,” Mara said.

“Tomorrow. Slack tide. After that the buoys go in and the permit becomes a thing you apply for in Naha and wait six months and get told no.”

Mara let the camera hang. “Tomorrow’s our window.”

“Tomorrow’s everyone’s window.” Saki looked at the cracked barometer like it owed her money. “There’s one slack-water gap with light enough to work the Main Terrace. Eleven-forty. They want it too. Endo asked me this morning, very nicely, whether my charter would mind shifting to the afternoon.”

“And you said.”

“I said the afternoon current runs three knots through the Trench and I don’t take guests into water that wants to fold them in half.” She found the kettle, shook it, set it back. “He wrote it down. He writes everything down. It’s how he makes a thing into a record and a record into a thing that already happened.”

The official story, said plainly, is generous to everyone and unkind to certainty.

In 1986 a local diver named Kihachiro Aratake went looking for hammerhead schools off the south coast of Yonaguni and found instead a wall of stone that ran straighter than stone usually bothers to. Sandstone — fine to medium grained, mudstone in the seams, all of it Lower Miocene Yaeyama Group, which is to say the rock itself is around twenty million years old and was laid down flat and patient long before anyone wondered about it. Sandstone of this kind splits the way a stale cake splits: along its beds, and along the vertical joints that crack down through them, and where bed meets joint you get corners. Right angles, even. Steps, if the geometry feels generous. Tide and earthquake do the housekeeping.

That’s the case Robert Schoch makes, and it is a good case, and the men who make it are not fools. They point at Yonaguni’s own coastline, above the water, where the same beds make the same terraces in the open air with no one to carve them. They point at the absence — no confirmed tool mark in the peer-reviewed literature, no cultural

layer, no midden, no abandoned chisel sulking in a crack. They say: when you have a hammer made of bedding planes, everything looks like a staircase.

And Masaaki Kimura, who has spent more hours over this rock than the rest of the argument combined, points at the Main Terrace. A hundred and fifty meters long. Forty wide. He maps the steps, the rooms with their right-angled corners, the Trench that runs parallel like a road that knew where it was going. He has photographs. He has a reading. He has never had the consensus, and he has never stopped diving.

Two credentialed geologists. Same stone. The line between them runs right down the middle of the water, and the water doesn't take sides.

Mara had read both papers on the boat over, in the order Olu the recorder had bound them, skeptic then believer then skeptic again, and she'd thought: *this is the rare honest fight*. Both men measuring. Neither lying. The hole sitting in the gap between them like something held in suspension, neither falling nor rising, just there.

She found Theo on the seawall, which was where the ND lead went when the day got too loud, and the day had been getting louder since the third survey boat arrived.

He had his hands flat on the concrete. Not gripping. Just reading it, the way he read everything, fingertips taking the temperature of a surface the rest of them only looked at. He didn't turn when she sat.

"They poured this in sections," he said. "You can feel the cold joints. Where one batch went off before the next came. Honest seams. Made things have honest seams." He pressed harder, as if to be sure. "That's the whole problem with down there."

"Tell me."

"Concrete tells you. Worked stone tells you. There's a —" he searched, and she watched him not find it, and let him not find it. "There's a confession in a made surface. Tool leaves itself behind. Even when you can't see the mark, the surface remembers being pushed. It's directional. It has a hand in it." He took his palm off the wall. "Down

there the edges are too clean to be careless and too dumb to be careful. I keep waiting for the confession and the stone just — looks at me.”

“Schoch would say that’s because there’s nothing to confess.”

“I know what Schoch would say. I’ve felt it. The bedding plane thing — it’s real. When I touched the long step on Tuesday it had that grain, that layered give, the way the rock split lazy along its own beds.” Theo turned to her finally, and his eyes had the particular trouble in them, the trouble of a sense that had never failed him failing now not because it was weak but because the world was genuinely ambiguous and would not be bullied into a verdict. “But the corner above it. Where the wall meets the floor of the room. I put two fingers in it and it was square. Not square-ish. Square. And the rock doesn’t owe me square.”

The fish-voice in him, the part that heckled when he got too earnest, surfaced dry. “Or the rock owes the whole human race a square corner and we’ve been weeping over it for a million years like it’s a miracle instead of just Tuesday’s geology.”

He almost smiled. It cost him something. “Tomorrow’s the last touch. If I can’t read it tomorrow I never read it. They close the door and I spend the rest of my life with a corner I can’t name.”

That was the weight. Not the mystery. The *missing* it. The specific grief of an instrument that knows it had one more chance to take the measurement and is about to lose the room.

They tried the potato again that afternoon, because Olu insisted, because the test deserved a fair last run and because all of them, Mara suspected, wanted something to do with their hands besides count crates.

The setup was honest. A block of the same sandstone — quarried, legally, from the island’s own beds, papers and all, Olu had the receipt photographed — sunk in three meters of sheltered water inside the breakwater. Saki had picked the spot for current. Theo went down with a hammer and a flat chisel and the simple, stupid, beautiful intention to carve a right angle by hand into wet stone, the way a believer’s ancient mason theoretically had.

Mara filmed it. She'd filmed a lot of things that didn't go the way the people doing them hoped.

The chisel skated. The wet rock didn't bite clean; it crumbled where it should have cut, and along the bedding it sheared in long lazy flakes that were *easier* than he wanted, that did half his work and the wrong half. He fought the grain. The grain won. After forty minutes underwater he surfaced with a block that had a thing on it you could call a corner the way you call a child's drawing of a horse a horse — because you love the child, not because you'd bet on it at the track.

It was a potato. It was always a potato.

"Rough," Theo said on the surface, spitting his reg, breathing hard. "Messy. Mine's got my whole arm in it. You can see where I slipped, where I dug in, where I lost my temper at minute thirty." He held the block up, sluicing. "It confesses. Look at it. It's *covered* in confession."

Saki took it from him. Turned it in her brown hands. Set her thumbnail along the so-called corner and looked at it the way she looked at everything, without hope or despair, just measurement.

"This is the thing nobody upstairs understands," she said. "You can't fake the clean one. We just proved you can't. Two thousand years ago, ten thousand, doesn't matter — a person with a tool makes *this*." She tapped the ruined corner. "Tired. Human. Full of slips." She looked south, toward where the Main Terrace lay under thirty feet of moving green. "And the sea makes the clean one. The sea has all the time and no temper and no arm. So when you go down there and find clean —" she handed the potato back, gently, like a thing that had earned respect by failing well — the clean *is* the argument for natural. That's what Schoch is really saying. The cleaner it gets, the less human it looks."

"Then why does Kimura look at the same clean and see a hand," Mara said.

"Because at some point clean stops being lazy and starts being *intended*. Because nature is clean by accident, in patches, and gives up. And down there it doesn't give up." Saki was quiet a moment. "I've dived it three hundred times. I still don't know which I'm looking at. That's not a confession of failure. That's the most honest

sentence I have.”

She would not be drawn further. That was hers to withhold and she withheld it, and Mara, who had spent a career pointing a lens at people’s worst and best moments and asking them to stay still for it, recognized the boundary and lowered the camera without being asked.

Endo came to the slip at dusk with two of his crew and a thermos and the clipboard, of course the clipboard.

“Dr. Tanaka.” A small bow. To Mara, a nod, photographer to documentarian, a kind of professional courtesy that made her teeth ache. “I wanted to tell you directly. The closure is confirmed for the day after tomorrow at dawn. The buoys arrive tonight.” He said it the way you’d report weather. “After installation, the site enters the archival protocol. Access by application.”

“You’re boxing it,” Saki said.

“We’re protecting it.” And the worst part was he believed it, you could see it, a young man who’d been told the legend was hurting the science and the tourists were hurting the stone and that order was a form of care. “There are people who dive this who shouldn’t. There are claims being made in the press — Atlantis, this and that. The monument deserves a clean record.”

“The monument deserves the truth,” Saki said. “And nobody has it. You’ll archive a question and stamp it answered.”

Endo wrote something down. Then he stopped writing and put the cap back on the pen, which Mara photographed without meaning to, the small surrender of a man caught between his orders and a thing he half-suspected was true. “The morning slack,” he said. “Eleven-forty. We’ve scheduled our final mapping pass.”

“So have I,” said Saki.

“There’s one window.”

“There’s one window.”

They looked at each other across the slip, two professionals who respected each other and wanted opposite things from the same forty

minutes of still water, and there was no villainy in it, which was somehow worse than villainy, which left nowhere clean to put the anger.

"I'll take the second half," Endo said at last. Quietly. "You take eleven-forty. We map after. The current will be turning by then but my people are good." He almost smiled. "And you said yourself you don't take guests into water that wants to fold them in half. I'm not a guest. It's our job to go where the water's bad."

He left the thermos on the bollard. A gift, or an apology, or a record of having been generous. Saki didn't touch it.

That night the buoy-boat ran its lights out past the breakwater, and Mara stood on the seawall where Theo had read the cold joints in the concrete and watched the survey vessel's wake unzip the black water and seal it again behind.

Theo came and stood beside her without his hands going to anything, which for him was a kind of stillness she'd learned to be glad of and afraid of in equal measure.

"Eleven-forty," he said. "How long's slack hold?"

"Saki says twenty minutes of real still. Maybe twenty-five." Mara watched the buoy lights diminish. "Then the Trench starts breathing."

"Twenty minutes to put my hand on a corner and find out whether the sea's a better mason than the whole of human history." He breathed out. The fish surfaced one last time, gentle now. "No pressure."

Below them, somewhere off the south coast, the Main Terrace lay in the dark holding its line straight as a held breath, a hundred and fifty meters of *maybe* under the moving sea, and it had held it for thousands of years and would hold it whether they read it or not, whether the buoys went in or not, whether the case was ever closed.

"One dive," Mara said.

"One dive," said Saki, from behind them, where she'd been the whole time, reading the water and the men with the lights and the pressure she could feel dropping behind the cracked glass in the office. "Get the gas sorted tonight. Sleep if you can." She turned to go,

then stopped, her face half-lit. “And Theo. Tomorrow. Whatever your hands tell you down there — if they tell you nothing, that’s not nothing. That’s the answer most days. Most days the honest thing is the corner you can’t name.”

She went up the slip into the dark, and the barometer in the office, had anyone been watching, slid one more degree toward STORM, and the door to the last dive stood open exactly the width of twenty minutes of still water.

Chapter 12 — Descent to the Trench

The water at slack tide goes still the way a held breath goes still — not empty, just waiting. Mara felt it on the back of her hands before she felt it anywhere else, that pause in the current the divers had been counting on all morning, the moment when Yonaguni stopped breathing long enough to let you in.

Tanaka rolled backward off the gunwale without a word. She didn't gear-check theatrically, didn't give the thumbs-up the way the survey divers did, all GoPro and procedure. She just went, and the sea took her, and by the time Mara's own mask cleared and the green-blue resolved into something she could read, Tanaka was already eight meters down and dropping like she had an appointment with the floor.

Mara followed. Behind her, the bubbles of the others — Devra with the slate strapped to her forearm, Hollis with the camera housing he treated like a sleeping animal, and somewhere up top, on the boat, Jakobus, who did not dive and had never pretended otherwise. *The road, not the lead*, he'd said that morning, handing her the spare reel like it was a baton. *I read what's on the table. Down there it's Saki's table.*

The light changed at twelve meters. It always did. The blue thickened and the edges came up out of it — and that was the thing, the thing the brochures and the cranks and Kimura and Schoch all agreed on before they agreed on nothing else: the edges. They came up *clean*. A terrace, broad and flat as a loading dock, and below it another, and below that the long fall of stacked steps the believers called a

staircase and the skeptics called bedding planes parted along their natural seams.

Could go either way, the fish said in her ear, the dry little voice she'd given the doubt years ago so it would stop sounding like her own. *Loading dock or landslide. Both real popular underwater.*

She put her glove on the lip of the first terrace.

This was the gift, if you wanted to call it that — and Mara had spent enough years being told it was a deficit that she'd learned to call it nothing at all, just *how I touch things*. Worked stone and fractured stone do not feel the same. A fracture has a memory of violence in it, a directionality, the stone parting the way it always wanted to part. A worked surface fights its own grain; you can feel the argument in it, the place where a hand overrode the rock's preference.

The lip under her glove felt like neither and both. It ran straight — genuinely, stubbornly straight, the kind of straight that made the back of her neck go cold — but when she dragged her fingertips along it, she got the long clean break of a bedding plane, sandstone shearing the way Yaeyama sandstone has been shearing for twenty million years, since before there was anyone with a chisel to argue with it.

She lifted her hand. Put it back down a meter along. Same.

See, said the fish, *that's the trick of it. The hole's not in the stone. The hole's in your hand.*

Tanaka had paused below her, hovering with that horizontal stillness divers spend a decade learning, finning so small it didn't show. She watched Mara's gloved hand on the terrace. Then she pointed — not at the lip, but down, into the long dark cut that ran parallel to the whole formation. The Trench. The Road. The feature the maps drew as a corridor and the geologists drew as a joint widened by the sea pulling out a softer layer.

They descended into it together.

The Trench is the place where the argument gets honest, because the Trench is where the monument stops being a postcard and starts being a *space*. It runs maybe ten meters wide in places, walls rising sheer on either side, and the light comes down it in shafts that move

when the surface moves. Marine life packs the edges — soft coral, the encrusting growth that makes every measurement a negotiation, the small fish that hang in the column and scatter when your bubbles reach them.

Devra worked the slate. She had a system: depth, heading, a quick sketch, a note on the encrustation because the encrustation was the thing everyone underplayed. *You can't read tool marks through forty years of coral*, she'd said on the boat, *and you can't prove there were never any, either. That's not a finding. That's a closed door someone painted to look like a wall.* She wrote it down now, the heading of the Trench, and beside it a single word Mara couldn't read upside-down but recognized by the shape: *straight*.

Hollis had stopped finning.

That was the tell with Hollis. The crew had learned it over four books — the moment he went still in the water and the camera came up slow, like he was lifting it against his own better judgment. He'd photographed worse than sunken rock. He'd photographed things that came back to find him at three in the morning, and the camera had been the only thing between him and them, the rectangle that turned a horror into a composition you could survive looking at. Down here there was no horror. Just a wall of sandstone too straight to be comfortable, going up into the green, and Hollis behind the housing, not pressing the shutter.

Tanaka touched his arm.

She didn't tell him to shoot. She put two fingers on the wall, just below where his lens was pointed, and held them there until he lowered the camera and looked at the wall instead of the picture of the wall. Then she moved on. It was the gentlest correction Mara had ever seen administered underwater, and Hollis followed her with the housing hanging at his side like a thing he'd forgotten he was carrying.

They came to the right-angled corner.

Here is the official story, told straight, the way it deserves to be told.

A man named Kihachiro Aratake — a local diver, looking for hammer-head grounds, not for Atlantis — found this in 1986, and the world

did what the world does. Kimura of the University of the Ryukyus came and mapped it and read in it a ceremonial platform, a temple, maybe a city; he saw stairs and terraces and what he believed were carvings, and he published, and he stood by it. Schoch of Boston University came and read the same stone and saw the Yaeyama Group doing exactly what sandstone does when it's faulted and jointed and worked over by earthquake and tide — flat fractures along the bedding, vertical fractures along the joints, the two intersecting at the angles that so unsettle the human eye because the human eye is built to find rectangles meaningful. He pointed to formations above water on the nearby islands, same rock, same angles, no diver required. He pointed to the absence — no confirmed tool mark in the peer-reviewed literature, no cultural layer, no proven hand.

Two credentialed geologists. Same stone. No consensus. Decades on, none.

That is not a failure of the experts. That is the most honest thing in this whole book. Both of them are looking at something real and refusing to lie about it, and the gap between them is not ignorance — it's the actual shape of what we know, which is: *we don't*.

The corner Tanaka had brought them to was the cleanest on the site.

Two faces of stone meeting at very near ninety degrees, the vertical wall and the horizontal terrace, and the edge between them ran true for longer than any edge has a right to run. Mara put both hands on it, one on each face, the way you'd hold a doorframe.

The vertical face read like a joint. Cold, clean, the parting-memory of stone that had sheared along a plane it was always going to shear along. Fine. Natural. The fish was satisfied.

The horizontal face read the same.

But the *edge* — the line where the two met — that was the place her gift went quiet. Because a joint and a bedding plane meeting at a right angle is just two natural surfaces happening to intersect; the corner itself isn't worked, it's a coincidence of geometry, the rock being the rock in two directions at once. She knew that. She'd read that on the boat, in Schoch's own words. And her hand, running the edge, wanted to agree.

It was just too long.

A natural corner is a corner for as far as the two planes happen to align, and then the alignment wanders, because nothing in fracture is committed to a heading. This edge did not wander. It held its line through the encrustation, through a dip where the terrace stepped, through three meters of green water, and it was still holding it when Mara ran out of arm.

Okay, said the fish, and for once it didn't have a follow-up.

They had tried, two days before, to make one of these.

Down in the test patch Tanaka had cleared for them — a slab of the same Yaeyama sandstone, broken loose and lying flat — Devra and Mara had spent a whole tide-window trying to cut a straight edge by hand. Not to fake the monument. To *understand* it. To put a chisel against this rock and feel what it would take.

It took everything and gave back a potato.

The sandstone didn't cut; it crumbled. It came away in lumps where you wanted a line and held stubborn where you wanted it to release, and the marine growth fought every stroke, and the visibility went to soup with the first cloud of silt, so that you were carving blind inside your own mess. After ninety minutes Mara had produced an edge that wandered like a drunk and a face like a chewed thumbnail. Worked stone fights its grain — and her edge had the fight in it, all right, every ugly indecisive millimeter of it. It read, unmistakably, as *made*. Because that's what made looks like, down here, with hands. Rough. Reluctant. Human.

The monument's edge did not read as made. It read as *decided*.

Which was, of course, exactly what the natural-origin argument predicted. Fracture is decisive. Fracture commits. A bedding plane doesn't agonize over its line the way a diver with a chisel does — it just goes, clean, the whole length of the bed at once. The cleanness was the *evidence for nature*, not against it. Mara knew this. She'd written it in her own notes. The potato proved the skeptics' point: a hand makes a mess, and this was no mess, therefore no hand.

And yet.

She hung at the corner with both gloves on the impossible edge and

could not make her body believe either thing, and that was the gift not failing but doing its actual job, which had never been to give answers. It was to feel the exact weight of not knowing, and to refuse to set it down early.

Tanaka was watching her again.

The Okinawan held position above the corner with the boat-time ticking somewhere in all their heads — slack wouldn't last, the current would come back like a closing hand, and up top the survey unit's RIB was already on the water, their schedule moved up *again*, their orders to document and archive and lock the legend in a box where it would stop embarrassing the maps. This was the crew's last window. Everyone in the water knew it.

Tanaka uncoiled and finned along the terrace, beckoning, and they went after her — past the corner, past the steps, to the long northern run of the Main Terrace where the formation's great straight margin lay.

A hundred and fifty meters. That was the published number, the Main Terrace, a hundred and fifty meters long and forty wide, and Tanaka took them along the edge of it the way you'd walk someone down a pier. She knew where the encrustation thinned. She knew which way the silt would drift if you breathed wrong. She'd been reading this stone since before any of them could spell Yaeyama, and she read it now without a single gesture toward proving anything, just *here, and here, and look at this*, a local showing visitors her own street.

She stopped at the far end and let them catch up and pointed down the length of the margin, back the way they'd come.

Mara turned and sighted along it.

A hundred and fifty meters of edge, running away from her into the green until the green ate it, and it did not bend. It did not wander. It held its line the whole impossible length, straighter than the terrace had any business being, straighter than fracture promised and straighter than hands could manage, and the two arguments she'd been carrying since the surface — *natural, decisive, clean as a joint* and *made, worked, fighting its grain* — both of them ran out of road

at exactly the same place, somewhere out in the water where the line went on being straight after every reason she had for it had stopped.

Beside her, Hollis raised the camera.

This time he didn't lower it. He sighted down the long margin the way Mara was sighting down it, and the shutter went, once, and Mara understood that he wasn't taking a picture of the answer. There wasn't one. He was taking a picture of the question — the whole hundred and fifty meters of it — because the question was the most beautiful and most unbearable thing in the water, and the camera was finally, for once, the right tool for what was actually there.

Tanaka watched the line too. Her face behind the mask gave nothing. She had not yet said what it was for. She had not yet said whether it was *for* anything. She held that — the last word, the local's word — the way she held her trim, without apparent effort and without any intention of letting go before she chose to.

The current shifted in Mara's ear, the first faint pull of the sea waking up.

The straight edge ran on into the green, and did not stop, and did not explain itself, and the four of them hung above it in the failing slack, and out beyond the line, just past where the water turned everything to nothing, there was the place where the answer would have been, if there had been one.

Mara put her glove back on the margin.

It ran straight under her hand, all the way to the end of her reach, and then further, and she had no way at all to know which thing she was touching.

Chapter 13 — The Hole

Slack tide came at 9:14, and for eleven minutes the sea forgot to push.

Mara dropped through it like falling into held breath. The green went to blue went to a deeper blue, and then the Main Terrace came up under her the way a floor comes up when you've misjudged the last stair — all at once, flat, and far too sure of itself. A hundred and fifty meters of it, give or take, fading off into the silt-haze where her light gave out. Forty wide. She knew the numbers. The numbers were on a card in a dry bag on the boat. The numbers did not prepare you for lying face-down over the thing in twenty meters of water while a parrotfish the size of a toddler ignored you completely.

She put her glove on the edge.

That was the job, the only job her hands had ever been good for. Worked or broken. Chisel or weather. She'd done it on a thousand surfaces — Petra, a quarry outside Carrara, a fake Roman wall in a museum basement that had fooled three curators and not her left thumb. Stone fractured along a plane felt one way under the fingertips: a grain, a memory of the direction it tore. Stone *worked* felt like an argument someone had won — a flatness that disagreed with the rock around it.

This edge.

This edge ran straight under her glove for longer than straight had any right to last, and at the end of it, it turned. Ninety degrees. Or close enough that her hand wanted to call it ninety and her training told her hands they were not allowed to want things.

"Tell her it's a corner," came Devin's voice in her ear, tinny through

the comms, the dry one, the fish. “*Tell her the sea made a corner and went, eh, good enough, knock off early.*”

“Quiet on the line,” said Theo — the recorder, methodical, logging depth and time and the angle of her tank. Nobody listened. The fish never stopped and Theo never stopped telling it to stop and that was the engine that kept the rest of them breathing evenly down here.

The official story, for the record, is two stories, and they are both wearing lab coats.

Story one belongs, broadly, to Masaaki Kimura of the University of the Ryukyus, who has been mapping this formation since the late eighties and reads it the way you’d read a ruin: stairs, terraces, a ceremonial platform, the bones of something somebody built when this rock was dry land — two thousand, five thousand, ten thousand years back, the date a moving target depending on whose sea-level curve you trust. He’s published maps. He’s logged what he calls steps and what he calls carvings. He is a credentialed man who looked at this and saw a hand.

Story two belongs, broadly, to Robert Schoch of Boston University and to most of the room, who looked at the same rock and saw the rock. Lower Miocene sandstone, the Yaeyama Group, twenty million years of layering laid down flat and shot through with vertical joints. Sandstone like this *fractures* in planes and right angles. It does it on Yonaguni above the waterline, where you can walk it dry — go look, they say, go look at the cliffs, the sea didn’t carve those, the rock just *is* that. Add earthquakes. Add a few thousand years of current grinding the loose stuff out of the cracks. You get terraces. You get steps. You get a ninety-degree corner because the sandstone was always going to give you a ninety-degree corner.

Both of them are serious people. Neither of them is a crank. That is the part the documentaries always rush past, and it’s the only part that matters: the split is *real*, and it runs straight down the middle of the qualified, and it has not closed in nearly forty years.

Mara floated over the seam between their two stories and could not, with her hand, with her hand that had never once been wrong about Carrara, tell which one was lying to her.

Saki came down the water column slow, the way locals come down, no kicking, just letting weight and breath do the descending. She'd told them this morning, on the boat, in the flat voice she used when she'd said a thing four hundred times: *I'm not going to tell you what it is. I'm going to show you what the water does. You decide what that makes it.*

She settled beside Mara without disturbing a grain of silt. That alone was a kind of out-reading — Mara had watched the survey team's divers all week, government-funded, well-kitted, kicking up clouds wherever they went, boxing samples like men late for a train. Saki moved through the place like she owed it manners.

She pointed at the corner. Then she pointed at the joint that ran up the back of the terrace wall, a clean vertical line, and traced it with one finger — not touching, hovering — up to where it met the horizontal bedding plane. She tapped twice in the water. *There. That's the recipe.* Vertical joint meets horizontal bed. Sea pulls the corner out. No mystery.

Mara nodded. She believed her. That was the maddening thing. She put her hand back on the corner and she believed every word Saki hadn't said, and her hand kept disagreeing anyway.

She unclipped the slate and wrote: *TOOL MARKS?*

Saki took the slate. Looked at the corner a long time — longer than agreement takes. Then she shook her head. One slow shake. And under Mara's word she wrote one of her own: *NONE.*

Then, after a pause Mara felt more than saw, Saki added a second line, smaller: *kimura says yes. nobody has shown me.*

Here is the potato, and it had happened the day before, and it still itched.

They'd found a slab of the same Yaeyama sandstone, broken off and tumbled into the trench feature — the long parallel cut they call the Road, which is either a quarried passage or a slumped block depending on which lab coat you've been listening to. Theo had it on film. Mara had taken a flat chisel and a hammer the LENS had wrapped in

dive tape to keep the head from glinting, and she had tried, in nine meters of water with the tide turning, to put a clean right angle into rock that everyone agreed could *make* clean right angles all by itself.

It came out a potato.

It came out the way it always comes out: a face that wanted to be flat and went lumpy at the heart of it, an edge that started crisp and crumbled where the grain decided otherwise, a corner that was a corner the way a drunk man's signature is a signature. The sandstone fought the chisel and then it just *gave*, all wrong, sloughing off in handfuls instead of cleaving. Underwater you couldn't even swing right. Buoyancy ate the blow. By the end of it she'd produced a sad rounded gouge and a cloud of silt and a profound new respect for anyone who'd ever claimed people did this here on purpose.

"Behold," Devin had said, "the lost temple of Lumpyatlan."

And the joke landed, because that was the case for the sea — that a human with a chisel makes a potato, and the ocean, given a few millennia and the right rock, makes *this*. The Carrara test, run backward. The sea is the better mason. Every diver who's ever tried to copy Yonaguni by hand has come up holding a potato, and that is the single strongest argument the natural camp has, and it is a *good* one.

So the corner under Mara's glove should have been a relief. See? *Nature did it. Your chisel proves nature did it.*

Except.

She found the hole at minute six of the eleven, and she found it the way you find a step missing in the dark.

She'd been running her hand along the top tread of the big terrace, the one Kimura calls a stair, the long shelf where the whole argument lives. And she came to the riser — the vertical face dropping to the tread below — and she laid her palm flat against it, and her hand stopped lying to her for exactly one second and told her the truth, which was that it didn't know.

The riser was flat. Not flattish. Not flat-for-nature. Flat the way the corner was square — past the point where her thumb would forgive it.

And there was no grain in it. That was the thing she couldn't get past. A fracture face has a *direction*, a tear-memory, the rock remembering which way it came apart. Worked stone has tool-memory, the scallop-track of whatever bit it. This face had neither. It was just *flat*, blank, mute, a surface with no story about how it got that way, and surfaces always have a story, that was the one law her whole gift was built on, surfaces *always* have a story —

She pulled her hand back like it had gone hot.

"*You good?*" Devin, not joking now. The fish could read a heart rate through a regulator.

She wrote on the slate, fast, ugly letters: *NO MARKS. NO GRAIN. TOO STRAIGHT.* And then, because she had to put it somewhere: *I CANT READ IT.*

She turned the slate to Saki.

And this — this was the moment the whole week had been swimming toward, and Mara would carry the next four seconds for the rest of her life. Because Saki read the slate. And Saki looked at the riser. And Saki, who owned this water, who out-read the survey team and the crew and probably Kimura too, who had logged ten thousand hours over this stone — Saki did not nod and did not shake her head.

She just looked at it. The way you look at a person you've known forty years and still don't fully have.

Then she took the slate back and wrote, and her letters were as steady as ever, no faster, no slower: *me neither. forty years. me neither.*

That should not have been a comfort. It was the only comfort going.

Because here is the actual hole, the checkable one, the one that survives the documentaries and the survey team and the cold morning when you've had coffee and you're no longer dazzled: after nearly four decades of credentialed people diving this exact terrace, *nobody has published a confirmed tool mark.* Not Kimura, not for want of looking and saying so. The marks he reports have never been verified in independent peer-reviewed work. That door is shut. The man-made case has no signature.

And on the other side of the same hole: *nobody has produced another underwater formation anywhere of this size, this flat, this geometric, that everyone agrees nature made alone.* The cliffs above the water-line are the natural camp's best receipt and they are real and they are right-angled — but they are not a hundred and fifty meters of terrace with risers a hand can't read. The natural case explains every individual feature and has never had to defend the *whole*, all at once, at scale, in one place. That door is shut too.

So you've got a riser that no chisel has touched, that no grain explains, that the best diver in the water has spent forty years not being able to call. Both expert camps walk right up to this terrace and both of them have to leave the same way they came: with a strong argument and no proof. The potato says *people can't*. The blank flat face says *nature didn't show its work*. And the gap between those two is exactly the width of one terrace step, and that is where Yonaguni lives, and it has lived there the whole time, and nobody put it there. The sea did. Or somebody did. That's the sentence. That's the whole sentence and it doesn't have an end.

The tide turned at 9:25. They always know before the watch tells them — the water remembers it has somewhere to be, and a thread of current came combing through the trench, lifting the silt, turning the blue grainy.

Saki tapped Mara's arm. *Up*. Past her shoulder, off at the limit of the green, Mara could see the survey team's down-line, a yellow rope going up to a hull that had no business being over the site during a slack window that was supposed to be theirs. Boxing the place up. Closing the door from the surface while the sea closed it from below.

The LENS hadn't shot a frame in four minutes. Mara only noticed now. He was just over the terrace, both hands off the camera, letting it hang on its strap, looking at the corner the way Saki had looked at the riser. For once he'd lowered it without being asked. Whatever he was seeing, the picture wasn't going to hold it, and he'd stopped pretending it would.

Mara put her glove on the riser one last time, on the flat that wouldn't tell her, and she let it stay there while the current built. Her gift had run all the way to the end of itself and found a wall, and the wall was

not a failure of the gift. That was the part she'd take up with her. The not-knowing was the *reading*. The honest answer her hand had given was *maybe* — and *maybe*, here, was not the place where her hand had failed. It was the deepest true thing the stone had to say.

She lifted her palm. The flat held its silence. Twenty million years of it, or ten thousand, or none.

Above them the yellow rope was hauling its boxes toward a daylight that thought it had the answer. Down here, in the last clean minute before the sea took the place back, the riser kept its.

Saki gave the signal. They went up slow, the way you go up when you're leaving somewhere that out-read you, and didn't gloat, and let you go.

Chapter 14 — The Adversary Locks Down

The sea spat them out into a different morning than the one they'd left.

When Mara broke the surface she was still half-down in it, still feeling the cold under her palms where the Main Terrace had run flat and stupid-straight beneath her gloves, that long unbroken edge that her hands kept insisting was a decision and not an accident. She came up arguing with herself. She came up to a boat that wasn't only their boat anymore.

There were three of them now, riding the slack-tide chop off the harbor mouth, and two of the three flew the pale blue pennant of the National Maritime Survey Unit. They'd come around the headland while the crew was at twenty meters, which was a thing you could do politely, with paperwork, and they had.

"Easy," Saki said, beside her in the water. She'd surfaced clean and quiet the way she did everything, no splash, her reg already out and hooked over her shoulder. She wasn't looking at Mara. She was reading the boats. "Let me go up first."

The fish — Dev, bobbing ten feet off with his mask shoved up onto his forehead and his snorkel still trailing a string of spit — said, "Oh good, the men with clipboards have arrived to save us from our fun."

"Dev."

"I'm just saying. Nobody ever shows up in matching windbreakers to *open* a thing."

The survey lead came to the rail of his boat as they hauled aboard their own. His name was Higa; he'd told them three days ago, over a too-careful cup of coffee at the dive shop, and he'd been nothing but courteous since. He was courteous now. That was the part that got under your skin. He wore the kind of mild, tired face you'd trust to mind your bags at a station, and he held a laminated sheet in both hands like it was warm and he wanted them to have it.

"Tanaka-sensei," he said first — to Saki, in Japanese, with a small bow she returned shorter — and then in English, for the rest of them, because that was the courtesy too. "Good dive?"

Nobody answered. Lin, their recorder, was already cradling the sample case to her chest, unconsciously, the way you hold a thing you've just been told you can't keep.

"As of this morning," Higa said, "the Monument and the waters within four hundred meters are designated under temporary survey protection. Documentation and archival work begins today. The area is closed to recreational and independent diving until the survey concludes." He turned the laminated sheet so they could read it. It was bilingual. It had a stamp. It had a map with a red ring drawn around everything that mattered. "I am sorry to give you this news at the rail. I would rather have given it over coffee."

"How long," Mara said.

"The survey is scheduled for eighteen months."

Dev laughed once, sharp, like a cough. "Eighteen months. To photograph some rocks."

"To document," Higa corrected, and there it was — the one word doing all the work, *document*, smooth as the terrace edge, smooth as a thing you could not get your nail under. "Catalogue. Establish the geological record. Make a complete archive." He spread his hands. The gesture was almost gentle. "After that, decisions about access will be made by the prefecture. With consultation."

That was the part that ought to have been reassuring and wasn't. A *complete archive*. Mara thought of the case Lin was holding, the chips of Yaeyama sandstone they'd knocked off a dead corner with the survey crew's own permitted hammer, the chips that were supposed to settle it and hadn't, the chips that looked like every other

handful of broken sandstone on every other above-water headland in the Ryukyus. You could build a complete archive of those. You could fill eighteen months. And at the end you'd have a beautiful, exhaustive, peer-reviewable record of a question, and the question would still be standing right where it had always stood, on the last step, in the green dark, with the current running through it.

Here is the thing they want you to understand about the survey, and it is true, and you should sit in it before you reach for the wink: it is good science. That ring on the map is not a conspiracy. Higa is not a cabal. He is a civil servant with a budget and a mandate and a real, defensible fear that some YouTube outfit will pry an "inscription" off the Trench wall with a screwdriver and sell it as the keys to Atlantis. Closing the site protects the site. The marine encrustation alone — the coral, the soft sponge, the algal mat that furs every edge and blurs every angle into maybe — degrades a little more with every careless fin-kick, every glove dragged across stone to feel whether it was worked or only broken. The crew had done exactly that, all week, with permission. The survey isn't wrong to want the kicking to stop.

Play it straight. Higa's outfit will produce, in eighteen months, the single most thorough record of the Yonaguni Monument that has ever existed. Bathymetric scans to the centimeter. Photogrammetry that builds the whole Main Terrace in a computer so you can spin it in your hand. Core samples logged and curated. It will be magnificent work, and the people doing it will love this stone in the only way they're allowed to love it, which is precisely and on the record.

It just won't answer the question. It *can't*. That's the part nobody at the rail was saying out loud.

"We have one more window," Lin said. Her voice came out steadier than her hands. "We scheduled it. Tomorrow's slack, before noon, you signed off on it three days ago—"

"That permission is withdrawn as of this notice," Higa said, and to his credit he didn't look away when he said it. "I am sorry. The protection supersedes prior approvals. This is in the document."

"It's in the document," Dev echoed flatly.

Beside Mara, the LENS hadn't said a word the whole time. He never did when there was something to shoot. He'd already had the long

lens up at the boats before they were fully aboard, working, his eye gone somewhere none of them could follow — the place he went where the windbreaker pennant and the laminated sheet and the red ring all became light and edge and weight, became an image he could hold instead of a loss he had to feel. He'd shot the harbor at dawn and the wave-curl over the Trench from twenty meters down and Saki's hands on the stone, and now he turned the camera onto Higa's boat and the men unloading the gray pelican cases that would hold the cores, and he framed and he framed.

"Sir," one of the survey crew said. Younger. Polite, like all of them, mortified to be doing it. "I'm sorry, sir. No photography of the survey operation."

The LENS didn't lower the camera. He didn't seem to hear, or he heard and the hearing didn't reach his hands.

"Sir." The young man had stepped to the gunwale of the survey boat now, near enough across the gap that you could see the apology and the firmness both fighting on his face. "Survey protocol. No imaging of equipment or personnel. I have to ask you to stop."

The shutter went again, that small mechanical bite, twice, three times. The man on the terrace, Mara thought, watching him — because that's what he was, even up here, he was always on a terrace somewhere, in a city that no longer existed, behind a lens that had let him survive it by turning blood into composition. He had to lower the camera and he couldn't, and watching him fail to was its own kind of looking-away, and she made herself look at it because somebody on this boat ought to.

It was Saki who reached over and put her hand flat on the top of his lens. Not grabbing it. Just resting there, warm, the way she'd rested her reg on her shoulder.

"That's enough now," she said. Quiet. Not unkind. "You've got it. You got it days ago."

The LENS came back from wherever he was. You could see it land in his eyes — the boat, the morning, the gray cases, the woman with her hand on his glass. He lowered the camera. His jaw worked. He nodded, once, at the young surveyor across the water, and the young surveyor nodded back, both of them ashamed of their jobs for a sec-

ond and then not, and the moment passed, and the camera hung at the LENS's chest pointing at the deck.

"Sorry," he said, to no one, to everyone.

"Don't be," Saki said, and took her hand back.

Higa had watched all of it with the patience of a man who'd run this scene before, on other boats, over other closing doors. When it was done he turned, very deliberately, to Saki — not to Lin who held the samples, not to Mara who'd surfaced still arguing, not to the LENS or the fish. To Saki. He spoke to her in Japanese, low, and she answered shorter, and whatever passed between them was the only conversation on the water that actually mattered, and the crew couldn't follow a word of it.

That was the thing they'd learned all week and were learning again now, harder. They owned the telling. They'd come to read these stones and write them down and they were good at it, the best, Mara's hands and the LENS's eye and Lin's discipline and Dev's heckling that kept them all honest. But the place wasn't theirs and the door wasn't theirs to hold open or shut. The door belonged to the people who lived above it. And when the government boat came to close the door, it didn't come to the crew. It came to Saki. It asked Saki. Higa had bowed to *her* first, before the coffee speech, before the laminated sheet — because on Yonaguni the question of who reads this water has one answer, and it has had that answer since long before a diver named Aratake found a flat ledge in 1986 and before any of them were born, and the answer is not, and was never going to be, *the visitors*.

Saki listened to all of it. Then she said something final-sounding, and Higa bowed again, and that was that.

"He's right," she said, turning back to the crew, switching to English without ceremony. "About the protection. I'd have signed it myself if they'd asked me, and they did ask me." She let that sit. "I told them yes."

Dev opened his mouth. Closed it.

"You—" Lin started.

"You came to read it," Saki said. "You read it honestly, which is more

than most. You couldn't close it and neither could I and neither will they, eighteen months or eighteen years." She wasn't apologizing. She had nothing to apologize for; it was her water. "The stone's been down there twenty million years and underwater for some thousands of them, and it'll keep its mouth shut a while longer with a red ring around it. That's all the ring is. It's not a verdict. Kimura doesn't get the last word and Schoch doesn't get the last word and a survey team with a centimeter scanner doesn't get the last word." Something almost moved at the corner of her mouth. "Down here we're a little more comfortable than you are with nobody getting the last word."

"That's not science," Dev said, but gently. "That's a koan."

"It's geology," Saki said. "On a good day they're the same thing."

The fish had nothing for that. The fish, for once, looked at the water.

The survey boats began their work behind them, unhurried, lowering a frame of instruments on a line, the gray cases open on the deck and waiting. Real work. Honest work. The kind that would fill a binder and never fill the hole. Somewhere down there, under the line they were lowering, the Main Terrace ran a hundred and fifty meters out and forty across with that long flat edge that Mara's hands would not stop describing as a decision — too clean for what Schoch's people said it was, too featureless of any tool mark for what Kimura's people said it was, sitting in the gap between two credentialed certainties like a stone wedged in a crack it was too big and too smooth to have rolled into by chance, and too unmarked to swear any hand had set there.

Mara peeled off her glove and looked at her own palm, ridged white from the water, and thought about how it had felt under there an hour ago, and how it still didn't know.

"One window," Lin said again, quietly, mostly to herself, putting it down for the record the way she put everything down. "We had one more window."

"We had this morning," the LENS said. His voice was rough. He lifted the camera off his chest and looked at it, at the back screen, at whatever he'd caught before the hand came down on the glass. "I had this morning."

He turned the screen so Mara could see it.

The last frame before Saki stopped him wasn't the cases or the pennant or Higa's mild official face. He'd panned past all of that. The last frame was the water itself, the slack tide gone glassy over the closed site, the morning light going straight down into green-blue and not coming back, the surface holding the whole sky and giving up nothing of what lay underneath it.

The boat's engine turned over. Saki took the wheel; nobody questioned that either. She brought them around in a slow arc, away from the gray boats and the red ring and the eighteen months, and pointed the bow at the harbor.

Behind them the survey's instrument frame went under and the line paid out and the sea closed over it, smooth, unmarked, keeping its own counsel the way it had kept it through Miocene and earthquake and the slow drowning of whatever this was, made or not, the way it would keep it through the binder and the scan and the centimeter and out the far end of all that careful looking.

The chase was over. They'd lost it the way you lose a thing that was never yours to win.

What they hadn't lost — what Mara would only understand later, when Saki finally turned at the dock and held the wheel a second longer than she needed to, and looked at the four of them, and seemed to be deciding something — was the door behind the door. The one Higa's ring didn't reach. The one only Saki could open, and only if she chose, and only for what it was for.

She killed the engine. The hull bumped the fenders. She didn't get up.

"Come to the shop tonight," she said. "After they've packed up. I want to show you something nobody's putting in a binder."

Chapter 15 — The Choice to Respect

The kitchen of the dive house smelled of instant coffee and neoprene that would never fully dry. Outside, the harbor lights jittered on black water, and somewhere past them, under five to twenty-five meters of sea, the Monument sat in its dark doing whatever it had been doing for however long — twenty million years if you asked the sandstone, two to ten thousand if you asked the question everybody actually came here to ask.

Mara had the survey schedule taped to the wall. She'd lifted it, technically, off a clipboard left in the harbor office, and nobody in the room had asked how. The National Maritime Survey Unit's grid was drawn in a hand so neat it looked printed. Sectors A through F. Sampling windows. A line at the bottom, *site access — restricted pending archive completion*, with a date that was the day after tomorrow.

"They're not even diving sector F," said Eli. He was the one who read texture, who'd spent the week with his bare palm flat against terraces in green light, trying to tell worked stone from broken stone and coming up, every time, with *maybe*. His hands were doing it now, on the tabletop, reading the wood grain because they had nothing better to read. "They've marked it 'low priority.' That's the Main Terrace edge. The straight part."

"The part you can't explain," said the fish.

The fish was Tomo, dry as the salt rings on the windowsill, currently dismantling a regulator he didn't need to dismantle. He hadn't looked up.

"None of us can explain it," Eli said. "That's the point. That's the whole—"

"I know what the point is. I'm agreeing with you in the most annoying way available. Carry on."

Eli carried on. He laid it out the way he'd been laying it out in his head all night, the way it stacked. Tomorrow was the last legal window. After that the buoys went out, the survey's neat little flags, and the site went into a folder. The Unit would write *documented, naturally consistent with regional sandstone jointing*, or they'd write *anomalous features pending further study*, and either way the word *pending* would do what *pending* always did, which was nothing, forever. The mystery wouldn't be solved. It would be *shelved*, which was worse, because shelved looks like solved from across the room.

"So we dive F," Eli said. "Tonight or tomorrow at slack. Off the survey's grid. We get the Main Terrace edge on camera at the resolution it deserves, we get a clean run along the straight, we get—"

"What," said Saki.

She'd been quiet in the doorway. Dr. Saki Tanaka, who owned these currents the way other people owned their own pulse, who had outdived every one of them every day this week without making a show of it, surfacing slow and easy while the crew came up tasting their own heartbeats. She had a mug in both hands and she had not raised her voice.

"We get *what*, Eli. Say the end of the sentence."

He didn't, right away.

The official story, to be fair to it, is beautiful from both sides, and the room knew both sides cold. On the natural side you had Robert Schoch — credentialed, sober, no axe to grind. He'd looked at the same terraces and seen the Yaeyama Group doing what sandstone does: fracturing along bedding planes that are already flat, splitting down vertical joints that are already plumb, the sea then carrying the rubble off and leaving the geometry standing like a thing that meant it. He could point to formations on Yonaguni itself, *above* water, dry land you could walk, that step and corner the same way with no human hand anywhere near them. Nature, the argument went, is a better

architect than any diver with a chisel, and it works for free, and it works in the dark, and it has all the time there is.

On the made side you had Masaaki Kimura, of the University of the Ryukyus, who had spent more hours over this site than anyone breathing, who had mapped it and dived it and pointed his finger at stair after stair after stair and said: *that is too much order in one place*. The right angles. The terraces that read like floors. The Main Terrace, a hundred and fifty meters long, forty wide, with an edge that ran straighter than the sea has any business running anything.

Both men had the receipts. Neither had the verdict. And that — Eli would have said it if his throat had let him — *that* was the thing the survey was about to file.

“We get it on the record,” Eli said finally. “Honestly. Carefully. We don’t touch anything. We don’t say anything. We just look harder than they’re willing to, at the one part that doesn’t resolve, before they cover it up with a sentence.”

Jakobus moved.

He’d been in the corner the whole time, on a stool too small for him, hands wrapped around a coffee gone cold an hour ago. The crew’s fixer, the man who read made things for a living — *what is it for, what was this built to do* — and who, all week, on the one site in the world that should have been his to crack, had said almost nothing. Eli had watched him touch the terrace once, on the second dive, lay two fingers along an edge and hold them there, and then take them away, and not write anything down. That had spooked Eli more than the stone had. Jakobus always wrote something down.

He didn’t stand. He just leaned, and the stool complained, and the room turned to him the way rooms do.

“You want to go to F,” Jakobus said. Not a question.

“It’s the only part that—”

“I heard you.” His accent rounded the edges of it, gentle. He looked at the schedule on the wall, then at Saki, and then he did the thing he always did, the thing the crew had stopped being surprised by and started being grateful for: he handed it past himself. “It’s not my dive,” he said. “It’s not my water.” He nodded at Saki. “Ask her.”

Eli asked her. Not in words. He just turned.

Saki set the mug down. She had a way of choosing, you could watch it happen, a slow settling, the same way she settled on the bottom in a current that would have rolled the rest of them into the trench.

“You think I don’t want to know,” she said.

“I didn’t say—”

“I’ve been diving that edge since I was nineteen. My uncle showed me the Monument before the magazines did, before Aratake’s name went round the world.” She wasn’t sharp about it; she was patient, which was worse. “I have lain on the Main Terrace at slack tide and put my whole hand on that straight line and felt it run away from me in both directions, and I have wanted, *wanted*, to be the one who finally knew. So don’t tell me about wanting more. I have more want in this than you’ll have if you dive here ten years.”

The fish had stopped pretending to fix the regulator.

“Here is what you don’t have,” Saki said. “You don’t have the morning after. You’ll be on a plane. I’ll be in the harbor, with the survey men I have to live beside, with the fishermen who already think outsiders come and take the island’s strange things and sell them. You want to go to F off the grid, get it on camera, *honestly*, you said.” She picked the word up and turned it like a shell. “And then what’s the honest thing? You publish. The Unit hears an unauthorized dive went down on the last window. They don’t just close the site, Eli. They close *me*. They have the harbor master’s ear. They have the prefecture. I lose the water. And the next people who come — and they’ll come, they always come — they get a ‘no’ that I can’t take back, because I’m the local who couldn’t be trusted with her own coast.”

Eli’s hands had gone still on the table. That, for him, was a kind of falling.

“The straight line’s still going to be there,” she said, softer now. “Whether the camera gets it or not. It was there before the survey. It’ll be there after their folder yellows. You think you’d be saving it. You’d be spending it. Mine.”

Here is the potato of this chapter, and it isn’t stone.

All week the engine had run the way the engine runs: they’d taken

slate and a chisel down to a control block at fifteen meters, a slab of the same Yaeyama sandstone broken loose in a storm, and they had tried — Eli, the most careful pair of hands among them — to cut a clean right angle into it underwater. To make a step. To make, by hand, the easy thing the made-side says was made.

It came out a *potato*. It always comes out a potato. The chisel skipped, the grain ran where it wanted, the corner crumbled into a rounded shoulder, the edge feathered. Forty minutes of real effort and what you got was a lumpy approximation that wouldn't have fooled a child, while ten meters away the Monument sat there with its hundred-and-fifty-meter line, sharp and certain, made by — by *what*, exactly, that's the whole book — and looking down its nose at the both of them.

And now the second potato, the human one, was sitting in the kitchen, and it was Eli's plan, and it had come out just as rough. *Get it on the record, honestly, carefully*. It had felt clean in his head. Out loud, in Saki's mouth, it crumbled at the edges. The grain ran where it wanted. You can't cut a clean corner into someone else's home and call it careful because you meant well.

"The Unit closing the site," Eli tried, one more time, "that's the wrong people winning."

"Maybe," said Saki. "Or maybe the Unit closing the site is just the site staying closed, the way it's mostly been closed for twenty million years, the way the sea closes things. You hate that they get to file it. I hate that they get to file it. But the file isn't the Monument. The file is a *story about* the Monument, and stories about it are cheap — Atlantis, the lost continent of Mu, ancient kings, ancient builders, the whole magazine-rack of it. You think your honest folder beats their dishonest one. Eli. They're both folders."

"The hole's real, though." Tomo, the fish, said it without heckle for once, which made everyone look. "She knows it is. Schoch can't show another formation this big, this geometric, made by nature alone — there isn't one, anywhere, that anybody's pointed to. Kimura can't show one tool mark that holds up. Both of them have been *trying*, with credentials, for decades. The gap's real. Eli's not wrong that the gap's real."

"No," Saki agreed, easily, and that was the thing about her, she never

argued the hole away, she was *fierce* for the hole. “The gap’s real. The gap is the most honest thing on this whole island. And you protect honest things by leaving them where they are, not by hauling them up into the light to prove you saw them.”

The LENS spoke from the window.

She hadn’t dived today. She’d stayed up top with the long lens and shot the surface, the chop, the survey boats, the buoys — and Eli had clocked it as a bad day for her, one of the days the camera became a wall again instead of a way through. She had a hundred frames of the *water*, she’d told Mara, and not one of the *thing*, because every time she put the housing on it underwater she felt herself doing the survey’s job for them, *documenting*, *archiving*, turning a place into a file. She’d said she didn’t want to be the one who made the Monument hold still.

“I keep trying to lower it,” she said now, the camera, meaning the camera and not the camera. “And I keep thinking I have to get the shot first. The *real* one. The one that proves I was here, that I saw it true.” She turned from the glass. “She’s saying we don’t get the last shot. Nobody gets the last shot. That’s not the camera failing. That’s the picture.”

Quiet then, a long one, the kind the sea makes when the tide stalls.

Jakobus stood up at last. He stretched the way old hands stretch, and he picked up his cold coffee and looked into it like it might have an answer and finding none, set it back down.

“You want to know what it’s for,” he said to Eli. It was the question the whole series lived inside, *what is it for*, and Eli had been waiting all week for Jakobus to point his finger at the Monument and *name* it — a marker, an almanac, a sightline, a key — the way he could name almost anything people had ever built. “That’s why you want F. Not the camera. You want me to stand on that terrace and tell you what it’s *for*, so the not-knowing stops.”

Eli didn’t deny it.

“I can’t,” Jakobus said. Simple. No shame in it, which was somehow the most generous thing he’d done all week. “First time in a long time. I put my hand on that edge and I read — function — and the stone says *maybe*, same as everything else here. Maybe a floor. Maybe a

step. Maybe just the way the bed broke.” He shook his head, almost smiling. “So if I can’t say what it’s *for*, I’ve got no business saying it’s mine to read. Or yours.” He looked at Saki, and the deference in it was total, and unforced, and it cost him nothing because he meant it. “It’s hers. The function, if there is one — the *meaning* of leaving it alone — that’s hers to give. Or not.”

“And I’m not giving it tonight,” Saki said. “Not like this.”

Eli put his hands flat on the table one more time, and this time he wasn’t reading the grain. He was just stilling them.

He thought about the control block at fifteen meters with its sad rounded corner, the potato, the proof that even *trying* to make the easy thing was hard. He thought about the straight line running away from his palm in both directions in the green dark. He thought about the morning after, the plane, Saki in the harbor with the survey men and the fishermen and the water she could lose. He thought about the gap — Kimura on one side, Schoch on the other, both holding their receipts, both honest, neither able to close the door — and how the gap had survived everything precisely because nobody had been allowed to fill it with a folder.

“Okay,” Eli said.

It was the hardest word he’d said all week, and it didn’t feel like defeat. It felt like the chisel coming out of the rock before it could ruin the edge.

“Okay. We don’t dive F.”

Mara reached up and took the schedule off the wall. Folded it once, twice, and didn’t throw it away — set it on the table, face down, the survey’s neat printed hand turned to the wood. Tomorrow at slack they’d do their last legal dive, in the legal sectors, and they’d come up slow the way Saki came up, and they’d leave the straight line where it was, sharp and uncounted, running away in both directions under twenty meters of green-blue water that had been making and unmaking the question for longer than there’d been anyone around to ask it.

“For the record,” said the fish, very quietly, “I think you’d have gotten a hell of a shot.”

“I know,” said the LENS. “That’s why we’re not taking it.”

Outside the harbor lights kept jittering on the black, and the tide, which answers to nobody, began very slowly to turn.

Chapter 16 — A Local Reading

The survey team's generator coughed across the harbor at 0530, which meant Saki Tanaka had already been awake for an hour, sitting cross-legged on the concrete lip of the dive shop with a thermos and a tide chart she didn't need to look at.

The ND lead found her there. The town was that grey before color, when the sea and the sky agreed not to be different things yet, and the orange floats of the survey boat were the only loud objects in the world. Across the water, men in matching windbreakers were stacking Pelican cases on the dock with the unhurried confidence of people who had a permit and a budget and a closing date.

"They go to the Main Terrace at slack," Tanaka said, without turning around. "Eleven-forty. They want the corner. The big one, southwest, where the step turns."

"The right angle."

"The right angle." She poured tea into the thermos cup and held it out without looking, and the lead took it because you take what Tanaka hands you. "They will photograph it from nine positions. They will laser-scan it. They will write that it is consistent with natural jointing along bedding planes, with a possible overprint of human use that cannot be confirmed." She sipped from the thermos itself. "Which is true."

"You think it's true."

"I think it is what you can say." She finally looked at the lead, and her eyes did the thing they did, the diver's habit of reading a face the way

you read water — for what it was about to do. “You have been here eight days. You have touched the stone. Tell me what you found.”

This was the test, and the lead knew it was the test, and there was no way to pass it except honestly, which is the worst kind of test.

So: honestly.

“The vertical joints are real,” the lead said. “Schoch’s right about those — the sandstone splits along bedding planes and along two sets of fractures more or less at right angles to each other, and that’s just what mudstone-sandstone does in the Yaeyama Group, it’s textbook, you can see the same geometry on the cliffs above the waterline at Sanninudai.” The lead’s hands moved while talking, the way they always did, blocking out planes in the air. “The big flat faces are bedding. The steps are bedding planes that broke clean and then the block below slid or dropped. I felt the difference, the first dive. Worked stone has a tool’s rhythm in it, a repetition, a hand that got tired. The terraces don’t have that. They feel like geology. They feel like time.”

Tanaka waited. She was good at waiting. It was the second-best thing about her, after the diving.

“But,” the lead said.

“But.”

“The southwest corner.” The lead set the tea cup down on the concrete with the care of someone whose hands were not entirely under their command this morning. “I put my palm flat in it. Both faces. And they’re square. Not approximately. The fish makes a joke about it” — the lead almost smiled — “calls it the corner that passed inspection. Two flat planes meeting at ninety, and they’re flat the way nothing the sea makes is flat, and they’re not weathered into roundness at the join, they’re *clean*, like the join is younger than the rock, and I have run my hand over a hundred natural joints this week and that one—” The lead stopped. “That one I can’t put down.”

A gull complained over the harbor. Across the water a Pelican case clacked shut.

“And nobody can,” the lead said, quieter. “That’s the part. Decades.

No tool mark anybody will stand behind in a peer-reviewed journal. And also no other formation, anywhere, this big, this geometric, that everybody agrees the sea made by itself. Both halves of the case are missing the same evidence. Schoch can't show you the matching natural monument. Kimura can't show you the chisel. They're standing in the same hole, just facing opposite directions."

The crew had tried, of course. That was Chapter Twelve, and it had ended the way the house promised it would.

The methodical recorder had built the test rig over two days: a slab of Yaeyama sandstone hauled up from a quarry on the main island, lowered to fifteen meters in a frame, and the LENS filming while the lead and a borrowed mason's hammer attempted to produce, by hand, underwater, in a wetsuit, against the surge, a single clean right-angled step in the kind of stone the monument is made of.

It came out a potato.

That was the dry wit's word, surfacing, peeling the regulator out of his mouth. *We made a potato*. The corner was rounded, the faces dished where the hammer skipped, the riser scalloped with the bright pale crescents of percussion that the monument simply does not have. You could feel the hand in it — every clumsy, tired, surge-knocked blow — which was exactly the point. The made thing screamed *made*. The monument said nothing. The sea, the dry wit observed, was a better mason than any of them, and didn't even charge for the slab.

So that was the official story, played straight all the way down. The skeptics had the geology and the gravity of it, and the lead believed them. The believers had the corner, and the lead couldn't put it down. Both were true at 0530 with the tea going cold. Both stayed true.

The lead said as much.

And Tanaka set the thermos down on the concrete, lined it up neat with the cup, and decided something. You could see her decide it. It was a small movement in the shoulders, the kind of thing the LENS would have caught if the LENS had been awake, the loosening of a person who has chosen to hand over something they usually keep.

"Come," she said. "The light is going to be good."

They walked the harbor road up past the survey camp, where a young technician in a windbreaker nodded at Tanaka with the deference of a man whose institution had been told, repeatedly, that the local geologist out-dove and out-read all of them and would be wise to consult. He offered coffee. Tanaka declined in Japanese, courteously, and kept walking, and did not look back at the cases.

The road climbed to the headland above where the monument lay drowned, and the sea down there was going from grey to the green-blue it kept for itself, and you could not see the stone from here, not even a shadow of it, just water doing what water does.

“My grandfather fished here,” Tanaka said. “Before the monument was a monument. Before 1986, before Aratake-san found it looking for hammerhead sharks, before anyone outside Yonaguni cared.” She crouched at the cliff edge, easy, a body that had spent fifty years getting in and out of this sea. “You ask the wrong question. You all ask it. The survey asks it with lasers. Kimura asked it. Schoch. Your fish asks it the loudest.” A flick of a smile. “*Did hands make it. Made or not.*”

“It’s kind of the whole—”

“It is the question that has no answer, so you should not build your house on it.” She picked up a flake of weathered sandstone from the cliff edge, turned it, dropped it. “My field is the stone and the water. I will tell you what I know with my body, which is more than I know with a paper. I know that the joints are natural. I know the bedding planes are natural. I know the current at the Trench runs the way it does because the Trench is shaped the way it is, and I know that southwest corner is square, and I know I cannot tell you who or what squared it, and after thirty years of this water I have made my peace that I will die not knowing, and that this is *correct*.”

The lead listened. Did not block out planes in the air. Did not reach for the corner. Just listened, which the lead had been learning to do all week, badly, then less badly. The local’s camera was heavier here. That was the whole law of it.

“You want to know what it is for,” Tanaka said. “Jakobus asks it the right way, at least. Not who made it. *What is it for.*”

Down the headland, where Jakobus had walked off at dawn to look at the water and say nothing, he was a dark shape against the brightening sea, hands in his pockets, not coming closer. He had handed this morning to the lead before it began. He did that. The road, not the lead.

“I will tell you what it is for,” Tanaka said. “Not what it was for, twelve thousand years ago, if there was a twelve-thousand-years-ago. What it is for now.”

She stood. The wind off the sea took her grey hair sideways and she let it.

“It is a marker,” she said. “You find it by the hammerheads — they school at the headland, the divers know the place by the sharks, so the stone is where the sharks are, which is where the food is, which is where the boats go. It marks the corner of the island under the water. A fisherman who could read this water could find his ground by it. Whether a man set it there or the sea set it there, it sits at the southwest, at the turn, exactly where you would put a marker if you wanted one. It marks.”

The lead said nothing. The tea was a sourness at the back of the throat. Across the water the survey generator changed pitch.

“It is a meeting place,” Tanaka said. “Now more than ever. You came from — where, the other side of the world. The survey came from Tokyo. Schoch came from Boston, Kimura is from the university up the road and he dives it like it is his own grandmother. Believers come. Skeptics come. They all come *here*, to the same forty meters of stone, and they argue, and the stone holds them. It is the one table everyone sits at. My grandfather’s fishing ground is now the place the whole argument has to meet, because the argument cannot be had anywhere else. There is no other formation like it to go to instead.” A dry look at the lead. “Your fish should appreciate that. The stone makes everyone show up in person.”

The sea went a shade greener. Far below, in fifteen meters of it, the southwest corner sat square and silent and refused, as it had refused everyone, to confess.

“And it is a guardian,” Tanaka said, and this was the one she said

slowest. “Of the maybe.”

The lead looked up.

“You think the not-knowing is a failure,” Tanaka said. “You feel it as a failure. I watched your face on the boat, after the corner. You hate that your hands could not decide. Your gift is to know worked from broken by touch, and here it cannot, and you feel the gift has *failed* you.” She shook her head once. “The gift did not fail. The stone is genuinely between. Your hands are reading it *correctly*. The correct reading is *I cannot say*. That is not the gift breaking. That is the gift telling you the truth about a thing that is true.”

The wind dropped for a second, the way it does, and the sea was very loud below.

“The monument guards the maybe,” she said. “It is the proof, out there in the water where everyone can dive down and put a hand on it, that there are things a credentialed man with a laser cannot close. The survey will document it. They will archive it. They will write *consistent with natural processes, possible cultural overprint unconfirmed*, and they will be right, and the file will close, and the legend will go off the books.” She looked across the water at the orange floats. “And the corner will still be square. They cannot box that. They can only describe around it. That is what it is for now. It holds the *maybe* open against everyone who wants it shut — Kimura who wants it a temple, Schoch who wants it a rockfall, the survey who wants it filed. It is a guardian of the question. There are not many of those left. People do not like the maybe. The maybe is the most honest thing in the sea, and almost nobody can stand it.”

She crouched again, picked up the dropped flake of stone, and this time she put it in the lead’s palm and folded the lead’s fingers over it. The lead’s hand knew it instantly — weathered, broken, ordinary, a rock the sea had cracked, no question in it at all. The certainty of it was almost a relief and almost an insult.

“Keep that one,” Tanaka said. “It is what *broken* feels like. So you remember the corner is something else. Not *made* — I will not say made. *Else*. Keep the else.”

She stood, and brushed the grit off her hands, and looked at the lead with the whole weight of her thirty years in that water and her

grandfather's boat and the sharks at the headland.

"You wanted me to give you the answer," she said. "I gave you the function. That is all I have, and it is more than the survey will get, and I am giving it to you because you did not lie to me about the corner. You said *I cannot put it down*. Good. Don't." She turned toward the harbor, toward the boats, toward 0540 becoming a working morning. "Slack is at eleven-forty. Get your gear. We are going to dive it one more time before they lock it, and you are going to put your hand in the corner, and you are not going to decide. That is the dive. That is the whole dive."

Down the headland, Jakobus had turned to watch the water go gold, and had not moved an inch toward them, and the lead understood that this had always been hers to receive and not his to take, and stood there a moment longer with a broken stone closed warm in one hand and the other hand already wanting the corner.

The generator across the water settled into its working hum.

The tide began, very quietly, to turn.

Chapter 17 — The Last Image

The survey boat sat where the harbor met the open water, white and patient, its deck stacked with the orange cases they used for everything. Sample tubes. Sonar heads. The future of Yonaguni, packed in foam and waiting for a flight to Naha.

We had until slack tide.

That was the deal Saki had wrung out of them on the dock that morning, in Japanese too fast for me to follow but slow enough that I caught the shape of it — the survey lead bowing, the survey lead apologizing, the survey lead saying yes, one more, with the precise warmth of a man who has decided to be generous because it costs him nothing. The site closed at fourteen-hundred. Buoys going down. A polite cordon around a question.

“He’s not a villain,” Saki said, coiling line at the stern. She said it the way you’d correct a child about a snake. “He has a budget and a deadline and a minister who wants a clean report. *Documented. Archived.*” She let the English words sit there, dry. “He wants to give the country a thing it can file.”

“And the thing won’t file,” said the recorder, checking her slate, her sample bags, her checklist that never let her down.

“No.” Saki looked at the green water. “The thing won’t file.”

The fish — that’s what we called the dry one, for reasons that had stopped being funny and become true — leaned over the rail and addressed the sea directly. “You hear that, Atlantis? Last call. Either

you're a temple or you're a rock. The man with the foam needs to know for his spreadsheet."

The sea did not answer. The sea never did. That was rather the whole point.

I want to be fair to the survey here, because the chapter could turn cheap and I'd rather it didn't. Their case was the strong case. It has always been the strong case. You stand on Yonaguni's coast above the waterline and you see the same thing the monument shows you below: sandstone of the Yaeyama Group, Lower Miocene, twenty million years of it, bedded flat as a stack of paper and jointed at angles that look — to a frightened animal that loves patterns — *carved*. The cliffs at Sanninudai do it in the open air. Right angles. Terraces. Steps a giant could climb. Nobody calls Sanninudai a sunken city, because Sanninudai had the bad manners to stay dry.

Schoch dove the monument and surfaced with that. Same rock, same fracture, same joint sets, just underwater and dressed up in coral. Earthquakes shake the Ryukyu arc like a tray of glasses. Bedding planes part. Blocks slide and stop square because square is what these joints do. No tool marks confirmed in any peer-reviewed paper. No midden. No hearth. No culture in the Ryukyu prehistory with the means or the motive to quarry a hundred and fifty meters of seafloor and then, apparently, leave nothing else of itself anywhere on the island above.

It's a clean argument. It deserves respect, and the survey man — bowing on his dock — was its honest servant.

We just kept running into the part it doesn't cover.

We dropped at the Main Terrace one last time, the four of us and Saki, with the LENS trailing a length behind because the LENS always trailed, the camera out front of him like a divining rod.

He had not lowered it once in three weeks. I'd watched. The methodical recorder had watched and logged it without comment, which is how she loves people. Down here the LENS was at his most himself and his most gone — a man who had spent a career making war hold

still long enough to be looked at, and who could not, would not, stop framing. The terrace edge, two hundred frames of it. The trench, the road, whatever it was, raking off into the blue. He shot the monument the way he must once have shot a street that might explode: composing the threat, composing the beauty, the same gesture for both, because his eye had stopped being able to tell them apart and that was the wound nobody was allowed to call a wound.

I went to the edge and put my hands on it, because that is what I am for.

I keep trying to tell people what this is like and I keep failing, so here is the failure again. There is a difference between worked stone and broken stone, and it lives in the fingertips before it lives in the eyes. Worked stone carries intention — the tiny hesitation of a tool that stopped and started, the over-bite where a hand leaned wrong, the rhythm of someone who got tired. Broken stone is clean of all that. It is decision without a decider. Conchoidal, plane-true, indifferent.

The Main Terrace edge, under my gloves, under the fur of algae and the small mouths of things, was indifferent.

It was also straight. Genuinely, stupidly straight, for longer than indifference is supposed to manage at this size and this depth, in this rock.

That's the hole. I've said it before and I'll keep saying it because it's the only honest thing in the book: there's no confirmed tool mark to make Kimura's case, and there's no second formation anywhere at this scale, this geometric, underwater, that makes Schoch's case feel finished instead of merely strong. The two best-read men who ever put a regulator in their mouths over this rock looked at the same edge I had my hands on and disagreed, in print, with their names on it, and never closed it. I had spent the trip trying to be the thing that closed it. My gift had spent the trip telling me, gently, in a language made of texture, that it would not be closing today.

The potato lived in my own hands too, by the way. We'd tried, in the shallows — the recorder, the fish, and me with a borrowed chisel and a block of the same Yaeyama sandstone Saki cut us from a dry quarry. Three days. We wanted one clean right angle. *One*. What we got was a rough vee, a chip-out where the bedding plane betrayed us, an edge a child would draw with the wrong end of the crayon. The sea

makes this look easy. A diver with a chisel makes a potato. That's not a metaphor I reached for. It's just what was sitting on the towel when we surfaced, the saddest little spud of failed geometry, and the fish had named it and we'd let the name stick.

Saki swam the trench below me like she was reading a sentence she'd read a thousand times. She didn't touch much. She didn't need to. Where I read by hand she read by current — the way the water moved through the so-called road told her things, the velocity at the step risers, the eddies that scour and the ones that deposit. She'd shown me earlier in the week, finning slowly, holding a fistful of fine silt and letting it go and watching it choose its path, how the water and the stone had been arguing this shape out between them for longer than language.

"Here." She'd hovered at a step corner, pointed her light. "Tell me what your hands say."

I'd put my hands on it. The riser was square. My fingertips found a fracture face, clean, conchoidal, indifferent — and then, a hand's width along, something that hesitated. A texture with rhythm in it. Worked, said the hand. Then nothing. Then indifferent again.

I'd looked at her, and even through a mask you can ask a question with your whole face.

She'd shaken her head. Not *no*. Not *yes*. The other thing. The motion that means *that's the place where I stop too*, from a woman who out-read me on this rock every single day, who knew currents I couldn't feel and joints I'd missed and the precise way this island's stone wants to come apart. She had more camera than I did. She always had. And at the one corner that mattered she held it level and steady and pointed it at the gap and declined, like the professional she was, to invent what wasn't there.

That was the gift. I'd come to understand it as the gift. Not the answer. The exact, honest, fingertip-measured edge of where the answer ran out.

Now, on the last dive, the survey's buoys already going down some-

where off the bow, I watched the LENS come into the trench with his camera up.

He drifted to the great square corner, the one Kimura photographs, the one Schoch explains, the one I couldn't close and Saki wouldn't fake. He framed it. I watched him frame it. Twenty years of framing, the reflex of a man who had survived by turning the unbearable into a rectangle he could hold at arm's length.

And then Saki turned in the water and held out her bare hand to him. Not for the camera. *To him.* Palm to the stone, fingers spread, the universal *come here, feel this* that needs no language and no print and no minister's report.

The LENS stopped.

I have no way to render what happened on his face because he had a mask on and so do I and the whole point of all of this is that the most important things don't render. But I saw the camera come down. Not dropped — he'd never drop it. Lowered. Hung off its tether, drifting, the lens pointing uselessly at silt for the first time in three weeks, while he reached out his own naked glove and laid it on the stone beside hers.

I don't know what he felt. I'm the texture-reader and I couldn't read it for him. That was his to have.

But I watched a man who had spent his life standing one rectangle away from the world put his hand flat on a thing that might be a temple and might be a rock and might be the both-at-once that this island has held in trust for ten thousand years, and not photograph it. Just hold it. Saki beside him, not explaining. The two of them at the corner where everyone's certainty runs out, touching it, letting it be exactly as unfinished as it is.

The fish, hovering nearby, said nothing into his regulator for once. Even the heckler knows when to let the room alone.

We surfaced into the slack and the survey was already running their line, the orange floats bobbing out a perimeter, polite as a museum rope. The lead lifted a hand to us from the white boat. Not a gloat. A wave. *Thank you for your cooperation. The site is now documented*

and archived.

Saki waved back, civil to the last.

“He thinks he’s closing it,” the recorder said, watching the buoys go.

“He’s closing the access.” Saki pulled her mask down around her neck and looked at the patch of sea that, from up here, was just sea — green-blue, ordinary, hiding its hundred and fifty meters of impossible-or-not. “You can rope off the rock. You can box up every chip of it.” She almost smiled. “The split’s in the literature, not in the water. Kimura’s paper. Schoch’s paper. Two credentialed men, names on the line, neither one wrong enough to win.” She nodded at the floats. “That’s not in his cases. He can’t archive the gap between two arguments. Nobody can. It just sits there.”

The LENS hadn’t said anything since we’d surfaced. He sat on the gunwale with the camera in his lap, both hands resting on it, not raising it, looking at the water the way you look at a person, not a picture.

“You get the shot?” the fish asked him, gently, because it had to be asked and the fish was the only one allowed to ask it lightly.

The LENS looked down at the camera. Looked at the sea. He turned the camera over in his hands like he’d found it on a beach and couldn’t quite remember what it was for.

“No,” he said. “Wasn’t anything to shoot.”

Which was the most extraordinary thing I ever heard him say, and the closest the book ever came to a miracle, and I’m not going to caption it for you. Some edges you leave indifferent. Some you leave with the rhythm still in them. You don’t get to know which.

The boat turned for the harbor. Behind us the buoys held their polite little perimeter around the question, and the question — straight where it should be jointed, indifferent where it should be worked, a hundred and fifty meters of *maybe* — did what it has always done.

It stayed down there.

It kept its own counsel.

And it let the water carry the part nobody, on any boat, in any paper, with any budget, ever got to take home.

Chapter 18 — The Maybe

The dive computer on Mara's wrist counted down the slack like a held breath. Eleven minutes. The current at Yonaguni doesn't ask permission; it leans on you, and at the turn of the tide it forgets to lean, and that forgetting is the only window the sea gives you to think.

Mara hung over the top step of the Main Terrace with her gloves off.

She'd taken them off against every rule the methodical recorder had ever read aloud to her, because there are things the hand needs to know directly. Below her, the sandstone went out flat and pale in the green-blue, a plane so level the silt sat on it the way dust sits on a tabletop you mean to wipe tomorrow. A hundred and fifty meters of it, more or less, off into the gloom where the light gave up. Forty wide. She'd memorized those numbers on the boat the way you memorize a prayer you don't believe but say anyway.

She laid her bare palm against the edge where the terrace dropped to the step below.

This was the thing she did that nobody else could. On land she could walk a temple wall and feel where the chisel had bitten and where the rock had simply broken — the difference between a surface a hand had argued with and a surface that had only ever obeyed gravity. Worked stone has a grammar. Her fingers had read it on basalt and limestone and granite, on Roman quarry faces and on the gut-rough backs of standing stones, and she had never once been wrong in a way that mattered.

The edge under her hand was sharp.

Not knife-sharp. Stone-sharp. Clean along a line that ran true for longer than it had any business running. She moved her palm along

it, and the marine encrustation rasped, and beneath the encrustation the angle held, and held, and held.

Made, said her hand.

And then, two body-lengths along, the same edge crumbled into a fracture that no hand had ever touched, a bedding plane sheared off the way the whole island had once sheared, and her palm read it instantly:

Broken.

Same edge. Same stone. Twenty seconds apart.

She pulled her hand back and watched a small school of something silver pour over the step like the terrace was a thing they used, a road they took because it went where they were going, and she thought — not for the first time on this island — that her gift had finally found the one place that didn't care about it.

The skeptics' case is clean, and Mara had learned to love it the way you learn to love a stubborn relative. Sandstone of the Yaeyama Group, Lower Miocene, twenty million years in the laying-down. Sandstone fractures along bedding planes, which are flat, and along vertical joints, which are straight, and where flat meets straight you get a right angle for free, no architect required. Schoch had dived here. He'd put his own hands on it. He'd come up and said: nature did this, and pointed at the cliffs above the waterline on Yonaguni itself where you can watch the same shapes forming dry, in the air, with nobody's chisel anywhere near them. Terraces. Steps. Corners.

That's the part that ought to settle it. You can stand on a beach on this island and look at the natural rock and see the monument's cousins sunning themselves in the open. No mystery. No drowned city. Just stone doing what this particular stone does.

The crew had given that its full and honest weight. The dry one — Tomas, who supplied the fish-voice and never the verdict — had stood on exactly that beach and said, deadpan, "So the sea's got a T-square and we don't. Cool. Cool cool cool." Which was the truest thing anyone said all week, and also a joke, and at Yonaguni those keep turning out to be the same sentence.

But.

They had tried to make a potato.

Three days back, in the shallows off the harbor mouth, they'd run the test. A block of the same sandstone, harvested loose from the rubble field where nobody could accuse them of vandalizing anything. Tomas with a chisel. The recorder timing it. The LENS up on the surface, refusing, for once, to shoot, just watching the water.

The idea was simple and a little cruel. If you want to argue a thing was carved, carve it. Make one step. One clean right angle, one flat plane, in this exact rock, with tools a person five thousand years ago could plausibly have held.

The sandstone did not cooperate.

It chipped where you didn't strike and held where you did. It spalled in dish-shaped flakes that took your intended edge with them. The flat plane came out cupped. The right angle came out a soft, embarrassed bend, like the stone was apologizing for being asked. After forty minutes Tomas held up the result — a lump, gouged and rounded and ashamed — and let it sit in his palm in the green light.

"Behold," he said. "I have made a potato."

And that was the joke that wasn't a joke, because the sea makes better angles than the diver does. The skeptic's whole point, handed to them by their own failure: the natural fracture is *cleaner* than the human one. Nature's not the one who needs the chisel. We are. We're the ones who leave the mess.

So the potato argued for Schoch.

Which would have closed it, except.

Except for the long edge under Mara's bare hand. The one that ran true.

Here is the hole, and the crew handed it to neither side, because it belongs to neither side. Bedding planes are flat. Joints are straight. Fine. But the Main Terrace runs level over a span and a regularity

that makes geologists who say *natural* shift their weight, just slightly, when they say it. And after decades — Aratake found it in '86, and the eyes have been on it ever since — nobody has published, in a journal that survives review, a single tool mark anyone agrees is a tool mark. No chisel scar. No quarry wedge. No cultural layer, no midden, no broken pot, no carved face anyone but Kimura reads as carved.

Two credentialed men. Kimura of the University of the Ryukyus, who has spent his life mapping this thing and sees stairs, sees a castle, sees inscription. Schoch of Boston University, who has dived it and sees the patient arithmetic of the sea. Both with the receipts. Both wrong, if the other is right. Neither able to make the other blink.

That's not a gap in the data. That's the data. The split *is* the finding. Mara had come to Yonaguni thinking her hand would break the tie, and her hand had found the one stone that won't be broken.

Made, it said. *Broken*, it said. Both true. Twenty seconds apart.

She loved it. That was the thing she hadn't expected to feel, hanging over the terrace with her gloves off and the slack running out. She'd spent her whole life being the one who *knew* by touch, the one whose certainty made rooms uncomfortable, the kid who couldn't stop reading the room because nobody had ever let her stop. Certainty had been the price of her wiring and also its only reward. And here was a place that took the certainty away and left the wiring, and the wiring, freed of the job of being right, did something she'd never let it do.

It just *felt* the stone. Cold and sharp and ambiguous and alive.

She'd been treating the not-knowing like a failure. The terrace was teaching her it was a gift.

Saki Tanaka came down through the silt above her, easy as breath, and that was the other thing about Yonaguni: no matter how well you read the room, here the room had a keeper, and the keeper read it better.

Mara had watched it happen all week. Saki knew the currents the way Mara knew worked stone — not as data but as a sense in the body, a thing she'd paid for in years and didn't have to think about. Saki put her hand to the same long edge now, and where Mara's hand

had asked *made or broken*, Saki's hand asked nothing. It just rested there, the way you rest a hand on the flank of a horse you've owned a long time.

She tapped the back of Mara's glove — *with me* — and finned along the terrace, and Mara followed, and the recorder followed her, and the slack ticked down.

Saki took them along the edge to where it crumbled — to where Mara's hand had said *broken* — and held there, and pointed not at the break but at the way the break sat against the true line, the two of them side by side, the clean and the ruined sharing one stone. She made a slow gesture with both hands, a holding-open, a *both*.

She knew. She'd known before the crew came. She'd dived this monument a hundred times and she had not chosen Kimura and she had not chosen Schoch, and that was not because she couldn't read it. It was because she could.

That was the part the survey team would never put in the archive.

The National Maritime Survey Unit had their boat moored off the point, white and clean and full of cases. They were polite. They had documented and they had archived and tomorrow they would close the site for research, which meant the legend would go in a box and the box would go in a building and the question — *made or not* — would be stamped, somewhere, *under review*, which is the bureaucratic word for *we would like everyone to stop asking*.

They weren't villains. That was almost the worst of it. They had funding and a mandate and a genuine wish to protect the stone from a thousand divers' fins. A man named Hidaka ran them, and he'd shaken everyone's hand, and he wasn't wrong that the encrustation was fragile and the currents were lethal and the legend brought careless people. He wanted the site safe.

But you cannot box a maybe. You can only close it. And a closed maybe is just a no that's afraid to say so.

Saki had argued with Hidaka on the dock the night before, in Japanese, low and fast, and Mara hadn't followed the words but she'd read the room — old habit, the gift in its day job — and what

she read was a woman defending not an answer but the *right to not have one*. The dignity of the open question. Hidaka wanted to be able to write a sentence with a period at the end. Saki was standing in front of the period with her arms crossed.

She'd lose. Probably. The funding always wins the dock. But she'd dived it that morning with the crew anyway, slack tide, gloves off, because the telling of the thing belonged to whoever was honest enough to keep it open, and the survey would not be honest enough.

On the boat afterward, dripping, the LENS finally lowered the camera.

He'd been shooting the monument for nine days through the housing, the way he shot everything, threat and beauty at once, the old war habit of putting glass between himself and the thing so it couldn't get all the way in. And now he sat with the camera in his lap, lens down, water beading off the dome, and he looked at the green sea where the terrace lay invisible under it, and he didn't lift it.

"I don't have a picture of it," he said. "Nine days. I don't have *the* picture. The one that decides."

"There isn't one," Mara said.

"I know." He almost smiled. "That's the picture."

Tomas, peeling off his hood: "We came all this way to not find out. We should put that on a shirt. *Yonaguni: We Came All This Way To Not Find Out*. In, like, a tasteful font."

"It would sell," the recorder said, not looking up from her log.

"It would *not* sell," Tomas said, "and that is the tragedy of my life."

Jakobus was at the stern. He'd been on the road this whole time, the way he always was — never the lead, never the one who held the camera, the weathered fixer who got them the boat and the slack-tide window and the introduction to a marine geologist who'd otherwise have thrown them off the island on sight. He had a way of looking at a made thing and asking the one question that mattered: *what is it for*. He'd asked it at a dozen sites and a dozen times the answer had cracked the whole thing open — a sightline, a water-map, a key.

He looked at the sea now. He didn't ask it.

He turned, instead, to Saki, who was coiling line at the rail with her back to all of them, and he didn't ask her either. He just waited, the way you wait at a door you have no right to open.

And Saki, after a while, coiling, not turning around, said it to the water, not to them.

"It's a place we go," she said, "to stand at the edge of what we don't know. People here have always had one. A rock, a reef, a mountain. You go to it and you put your hand on it and you don't find out anything. That's the use of it. You leave knowing you don't know, and you carry it more gently after."

She tied off the line.

"Kimura says it's a temple. Maybe. Schoch says it's the sea's good luck. Maybe. They both want it to be one thing because one thing you can put in a paper." She turned then, and looked at Jakobus, and the look had no answer in it, only a question she'd made her peace with a long time ago. "I don't dive it to find out what it is. I dive it to remember that I can't."

That was the function. That was the *what is it for*, and it was hers to give, and she gave only as much of it as she chose, and not one word more.

A marker. A meeting point. A guardian of the maybe.

Jakobus inclined his head, the smallest motion, and handed the moment back to her by not taking it, and that was the whole of his answer.

The survey boat ran its generator into the dusk. By the weekend the site would be closed, the access logged, the legend filed under *review*. Hidaka would write his sentence with the period at the end. The split between Kimura and Schoch would stay exactly where it had stood since 1986, two credentialed men and one stone and no tool mark anybody could agree on, and no second formation anywhere on Earth this big and this geometric that nature alone is known to have made — that hole, real, checkable, unclosed, the one the debunk never quite reached and the believer never quite reached either.

Mara pressed her bare palm flat against the wet gunwale and felt the grain of the wood, which was easy, which a person had made, which

her hand could read in a heartbeat and which told her nothing at all.

Somewhere under the green, the long edge ran true, and then it broke, and the two lived side by side on one stone, and the tide turned, and forgot to lean, and remembered, and leaned.

Made, or not.

Put your hand on it. Tell me what you feel.

Then take your hand away, and stand there, and let the water carry the question out past the light where neither of us can follow it.

That's the use of it.

Chapter 19 — The Road Home

The harbor at Sonai smelled of diesel and cut bait, and the survey unit's containers were going aboard the ferry one by one, blue and white and stenciled with a ministry seal, each one swallowing a piece of the last three weeks. The crew watched from the seawall with coffee gone cold in paper cups. Nobody had told them to leave. Nobody had needed to.

The ND lead had their hands wrapped around the cup the way you hold something to keep from holding something else. Out past the breakwater the sea was flat and lying about itself, the way it always lied at slack, looking like a thing you could trust until it turned and took your air and your bearings and the careful map you'd built in your head and stirred all three together.

"They got the cast," said the recorder, not looking up from the case she was latching. "The terrace corner. Silicone pull, the whole north-east angle."

"They got a cast." The dry one, the fish, sat on a bollard with his fins folded. "Of a corner. Which proves the corner exists. Bold. Daring. Somebody pin a medal on the man."

"It's evidence."

"It's a photograph of a question with the lights turned up." He flicked water off a fin. "Twenty million years that rock's been a rock. Three weeks the government's been a government. I know which one I'd bet the legend on."

Nobody laughed, which on this crew was a kind of laughing.

Here is the official story, one more time, laid out flat the way you lay out a body to say goodbye to it properly.

In 1986 a local diver named Kihachiro Aratake went looking for hammerhead sharks off the southern tip of Yonaguni and found instead a wall of stone going down into the green, terraced and stepped and squared, a hundred and fifty meters of it along the Main Terrace, forty wide, dropping in stages toward twenty-five meters and the dark. Sandstone and mudstone of the Yaeyama Group, Lower Miocene, laid down when the world had no people in it to wonder at rock. The steps are broad. The corners come to right angles. There is a feature the divers call the Road, or the Trench, running parallel to the mass like something meant to be walked beside.

Masaaki Kimura of the University of the Ryukyus dove it for decades and came up convinced: a structure. Stairs cut for feet, terraces leveled by hands, faces and pools and the ghosts of inscriptions, a drowned ceremonial place from when the water sat lower and the island reached further. He drew the maps. He named the rooms.

Robert Schoch of Boston University dove it and came up unconvinced: sandstone does this. It fractures along its bedding planes, flat as a table, and it splits along its vertical joints, square as a door, and the sea and the earthquakes do the rest, and if you want proof, look at the cliffs of Yonaguni *above* the water, where the same rock makes the same steps with nobody to thank for them.

Two credentialed geologists. No consensus. No confirmed tool mark in the peer-reviewed literature, not one, after all these years. No second underwater formation anywhere of this size, this geometric, that anyone can point to and say: nature, plainly, end of story.

That is the whole of it. That is the floor everyone stands on, and the floor does not hold an answer.

They had tried, in week two, to make a step.

This is the part the crew did not put in the rough cut, because it embarrassed them, and because it was the most honest thing they did. They'd taken a slab of the same Yaeyama sandstone — a fallen

block, nothing pried from the monument, Tanaka would have ended them — and the ND lead had gone at it underwater with a masonry chisel and a four-pound hammer, trying to cut a face as clean as the terrace edge they'd touched at fifteen meters.

The chisel skated. The stone didn't cleave, it *crumbled*, gave way in soft brown clouds that hung in the water and refused to make a line. Where they wanted a right angle they got a slumped shoulder. Where they wanted flat they got the rough scoop of a thumb in clay. Forty minutes of work and the result sat on the deck afterward looking less like a step and more like something the sea had been chewing and spat out: a potato, lumpen, apologetic, geometrically a coward.

"Nature did it cleaner," the fish had said, "with no thumbs and all the time in the world. Insulting, really."

And that was the trap of the place, the trap that had its jaws in the crew the whole time. Because the failure cut both ways. You couldn't carve those edges by hand — they'd proven it, they'd held the proof, brown and crumbling. So the believers' easy story died on the deck of a dive boat.

But you also couldn't make the sea answer for the *straightness*. The Main Terrace runs true. Not roughly true. You can lay a line along it and the rock holds the line further than rock has any business holding it, and that fact sat in the gut like a swallowed stone, and no amount of bedding-plane talk had quite dissolved it. The ND lead had run their bare palm along that edge at fifteen meters and felt their whole wiring light up and then go silent, the gift arriving and finding nothing to say. *Worked here. Fractured here. Worked. Maybe. The same.* No tool marks under the touch. No proof of intention. And no honest way to call it accident either.

That was the hole. It had no bottom. They'd dropped three weeks down it and it took every one.

Jakobus came along the seawall with his bag over one shoulder, weathered as the bollards, and stood a while saying nothing, which was most of what he ever did. He watched the blue containers go up the ramp.

"They'll write it up," he said finally. "The survey. Document and

archive. There'll be a report."

"And the report will say?" the recorder asked.

"Inconclusive, in nine hundred careful pages." He set the bag down. "Which is the truth, dressed for a funeral."

The ND lead turned the cold cup in their hands. "We didn't get it. Whatever it is. I had my hand on it and I didn't get it."

Jakobus looked at them, and there was no comfort in his face because comfort would have been a lie and he didn't deal in those. "I read made things," he said. "That's the trade. You hand me a wall, I tell you what it's for — a granary, a gate, a tomb, a place to count the moon. I've read stones older than the language of the people who set them and told you their purpose, and been right."

"And this one."

"This one I couldn't read." He said it the way another man might confess a sin, flat and clean. "I stood in the water and waited for it to tell me its function and it wouldn't. First time in a long time." He picked up a chip of broken Yaeyama from the seawall, turned it, set it down. "And do you know, I went home from a few of these jobs over the years certain. *Certain*. And the certainty was the cheapest thing I carried. You could buy certainty anywhere. This —" he nodded at the water, the green flat lying sea — "this you can't buy. This they couldn't crate."

"That's not an answer," the recorder said.

"No." He almost smiled. "It's better than an answer. An answer ends. This goes home with you and keeps you up."

The fish, on the bollard, said nothing, which was the highest review he gave anything.

Dr. Saki Tanaka came down to the harbor at the back end of the afternoon, in the rubber boots and the faded shirt, salt in the lines around her eyes, and stood with them and the loaded ferry and the leaving light.

She had out-read them at every depth and made it look like breathing. She knew the currents the way the crew knew the inside of their own

mouths — knew which fissure would suck and which would hold, knew slack to the minute, knew the silt before it lifted. On the second dive the ND lead had reached for an edge that looked, by every instinct, worked — a corner so square it ached — and Tanaka had touched their wrist and shaken her head and brought them six feet left to a face that looked rougher and was, to the fingers, the better candidate, a place where the rock had been *helped*, maybe, and even she would say no more than maybe. She read the stone home-court. They read it as guests. There was no shame in it. It was the order of the world set right.

“They’re gone tomorrow,” she said, of the survey. “Site closes Thursday. Research access only. Permits through Naha.” She watched the last container settle. “For a while there’ll be no one out there but the sharks and the report.”

“You fought it,” the recorder said.

“I lost it.” Tanaka shrugged, a small economical motion. “But losing the access and losing the question are not the same thing. They can lock the buoys. They can’t lock the *maybe*. That’s the part that was never theirs.” She looked at the ND lead. “Or yours. No offense.”

“None taken.”

“You wanted me to tell you,” Tanaka said, and now she was looking out at the water, not at any of them, “what it’s for. Your fixer kept circling it. Politely. He’s good — I’ll give him that, he never once asked straight.”

Jakobus inclined his head, an old man caught being himself.

“Here’s what I’ll give you.” She crouched, picked up the same broken chip Jakobus had, weighed it. “I don’t dive it to know what built it. I gave up that one years ago. I dive it because of what it *does*. Every kid on this island grows up knowing there’s a thing under the water nobody can explain. Not the scientists, not the believers, not the government with its boxes. A thing that two clever men with degrees looked at and saw two different worlds. And the island holds that. It’s ours to hold. The fishermen know the place. The old people tell it. The young ones argue it in the bar.” She stood. “It marks the edge of what we’re allowed to be sure of. That’s the function. It’s a boundary stone. It says: *here is where knowing stops, and you’re*

still standing, and the sea's still beautiful. You don't need to settle it to be its keeper. You need to *not* settle it. That's the job."

She handed the chip to the ND lead.

"Take that. It's just sandstone. Off the seawall, not the site, before you write something stupid. But it's the same stuff. Put it on a shelf. When somebody asks you what Yonaguni is, hold it up and tell them you held the real one with your bare hand at fifteen meters, in good light, with the best diver in the Ryukyus next to you, and you still don't know." Her eyes had something in them that wasn't quite a smile. "And then watch their face. That's the gift. Watch them want it open instead of shut. That's how you know they're worth telling."

The ND lead closed their hand around the chip. Worked or fractured. Made or not. The wiring went quiet, the way it had at fifteen meters, the not-knowing arriving like a tide and, for once, not pulling anything under.

The LENS had the camera up, late and slow, and for three weeks Tanaka had let it ride because she understood the trade. Now she put two fingers gently on the top of the lens and pressed it down, and the LENS let it go down, the eye closing, the green water going to memory instead of frame.

"You've got enough," Tanaka said. "More than enough. Some of it you don't shoot. Some of it you just stand in." It wasn't an order. The LENS lowered the camera the rest of the way themselves, and stood in it, and the harbor was just a harbor and the light was just light and that, it turned out, was the photograph that had been waiting the whole time.

The ferry took the crew the next morning, and the containers, and the seal of the ministry, and nine hundred careful pages of inconclusive waiting to be written. The buoys went up Thursday as promised. The site closed to all but permit and patience.

Out under the green, at fifteen meters, the Main Terrace ran true the way it had run true for as long as anyone had been there to lay a line along it, square-cornered and stepped and silent, crusted with the

small lives of the sea, holding to a straightness that nature does not owe and that no hand has been proven to give. The current came at slack and went again. The face Kimura named looked out at nothing. Schoch's bedding planes lay flat as tables, as they had lain since before the first human thought.

Nobody had closed it. That was the whole of what they'd done, and it was the right thing. They'd come to read the stone and the stone had read them back, and sent them home with a chip of sandstone and a question they couldn't crate.

The fish, last to board, looked back once at the flat lying sea.

"Twenty million years," he said, to no one, "and it still won't say."

Then the ferry pulled, and the harbor turned, and Yonaguni went down behind the swell with its door standing open, the way the best ones always do.

Chapter 20 — The Wink

Slack tide held the sea still for maybe forty minutes, and Saki used every one of them like she was spending someone else's money.

She went over the side first, the way she always did, no splash, no theatre, just a fold into the water that made the rest of them look like dropped luggage. The ND lead followed, then the Lens with the housing rig cradled against their chest like something that might wake. Below, the green-blue went down in steps, and the steps went down in steps, and somewhere in there the steps stopped being a word you used loosely and started being a thing you could put your gloved hand on.

The Main Terrace came up out of the murk the way it always did — not gradually, but all at once, the eye refusing it and then accepting it in a single ugly lurch. A hundred and fifty meters of flat. Forty wide. A plane laid into the seabed at a depth where planes had no business being.

The ND lead settled onto it and went very quiet inside, which was their version of loud.

Here's the thing they want you to say, the fish said, somewhere in the back of the skull where the fish lived. Say it. Go on. Say "this can't be natural." Everybody says it the first time. It's practically the admission fee.

The ND lead didn't say it. They'd learned not to, somewhere around dive nine. Instead they ran a flat palm along the terrace surface, feeling for the thing they'd come halfway around the planet to feel for — the rasp of a tool, the directional bite of something held in a human fist and dragged. Worked stone has a grammar. It tells you

which way the hand went.

The terrace told them nothing. It was smooth where the current had smoothed it, encrusted where the animals had decided to live, and flat with a flatness that sat in the chest like a held breath. No grammar. No hand. No nature shouting either. Just the flat, and the cold of it coming through neoprene, and the question.

Let's lay it out one more time, clean, because the site deserves clean.

The official story has two official stories, and that's the whole trouble.

On one side stands Masaaki Kimura, marine geologist out of the University of the Ryukyus, who has put more hours in this water than most people put into a marriage. Kimura reads a monument. He reads ceremonial platforms and a road and steps cut for feet, and he has drawn the maps and lit the dark and pointed his light at things he calls carvings and a thing he calls a face. He thinks Ryukyuan hands made this, back when the area last stood above the waterline — and the honest range on *that* runs anywhere from two thousand to ten thousand years ago, which is a window you could sail a fleet through. Kimura is not a crank. Kimura is a credentialed man pointing at right angles and asking the most reasonable question there is.

On the other side stands Robert Schoch, geologist out of Boston University, who dove the same stone and surfaced with the opposite verdict and the same calm. Schoch reads sandstone. Specifically he reads the Lower Miocene Yaeyama Group — medium-to-fine sandstone and mudstone, laid down in beds, and sandstone laid in beds *fractures in beds*, along the flat planes where it was deposited and down the vertical joints where the rock later cracked. Stack horizontal planes against vertical breaks and you get steps. You get terraces. You get corners that look cut because ninety degrees is just what you get when a horizontal plane meets a vertical one. Add earthquakes, which the Ryukyus have in profusion, and add a few thousand years of marine erosion, and Schoch says you don't need a single human hand. He points to formations on the islands *above* the water that do the same trick in the sun, for anyone with eyes.

Two credentials. Two careful men. One stone. No consensus.

That is the actual published state of play, and anyone who tells you it's settled is selling you the half they like.

So the crew did what the crew does. They tried to make one.

It had been four days earlier, in the shallows off the harbor, where the survey team's permits didn't reach and the sandstone came in slabs you could reach without going deep. Saki had picked the spot. The methodical one had laid out the tools — not power tools, nothing the bronze-age didn't have, just hard stone and harder stone and the muscle to drive one against the other. The brief was small and stupidly honest: make one step. Just one. Flat tread, square riser, the kind of clean line that the terrace below threw off by the dozen.

The dry wit had narrated the whole disaster from the surface like a sports anchor at a funeral.

The ND lead had gone at it for ninety minutes across two slack windows. The sandstone did not want to be a step. It wanted to be a mess. It crumbled where they wanted an edge and held stubborn where they wanted it to give, and the riser came out not square but slumped, a tired shoulder of rock, and the tread had a dish in it from where the pounding had bruised the grain. When they backed off and let the silt clear and looked at what they'd made, it sat there in the green light like exactly what it was.

"A potato," the dry wit said, blessedly, over the comms.

It was. Honest to the bone, it was a potato — lumpen, rounded, apologetic. Ninety minutes of human will and the best the species could manage was something the sea would have laughed off as a bad afternoon.

Which is the part nobody likes, because it cuts both ways and refuses to pick a team.

It cuts the believers, because if a hand makes a *potato*, then who made the terrace? Where's the rough draft, the bruised tread, the thousand failed attempts that real cutting leaves behind? Worked stone is a graveyard of mistakes. Where are Yonaguni's mistakes?

And it cuts the skeptics too, standing there in the silt over a potato, because the terrace below is *not* a potato. The terrace is flat the way intention is flat. And the sea, who is supposedly the architect here, who is supposedly so much better at this than any diver with a stone in his fist — the sea also makes a thousand mistakes, everywhere, all the time. The whole seabed is the sea's rough drafts. So why,

right *here*, in this one place, did the sea suddenly stop drafting and commit?

The potato doesn't answer. The potato just sits there being rounder than everything around it, and lets you carry the discomfort home in both pockets.

Now down on the terrace, in the last of the slack, the ND lead followed Saki to the edge.

This is the part the chapter has been walking toward, so walk it slow.

There is a step on the Main Terrace where the upper plane meets the lower, and Kimura photographed it, and Schoch explained it, and the survey team had it on a clipboard with a catalogue number, and none of that touched it. The ND lead put both hands along that edge and ran the length of it the way you'd run a hand along a held breath.

It was straight.

Not metaphor-straight. Not eye-fooled-by-green-light straight. The kind of straight where you keep waiting for it to be wrong — for the inch where it bellies out, the meter where it wanders, the crumble that gives the game away and lets you exhale and say *natural*, see, *there it goes*. The crumble didn't come. The line held, and held, and the ND lead's gift — the thing that reads worked from broken by touch, the thing that has never once lied to them on dry land — strained against it and came back with the worst possible answer.

Don't know.

Some of it felt fractured. Honestly, genuinely, joint-and-bedding fractured, the way Schoch says, the way the gift had confirmed a hundred times on a hundred lesser rocks. And some of it felt *too clean for that*, too committed, a line that fracture alone shouldn't have the nerve to hold this long. Worked and broken, in the same edge, under the same hand, refusing to separate.

That's the hole. Not aliens. Not a cabal. Just this: after decades, with two credentialed geologists and their cameras and their careers, nobody has put a single confirmed tool mark in the peer-reviewed record. And nobody has put another underwater formation of this size, this geometric, anywhere, that nature is *known* to have made alone. The split isn't sloppiness. The split is the honest shape of

what's actually known. The case is open because the case is open.

Saki hung in the water beside the ND lead and watched them run the edge, and she watched the way you watch someone reach the end of their own road.

She'd been out-reading them the whole trip and never once made it a victory. She knew the current that would lift the silt at the wrong moment. She knew which encrustation was a hundred years old and which was new growth softening a corner that had been sharper in Aratake's day, back in '86, when a local diver chasing hammerhead schools found the whole thing and changed the island's quiet life forever. She knew the stone the way the crew would never know it — not as a puzzle, but as a neighbor.

The ND lead turned to her, palms still flat on the impossible edge, and the question was right there behind the mask, the question the whole book had been holding: *made or not. You're home here. You know. Tell me.*

Saki looked at the line. Then she looked at the diver. Then she did something with one hand against the stone — a small flat press, the gesture of someone confirming a thing is real and choosing what to do about it.

She shook her head. Slow. Once.

Not *I don't know*. The crew had a lot of *I don't know* in their luggage and would have recognized it.

This was the other thing. *I'm not going to say.*

And she tipped her head toward the surface, because the slack was dying and you could feel the current beginning to want them, the patient enormous shoulder of the sea leaning in to take the stillness back. Forty minutes. Spent. The water was about to start moving and it didn't care whose question went unanswered.

Time, lovely, the fish murmured. *The sea's a survey team too, in the end. Documents everything. Archives it under "tide."*

The Lens hadn't taken the shot.

That was the other quiet thing, down there in the green. The Lens had the housing up, framed on the meeting of the ND lead's hands and the

long straight edge running off into the murk — the cover shot, the one that sells the book, the human animal touching the impossible thing. The Lens had it framed and lit and held, and for a long moment that cost something, the Lens just looked at it through the glass without pressing.

Because a photograph closes a thing. A photograph says *here is the answer, I caught it*. And there wasn't one to catch. There was only the edge, and the not-knowing, and a woman who'd earned the right to withhold, withholding.

The Lens lowered the camera. Let it hang. Looked at the edge with their own two eyes for once, the way you look at a thing you're agreeing not to own.

Then they all went up, because the sea said so.

So here's where we leave you, and we're going to leave you honestly, which means we're going to leave you holding it.

Is it a monument? A drowned platform where Ryukyuan feet once climbed toward something, before the water came and folded the whole intention under twenty-five meters of green? Kimura would walk you up those steps and you'd half believe him, because the steps are *there*, and feet are exactly the right size for them.

Or is it a masterpiece of geology — the Yaeyama sandstone doing what sandstone does, splitting along its beds and its joints with the dumb luck of ten thousand years and a few good earthquakes, building a thing so clean that human eyes can't help but read a builder into it? Schoch would walk you up to the formation on the dry island next door and show you the same right angles in the sun, and you'd half believe *him*, because there they are, made by nobody, square as a churchgoer.

Both half-believings are correct, which is the whole maddening point. The case stays split right down the credentialed middle, and we are not the ones to close it, and neither, it turns out, is anybody else.

We can tell you what it felt like under the hand: worked and broken at once, an edge that wouldn't choose.

We can tell you the potato sits in the harbor shallows still, rounded and honest, and that ninety minutes of human will couldn't out-cut

the sea, and that the sea, everywhere else, can't out-flat itself the way it did here.

We can tell you a local diver pressed her palm to that straight line, knew something we didn't, and decided the maybe was hers to keep.

What we won't tell you is which one it is. Not because we're coy. Because the truthful answer is a closed door we don't have the key to, and the people who do have the key know better than to use it.

So stand where we stood. Right hand flat on the lower tread, left hand reaching up into the murk for the edge of the next step, the green going dark above and darker below, the slack tide thinning under you by the second.

Now: is the step under your palm a thing that meant to be a step?

The current's coming back. You've got about a minute to decide. We had the same minute, and we surfaced without an answer, and the water closed over the question the way it's closed over it for ten thousand years, give or take a fleet.

Reach up. Feel for the edge.

Tell us it's only stone.

Chapter 21 — The Ledger: Real, Debated, Invented

The notebook came back salt-stained and swollen, its spiral spine flecked with rust, and the recorder set it on the galley table of the dive boat like a thing recovered from a wreck. Which, in a sense, it was.

“Last entry’s smudged,” she said. “Some of it’s the sea. Some of it’s me.”

Outside, the survey team’s pontoon sat low against the morning, antennas catching the first light, a generator humming its patient bureaucratic note across the water. They’d be down by slack tide, locking buoys to the terraces, running their official transect with their official numbers, and the numbers would be good. That was the thing nobody wanted to say about the National Maritime Survey Unit. Their numbers would be *excellent*. They would measure everything and explain nothing, and the explaining-nothing would read, on paper, like a closed file.

So the recorder did what she always did when a place was about to be taken: she made the ledger.

Not the pretty version. The honest one. Three columns. What we *know*. What we *argue*. What we *made up to make the telling easier*. Because the difference between those three is the only thing an outsider owes a place that isn’t theirs.

She uncapped the pen.

REAL. Column one. The cold floor.

She wrote the location first, because location is the one thing the sea can't argue with. *Off the southern coast of Yonaguni, western-most of the inhabited Ryukyus, Japan. Five to twenty-five meters down.* Aratake found it in 1986 — Kihachiro Aratake, local diver, looking for hammerhead schools, finding instead the edge of the Main Terrace coming up out of the green like the corner of something that shouldn't have a corner. She underlined his name. He gets his name. The man who saw it first always gets his name.

The stone next. *Sandstone and mudstone, medium to fine grain, Lower Miocene, the Yaeyama Group.* The ND lead leaned over the page and put a finger on the word *Miocene* without quite touching it, the way they did with edges they trusted.

"Twenty million years for the rock," they said. "Two to ten thousand for the question."

"Say it slower."

"The rock is twenty million years old. Nobody fights that. But you can't carve a thing that's underwater. So if hands touched it, hands touched it the last time this ground was *dry* — and the dry window's somewhere between two thousand and ten thousand years back." They sat back. "That gap is where the whole book lives."

The recorder wrote both numbers. *~20 million (rock). 2,000-10,000 (last subaerial exposure, estimated).* She did not write which one mattered, because both did, and that was the point.

Then the geometry, because the geometry is real even if its maker isn't. *Main Terrace: ~150 meters long, ~40 wide. Flat platforms. Broad straight steps. Right-angled corners. A Trench — some call it the Road — running parallel.* All of it measurable. All of it there. You could put a tape on it. The survey team would put a tape on it this very afternoon and the tape would not lie and the tape would not help.

She paused at the next line and made the LENS read it before she wrote it, because he'd been down there with the macro housing for three days and his eyes had gone strange.

"Tool marks," she said.

“No confirmed ones,” he said. He didn’t look up from the viewfinder he wasn’t using. “Nothing peer-reviewed. Nothing the field will sign. I shot every surface that looked worked. They all looked worked. None of them *proved* worked.” He set the camera down — set it *down*, which from him was a sentence with weight on it. “I have four hundred images of maybe.”

The recorder wrote: *TOOL MARKS: none confirmed or universally accepted in peer-reviewed literature.* She let the period sit there, hard.

Last in column one, the part the believers hate and the part that’s true anyway. *Ryukyu prehistory is long. No known culture in it had the engineering capacity or recorded motive to build at this scale, by mainstream archaeology’s count.* And under it, the marine life, the great encrusting blur of it — coral, algae, the soft green fur over every angle — that turns every honest investigation into an argument about what’s under the growth, and the growth never lets you finish the sentence.

That’s REAL, she said, capping the pen for a moment. *Every line of it you can check. Go check it.*

From the doorway, where the dry wit was making coffee with the resentment of a man whose island was about to be measured by strangers, came the verdict.

“So the receipts say it’s a hundred-and-fifty meters of *we-don’t-know*.”

“The receipts say it’s a hundred-and-fifty meters.”

“Same length either way,” he said, and handed Saki a cup.

Dr. Saki Tanaka took the coffee, took the notebook, and read column one without comment. She read it the way she read the seabed — fast where it was solid, slow where it lied. She was the only one on the boat who’d dived this site for twenty years and the only one who’d lose something real when the buoys went down, and the crew had learned by now to let her finish before anyone breathed near a conclusion.

She handed it back.

“Your facts are clean,” she said. “Now do the hard column.”

DEBATED. Column two. Where the two grown-ups disagree and neither one is a crank.

The recorder wrote *KIMURA* and gave him room. *Masaaki Kimura, marine geologist, University of the Ryukyus. Reads the monument as man-made — a platform, a temple, possibly a city. Cites the stairs, the terraces, what he interprets as carvings and inscriptions. Published site maps. Published underwater photographs.* She wrote the next part carefully, because fairness is a craft. *His reading is not accepted by the majority of geologists or archaeologists.*

A space. Then the other name.

SCHOCH. Robert Schoch, Boston University. Reads natural fracture — sandstone splitting along bedding planes and vertical joints, helped by earthquake and erosion. Points to similar shapes on nearby islands, above water, where no one was carving anything. Points to the absent tool marks.

She drew a line between them. Then she stopped, because a line implies a winner.

She erased the line.

“Two credentials,” the ND lead said quietly. “Two readings. Same stone.”

“Same stone,” Saki said. She was looking out the porthole at the survey pontoon now, at the orderly men in orderly vests. “Kimura sees the work of hands. Schoch sees the work of the joint set. And here is the thing nobody on land understands.” She turned. “They are *both careful men*. That is what’s unbearable about it. If one of them were a fool, you could close the file. Neither is a fool.”

The dry wit leaned in the hatch. “So the official story is that there *is* no official story.”

“The official story,” Saki said, “is a split. Down the middle. In the literature. Unresolved.” She let that land. “Write that exactly.”

The recorder wrote it exactly. *SPLIT: no consensus among credentialed geologists. The “made or not” question is genuinely unre-*

solved in the published record.

Under it she put the disputed sub-claims, each tagged with the only word that mattered — *claimed*. Tool marks and inscriptions reported by Kimura and some divers, *claimed, not independently verified*. Cultural connections to Okinawan folklore and old Ryukyuan custom, *claimed, speculative, not recognized by mainstream historians*. She tagged her own crew, too, while she was at it: their failed replication, the day they'd taken chisels to a slab of local sandstone in the shallows and tried to make one clean right angle by hand and produced — every time — a *potato*. Rough. Wandering. Ashamed of itself next to the terrace edge twenty meters down. *Replication attempt: inconclusive. The sea, in our test, made a straighter line than we did.*

"You should be careful with that one," Saki said, reading over her shoulder. "It cuts both ways."

"I know."

"It means we couldn't carve it cleanly. It does *not* mean nobody could. Or that the joint did." She tapped the word *potato* with one short nail. "It means our hands are bad. Write *that*."

The recorder added: *Our failure proves only our failure.*

The fish — the dry wit's running commentary that nobody had asked for and everybody waited on — surfaced from the galley.

"Column two could just be one word," he called. "*Maybe*. Save the ink."

"Column two is the most expensive column in the book," the recorder said. "It cost two careers and forty years."

He went quiet. Even he knew when a line had landed.

THE HOLE. Which lived, technically, inside column two, but the recorder gave it its own box and drew the box twice, because it was the thing the whole chase had been for.

She wrote it as a question with two faces, the way Saki had taught her to, so it couldn't be hijacked by either side.

FACE ONE: After decades of investigation, no one has produced a

single definitive, accepted human tool mark or cultural layer. Not one. The believers have not closed it.

FACE TWO: Nor has anyone shown another underwater formation of this *size*, this *geometric*, made *purely* by nature. The skeptics have not closed it either.

She sat back and looked at the box. It was the cleanest thing she'd ever written and it explained nothing and that was its whole virtue.

"That's the hole," the ND lead said. They had their fingers flat on the table, reading the wood grain out of habit, and the recorder knew that the ambiguity hadn't healed in them and never would. That was the deal. That was the gift — to feel *worked* and *fractured* in the same surface and report both, honestly, instead of choosing the one that felt better. "Both sides have a thing the other side can't make go away."

"And the survey team," Saki said, "is going to measure the whole site this afternoon and find exactly that. And report it as *characterized*." The word came out of her like a stone she didn't want in her mouth. "As if measuring a thing is the same as understanding it."

"It isn't," the LENS said.

"No," she agreed. "It is the opposite, usually."

INVENTED. Column three. The honest confession.

The recorder wrote the heading and then wrote, beneath it, the truth nobody else in this whole racket bothered to write: *Some of what you just read, we made up to make the telling go down easier.*

The boat. There was no specific named boat in the record; the dive vessel of these pages was a composite, rigged from a dozen real characters out of Yonaguni harbor. *Invented: the boat.* The galley, the rust on the spiral binding, the coffee made with resentment. *Invented: the weather of any given morning.* The exact words in anyone's mouth — Saki's, the crew's, the survey lead's polite stonewall. *Invented: the dialogue.* The arguments were real; the sentences were ours.

The survey team's *intent* — the way the book had let them read as quietly acquisitive, polite men coming to close a legend — *that was*

*a frame the crew put on a real bureaucratic process, and she flagged it as such, because the doctrine was clear: the adversary is human-scale, fallible, never an omnipotent cabal, and a frame is a frame even when it feels true. **Invented: their motives, as dramatized. Real: that sites get documented, archived, and access-managed by funded surveys, everywhere, all the time.***

She did not put Aratake in column three. She did not put the depths, the rock, the Main Terrace's dimensions, the tool-mark vacuum, the Kimura-Schoch split. Those were column one and column two and they would survive any reader who went and checked, which was the entire point of writing the ledger at all.

"That's the part they'll skip," the dry wit said, nodding at column three. "Readers always skip the part where you tell them what you faked."

"Then they'll be reading a different book than the one we wrote," the recorder said. "Ours has three columns. The legend only ever has one."

She turned the notebook around so it faced the crew, the gazetteer page she'd been keeping in the back. The rabbit holes. Where to go if you didn't believe a word of this and wanted to find your own maybe.

Go read Kimura's site maps yourself. They exist. Go read Schoch's natural-fracture argument and his photographs of the dry formations on the neighboring islands. They exist. Go look up the Yaeyama Group and learn how sandstone splits along bedding and joint, and then go look at the Main Terrace and decide whether you've ever seen a joint do that. Go find the date range for the last time this ground was dry and sit with the gap. Go dive it, with a local who knows the slack tide, who will out-read you on every current and every edge and who has earned the right to tell you nothing.

"That last one's the real invitation," the ND lead said.

"That last one's the only one that matters," Saki said.

Out on the water, the survey team's first diver went over the side. The splash was small and final. Within the hour they'd have buoys on

the terraces and a transect line running the length of the thing, and the green light down there would be full of orderly men making the site *legible* — and the legible site would, on every official form, read *natural formation, no confirmed anthropogenic modification*, which is true, and *characterized*, which is a lie, and *closed*, which is the lie that does the damage.

Jakobus came up the companionway then, the way he did — never the lead, never the last word, just the road that had brought them here. He looked at the three columns once. He looked longest at the box drawn twice. Then he did the thing he always did at the end, which was to hand it back.

“What’s it for,” he said. Not to the page. To Saki.

And Saki — who owned the currents, who owned the stone, who had dived this monument before any of them could find it on a chart — took the notebook, and the question, and held them both for a moment over the table.

“I’ll tell you what I tell the divers,” she said. “On the surface, it’s the corner where the hammerheads run. Underwater, it’s the edge of the thing the sea can’t explain and we can’t either. You stand at the bottom of the last step and the water carries the question up through you.” She closed the notebook. “It’s for *that*. For having a place where the not-knowing is allowed to be the answer.”

She set the ledger down in front of the reader, and went up to watch them measure what they could not close.

The pen was still on the table. Three columns. Go check them.

The last step is right there. The water’s doing the asking.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor